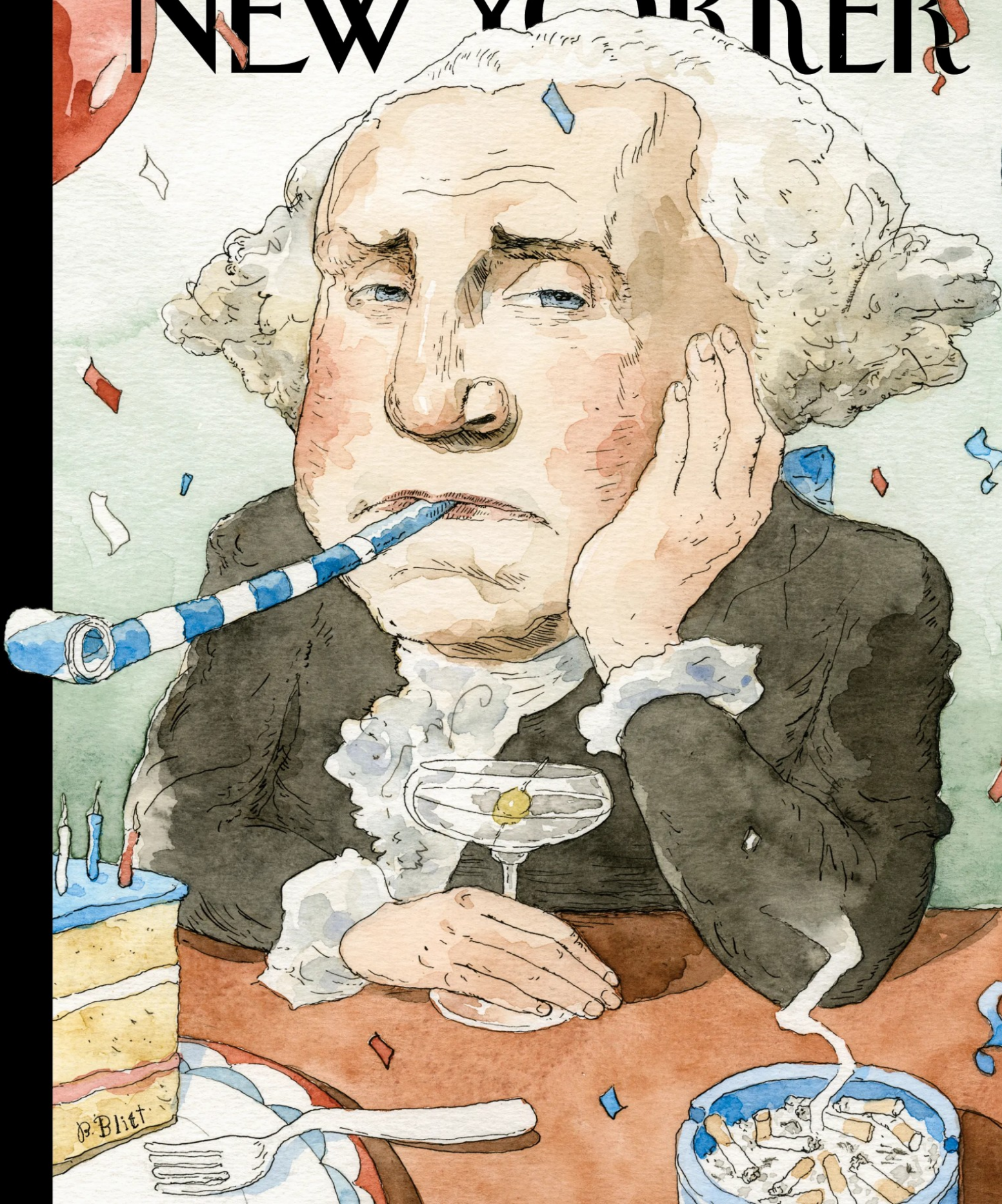


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- **Goings On**
- **The Talk of the Town**
- **Reporting & Essays**
- **Shouts & Murmurs**
- **Fiction**
- **The Critics**
- **Poems**
- **Cartoons**
- **Puzzles & Games**
- **The Mail**

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Goings On

- [“Heated Rivalry” and Its Wine-Mom Fans Reunite](#)
- [Rachel Syme Gets Suited Up](#)

Goings On

“Heated Rivalry” and Its Wine-Mom Fans Reunite

Plus: the radiant pop of MUNA, the visceral paintings of Juanita McNeely, a “Beaches” musical, and more.

By Dan Stahl, Sheldon Pearce, Jane Bua, Jillian Steinhauer, Richard Brody, Marina Harss, Taran Dugal

May 01, 2026

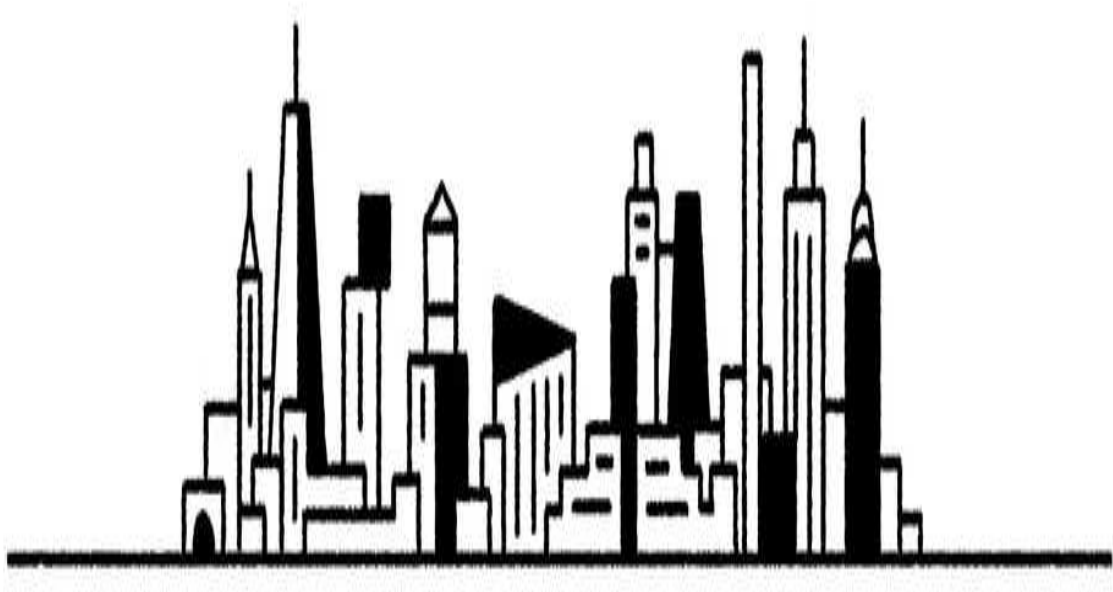


What’s the only thing that could make “Heated Rivalry” gayer? That’s right: turning it into a musical. Doing the honors is Dylan MarcAurele, a composer, writer, and parodist extraordinaire, whose previous projects include spoofs of the “Real Housewives” franchise and of the 2022 horror movie “M3gan.” His latest undertaking is **“Heated Rivalry: The Unauthorized Musical Parody,”** which begins previews on May 12, for an eight-week run at [the Club](#), near Hudson Yards.



As anyone on social media probably knows by now, “Heated Rivalry” is a sex-forward TV show about closeted hockey players. Its first season, based on the “Game Changers” series by Rachel Reid, was released last November and was promoted with steamy clips that quickly blanketed Instagram and TikTok. The show focusses on two young N.H.L. stars playing for different teams: Shane Hollander, an aw-shucks Canadian, and Ilya Rozanov, a standoffish Russian. They gradually progress from furtive hotel-room hookups, when their game schedules intersect, to emotional intimacy and self-acceptance.

The series has attracted attention for, among other things, the size of Ilya’s ass, which, in MarcAurele’s adaptation, is its own character. Filling out the role of Ilya is Jay Armstrong Johnson; Jimin Moon plays Shane; Ryann Redmond plays a wine-mom narrator who lives for their clandestine love. (Women constitute a sizable chunk of the series’ fans; a childhood friend who is now a mother of two persuaded me to keep watching the TV show when I’d given up, after Episode 3.) Audiences can expect such penetrating songs as “This Fuck Was Different” and “A Heavy Load,” plus, as in the TV show, a character whose only line is “Girl!” The production is directed by Alan Kliffer, whose qualifications include twenty years’ experience writing and directing comedy, and a lifetime of being Canadian.—*Dan Stahl*



About Town

Indie Pop

Phoebe Bridgers has done indie music a great many favors, but one of the most significant is rescuing the Los Angeles trio **MUNA** from major-label purgatory. The group, originally signed to RCA Records, released two albums of bustling synth pop and opened for Harry Styles in the late twenty-tens but was cast off in the early days of the pandemic owing to low sales. The Bridgers-founded label, Saddest Factory Records, stepped in, and, in 2022, MUNA reintroduced itself with an opalescent self-titled LP that made its already infectious grooves feel enriched. The songs were radiant, ecstatic, and cleansing, a deep exhale from a band freed from boardroom expectations. This May, the trio returns with another glowing album, “Dancing on the Wall,” reaffirming its commitment to the alternate path.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([*Music Hall of Williamsburg*](#); May 16-19.)

Classical

Grappling with questions of the human condition with no expectation of an answer is an inevitability of life. The Brooklyn Art Song Society is tackling this conundrum in its ongoing **New Voices Festival**, this year titled “Longing,” focussing on themes of morality and compassion. The next installment of the series includes Missy Mazzoli’s “Self-Portrait with Dishevelled Hair,” after Rembrandt’s vulnerable and revealing early work of the same name; a new commission, Lembit Beecher’s “After the Fires,” about how natural disasters are both environmental tragedies and profoundly personal ones; and Huang Ruo’s “The Work of Angels,” which examines the devastating—and all too relevant—history of immigrants held in detention on Angel Island, in San Francisco Bay, in the early nineteen-hundreds.—*Jane Bua* ([Roulette](#); May 10.)

Art



Whoever titled the exhibition “Holding Back” must have a morbid sense of humor, because the paintings of **Juanita McNeely** (1936-2023) are anything but restrained. In the artist’s frenzied canvases, humans and animals—and hybrids of the two—crawl, climb, splay, and stretch; here, in a set of pieces created between 1985 and 2010, they do so in vertiginous spaces marked by refractive windows and water. The dominant color is a sickly blue, tinged

with greens and purples. McNeely devised a remarkably visceral blend of German Expressionism, Surrealism, and feminism. In “Pre-Abortion Law Remembrance” (1985), inspired by her own experiences, a faceless figure connects a naked, bleeding woman to a contraption with meat hooks, while a ghoul and a monkey look on. These works are so much more than images or symbols—they’re psychic explosions.—*Jillian Steinhauer* ([James Fuentes](#); *through May 16.*)

Broadway

First a [novel](#), by Iris Rainer Dart, and then a tearjerker film, starring Bette Midler, “**Beaches**” has become a musical by Dart (lyrics and book), Thom Thomas (book), and Mike Stoller (music). This version also makes you want to cry, but for different reasons. Although the basic plot remains—an adolescent friendship between the tough-talking, stardom-chasing Cee Cee (Midler’s role, played here by Jessica Vosk, who holds her own) and the wealthy Wasp Bertie (Kelli Barrett) becomes a lifelong bond—the pair’s odd-couple charm gets sanded down with schmaltzy songs and tacky groaners. (Of a Carmen Miranda-style hat, Cee Cee remarks, “It’s got more fruit than the audience at a Judy Garland concert.”) Lonny Price and Matt Cowart direct this loud, listless production.—*Dan Stahl* ([Majestic](#); *through Sept. 6.*)

Movies

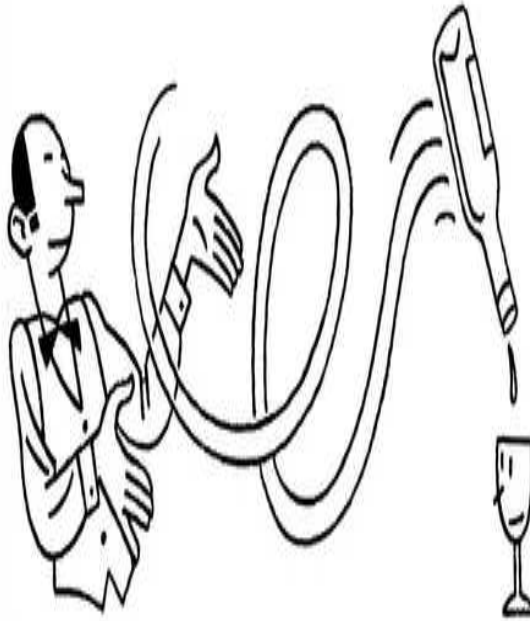


Yasujiro Ozu, who made dozens of masterworks from the nineteen-thirties through the early sixties, is among the most misunderstood of great directors. Daniel Raim's documentary "**The Ozu Diaries**," which brings together clips from many of Ozu's great films with voice-over readings of Ozu's diaries and interviews, helps to clarify his achievements. Often considered a formalist, Ozu describes practices, exemplified onscreen, that foreground spontaneous emotion and document the times. No mere chronicler of intimate conflicts, he's revealed—as in his anguished personal and cinematic responses to his military service in the Second World War—to be a caustic social critic. Raim also offers a fascinating history of the Japanese film industry and insightful sidebars from Ozu's associates and from such current filmmakers as Kiyoshi Kurosawa and Tsai Ming-liang.—*Richard Brody (TCM; May 5.)*

Ballet

Like the graduation performances held at the School of American Ballet in June, this weeklong run by American Ballet Theatre's junior troupe **ABT Studio Company** is a place to catch a glimpse of some of the city's most promising ballet dancers in the moment before they step across the threshold into their professional lives. Every year, the level of talent and sheer ability

seems more outrageous. The dancers, aged generally seventeen to twenty-one, take on not only the usual classic showpieces—such as the veiled pas de deux from the nineteenth-century exotic fantasy “La Bayadère”—but also recent works by contemporary choreographers including Twyla Tharp, Kyle Abraham, and Christopher Wheeldon. There’s also a dance by Brady Farrar, a graduate of the Studio Company who is now in the corps at A.B.T.—*Marina Harss* ([Joyce Theatre](#); May 13-17.)



Bar Tab

Taran Dugal snacks at one of the best new bars in the country.



In the seventies, the East Village was the punk capital of the world, and it had the grit to match. Nowadays, old-school residents bemoan the neighborhood's evolution from grungy to grandiose; what was once a warren of hedonism has become a breeding ground for characterless watering holes whose lack of personality is bested only by the exorbitance of their beer prices. Such displeased denizens might appreciate **Bar Snack**, a cocktail lounge that was recently named one of the country's best new bars. Wood-panelled, warmly lit, and dotted with mid-century seating and vintage novelty signs, the place has a distinctly low-key (if not quite punk) air. On a recent week night, two newcomers stopped by early and ordered a pair of the Split Ends—a whiskey sour imbued with raspberry amaro and topped with Guinness foam. They followed those up with the Spice Bag, a delectable jumble of chicken tenders, fries, onions, and red peppers, accompanied by a tangy curry sauce. As sunset approached and the shadows outside the bar's pink-tinselled windows grew longer, a steady stream of customers settled in; here was a double date, then a bachelorette party, now a group celebrating a birthday, extinguishing candles and distributing cake. The guests, influenced by a secondhand spirit of festivity, ordered a round of Melonades, a refreshing, bittersweet concoction of vodka, lemon, and cantaloupe, topped with a heap of crushed ice. Just as "Rich Girl" by Daryl Hall & John Oates began playing, their bill arrived. Unable to rely on the old man's money, the

pair assessed the damage—a far cry from the nineteen-seventies, though they’d certainly seen worse—and departed for the dimming streets.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [*Make your mark with the land*](#)
- [*Bob Odenkirk gets it*](#)
- [*A Petra Collins playlist*](#)

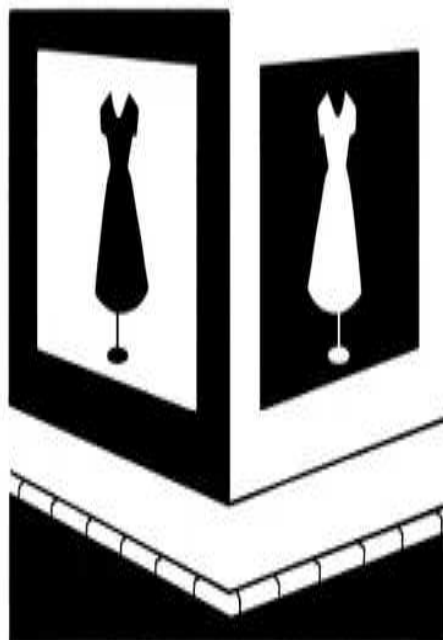
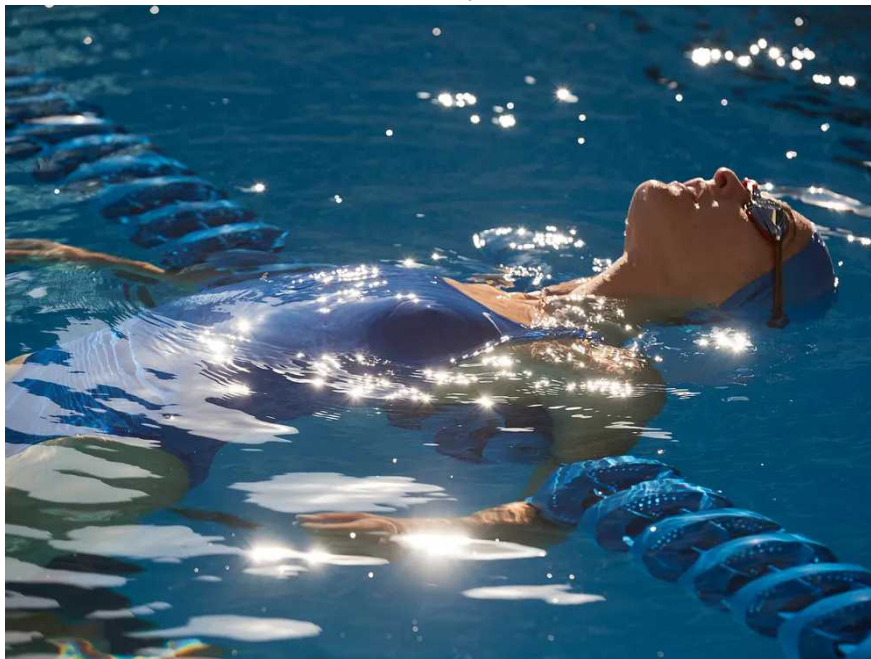
Goings On

Rachel Syme Gets Suited Up

Also: Jessica Winter's mom-themed movie picks

By Rachel Syme, Jessica Winter

May 08, 2026



On and Off the Avenue



I live directly across the street from a remarkably well-appointed, lusciously air-conditioned, and shockingly affordable (for New York City, anyway) Y.M.C.A. in Brooklyn, which is all to say: I have absolutely no excuse not to go. The gym is practically an extension of my apartment—so close that when I open my kitchen window, I can feel the chilled, tangy air wafting out of the Y’s linoleum lobby. The window next to my desk overlooks the gym’s large communal exercise room, and throughout the day, I am taunted by the sight of gyrating bodies panting through a Zumba class or a kettlebell set. I tried, for years, to motivate myself to join in, but I could never maintain a consistent cardio groove. Then, one afternoon last summer, I was walking past the gym when I was hit with a sudden nostalgia-inducing whiff of chlorine. The pool! Why had I never thought of it? I’d assumed the Y’s basement lido was the domain of serious lappers and diehard aquarobics addicts—not the place for a fitness dilettante. But my curiosity proved stronger than my nay-saying. I signed up for an hour-long swimming refresher course (from the coach Dan Daly, of [TrainDaly](#), who holds sessions at the John Jay pool, in midtown, and who has a warm if no-nonsense approach to instruction) and hopped into the slow lane. Now, I swim at least four days a week. My new hobby came, thrillingly, with the need to buy new gear. At first, I struggled. My two favorite one-pieces, a

vintage-inspired bottle-green ruched suit from the [Esther Williams line](#) (\$88), and a crinkly, scoop-backed number from [Hunza G](#) (\$240), were made more for lounging than for working out, but I find most “athletic swimsuits” to be so dowdy as to feel punitive. I spent a few unhappy weeks wriggling into a sad navy Speedo, until I spotted a woman in the locker room wearing a bright-red training suit, printed all over with whimsical watermelon seeds. She was kind enough to share that it was by [Sporti](#), and that she’d bought it for less than forty bucks at [SwimOutlet.com](#), which has since become my go-to source for kooky novelty sports suits. I also splurged on a hot-pink one-piece from **Left on Friday**, which has become the cool swimwear brand du jour for a reason; the [Sunday Suit](#) (\$200), as their best-selling, strappy style is known, is made of compressive fabric that holds up to exertion but also accentuates one’s curves. But the best purchase I’ve made by far, in my new life as a water nymph, is a pair of [Suunto Aqua Lights](#) (\$149), magical headphones that work underwater via cheekbone vibration. I used to avoid crossing the street. Now I happily dive in.—*Rachel Syme*

What to Watch

Just in time for Mother’s Day, Jessica Winter shares some of her favorite movies featuring complicated moms.



“The Reckless Moment” (1949)

After her rebellious daughter is implicated in a suspected homicide, Lucia Harper (Joan Bennett) must clean up the literal and figurative mess. She brings a grim determination to her matriarchal duties, whether she’s ordering this year’s Christmas tree, disposing of a corpse, or negotiating with the Irish bagman (a delightfully miscast James Mason) who tries to blackmail her and inevitably falls in love. [Max Ophüls’s](#) gorgeous SoCal melodrama is as brisk and economical as its heroine, and mordantly attentive to Lucia’s exhaustion and cognitive overload: “You don’t know,” she tells Mason’s character, “how a family can surround you at times.” Some of us know!

“Imitation of Life” (1959)

Like Ophüls, [Douglas Sirk](#) left his native Germany after the Nazis rose to power; the last film he made in Hollywood, before he returned to Europe, was “Imitation of Life.” Ostensibly, it’s a soapy tearjerker about two idealized single mothers, one a white actress (Lana Turner), the other her Black housekeeper and nanny (Juanita Moore), whose daughter passes for white. It’s also an extraordinary and enraged statement on race, class, identity, performance, bourgeois hypocrisy, and how a nation raises its children to hate themselves and those who love them most. The emotionally

overwhelming finale, in which a bereaved young woman confesses to her society's crimes as if they were hers alone, is the cinematic equivalent of Sirk taking a match and lighting his adopted country on fire. He never directed a feature again.

“News from Home” (1976)

Like much of [Chantal Akerman's](#) work, this epistolary cine-essay is not as simple or austere as it might first appear. In voice-over, the filmmaker reads aloud from plaintive letters she writes to her mother back home in Brussels, accompanied by long takes of unglamorous and underpopulated patches of nineteen-seventies Manhattan: parking lots, tenement exteriors, graffiti-covered subway cars. The juxtapositions of text and image, which strongly suggest the widening distance between mother and daughter, build in emotional and intellectual power over the film's ninety-minute duration. This is a uniquely lonely work of art, but one that maintains faith in the possibility of connection.

“The Brood” (1979)

Long before the trope of early motherhood as a horror movie became a cinematic cliché, the young director [David Cronenberg](#) blessed us with a gloriously disgusting movie about a woman (Samantha Eggar) whose past traumas become flesh—she literally gives birth to her suppressed rage in the form of hideous, murderous monster children. Lots of them! “The Brood” itself might be seen as a past trauma made flesh, as Cronenberg has said that the story was influenced by his own contentious divorce and custody battle. But the filmmaker's imagination transfigures personal history into something not of this world, wholly original, and uniquely demented.

“[Petite Maman](#)” (2021)

In [Céline Sciamma's](#) (slightly slept-on) follow-up to “[Portrait of a Lady on Fire](#),” a young girl named Nelly meets her doppelgänger, who turns out to be Nelly's mother as a child. (The girls are played by the twins Joséphine and Gabrielle Sanz.) In different hands, this setup might produce gimmicky results, but Sciamma regards this meeting of child and mother-child as an opportunity to simply be with these lovely girls as they play, pretend, and

discover each other and themselves. It's a movie that creates the most enchanting vertigo: How can something be at once so familiar, so comfortable, and yet so uncanny?

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [*Make your mark with the land*](#)
- [*City of orange*](#)
- [*Sharon Stone, party girl*](#)

An earlier version of this article included an incorrect photo for the film "Imitation of Life."

The Talk of the Town

- [Two Hundred and Fifty Years of Complicated Commemorations](#)
- [Colbert's Trumpet Player on Life After Late Night](#)
- [Is the Twenty-fifth Amendment *Really* an Option?](#)
- [On the High Line, Buddha Is the New Giant Pigeon](#)
- [In HBO's "The Dark Wizard," Dean Potter Climbs On](#)

Comment

Two Hundred and Fifty Years of Complicated Commemorations

Donald Trump's aversion to admitting fault suggests that we will not likely see events that grapple with the nuanced nature of the nation's history this July 4th.

By Jelani Cobb

May 04, 2026



Commemorations often tell us as much about the times in which they are being held as they do about the events they are commemorating. The two-hundred-and-fiftieth anniversary of the adoption of the [Declaration of Independence](#), this July 4th, falls at a moment when the nation is being led by a twice-impeached President amid a widely recognized crisis of democracy—last Wednesday, the Supreme Court's ruling in *Louisiana v. Callais* further weakened an already enfeebled [Voting Rights Act](#)—and in a social climate whose volatility might be measured by acts of political violence. The most dramatic recent example came with the frantic apprehension of an armed man in the hotel where the White House

Correspondents' Association dinner was being held. The alleged gunman fortunately did not reach the ballroom where the President and the other attendees were gathered, but he has been charged with an assassination attempt—the third made against Donald Trump in two years. This is the backdrop against which our recollections of the nation's origins are taking place.

Commemoration has been a complicated undertaking in this country from the start. On July 4, 1826, President John Quincy Adams decided to forgo making a major speech and instead rode by carriage in a parade to the Capitol, where he listened to celebratory remarks and a reading of the Declaration. He would later find out that two of his predecessors—his father, John Adams, and Thomas Jefferson—had died that day. Once fierce rivals, the two men were responsible for the country's first peaceful transfer of power between parties, after Jefferson and his Democratic-Republican Party defeated Adams and the Federalists in the election of 1800.

The nation's centennial, in 1876, arrived in the wake of a civil war that had left some seven hundred thousand Americans dead. The Declaration's insurrectionist contention—that people, when unjustly provoked, have the right to dissolve their government—hung heavily in a country that had just witnessed the eleven states of the Confederacy make the same argument. That year, President Ulysses S. Grant, who had commanded the Union forces, spoke in his annual address to Congress of the great economic and social progress that the United States had made during its first hundred years. But, though the guns of war were a decade in the past, the nation had not escaped the spectre of conflict. The Presidential election of 1876 pitted the Democrat Samuel J. Tilden against the Republican Rutherford B. Hayes, but disputed returns from Florida, Louisiana, and South Carolina, where there had been violence directed at Black voters, cast the results into doubt. With neither candidate gaining a clear majority in the Electoral College, the election was turned over to a special commission, which declared Hayes the winner. A compromise was then struck, insuring that Hayes could take office in exchange for the Republicans' promising to cease the federal occupation of the former Confederate states—thereby ending the period known as Reconstruction. Grant was compelled to celebrate the nation's hundredth anniversary just as its boldest experiment in democracy to date was being dismantled.

The nation's bicentennial, the only major commemoration in living memory, was framed by the exigencies of the Cold War and by the scarcely healed scars of the Vietnam War, as well as by Watergate and President Richard Nixon's consequent resignation. President Gerald Ford's Fourth of July address hit the boilerplate notes of progress and enduring values in a speech so anodyne that his audience might have overlooked the fact that the national festivities were being led by a man who had been elected to neither the Vice-Presidency (Nixon appointed him, in 1973) nor the Presidency (he assumed that office when Nixon resigned). The cumulative lesson of all this recollection is that, in commemorating the past, we may not like all that it calls attention to in the present.

There are other contexts worth considering at this moment. The semiquincentennial inherently underscores the comparative youth of the United States; Italy, Greece, China, and India count their historic legacies in millennia, not centuries. At the same time, the past two hundred and fifty years of popular self-government represent a global milestone: the Declaration of Independence marks the birth of the world's oldest constitutional democracy. Those divergent truths point to the sober reality that the vast majority of people who have existed on this planet lived under some form of tyranny. The events of July 4, 1776, signalled a partial departure from a miserably well-worn path in human history. In that light, two hundred and fifty years seems like a very long time.

The meaning of the Declaration was not entirely clear at the outset, even to those who wrote or signed it. With the haphazard spelling of the era, the signers refer to themselves in the final paragraph of the document as "Representatives of the united States." The use of the lowercase with the word "united" suggests that it is serving as an adjective, not as a herald of the new nation's name. (A subsequent line refers to the confederation as "United Colonies"—there were still things to be ironed out.) Notably, it was not until after the end of the Civil War that American grammar reliably described the United States in the singular: "the United States is" rather than "the United States are." Other editorial decisions in the founding document were less ambiguous. Jefferson's first draft contained a hundred-and-sixty-eight-word denunciation of the transatlantic slave trade, which was excised from the final text. A seed of conflict was sown in that moment.

Donald Trump's personal aversion to admitting fault suggests that we will not likely see commemorations that grapple with the nuanced, complicated nature of the country's founding and subsequent history this Fourth of July. What is more likely is that, fifty years hence, Americans will observe that this anniversary took place during a polarizing time, but that such circumstances were not unprecedented. One version of the nation's history anchors itself in the efforts to navigate those tempests, to better the imperfect tools bequeathed to us by imperfect men. This more mature approach to our past recognizes that national greatness does not exist without a simultaneous reckoning with national failure—and that this undertaking, rather than diminishing American standing, is the surest path toward a country where “united” is as much an aspiration as an adjective. ♦

Off the Air Dept.

Colbert's Trumpet Player on Life After Late Night

Since 2015, Jon Lampley has played in the house band of “The Late Show,” which CBS unceremoniously cancelled. As the final episode looms, he takes a look back.

By Mark Yarm

May 04, 2026



Viewers across the country are counting down the days till the final episode of Stephen Colbert’s “Late Show,” which will air on May 21st. When the program’s peculiar, sudden cancellation was announced, last July, the members of the show’s band, Louis Cato and the Great Big Joy Machine, were as surprised as anyone. “It felt like a deep sigh,” Jon (Lamps) Lampley, the group’s trumpet player, recalled the other day, at a sushi place near the Ed Sullivan Theatre.

CBS defended the cancellation as “purely a financial decision.” But many linked it to Colbert’s criticism of the network’s parent company for paying

sixteen million dollars to settle a lawsuit with President Donald Trump—a move that the host decried, on air, as a “big fat bribe.” Lampley, who is thirty-six and wears a neat beard, said, “I don’t really have a lot of interest in fuelling speculation.” He is unhappy, though, about how things went down.

Colbert already has his next gig lined up: writing a “Lord of the Rings” movie with his son Peter McGee and Philippa Boyens. Lampley, meanwhile, will release his second solo album in June—a joyous soul-pop record called “Notes to Self,” whose lead single, “Greener,” features a spoken-word cameo from Colbert. (“Hey, Lamps, how’s your day goin’?”) On the album, the trumpeter levels up as a singer and front man. “It was influenced by the gospel music that’s at the core of what I do,” he said.

Lampley grew up in the predominantly white suburb of Tallmadge, Ohio, but he attended the First Apostolic Faith Church, a Black, Pentecostal congregation in Akron. In seventh grade, he joined the church band. He rattled off the names of various sisters and elders he performed alongside. “Nobody knows who these people are, but they are the ones who taught me, This is what music is,” he said. “This is how you move people. This is how you play the guitar in a way that gets an entire church to clap their hands.” Lampley maintains a deep faith.

He went on to play sousaphone in the Ohio State University marching band, where, as a senior, he experienced one of his proudest moments: “dotting the i” in an on-field cursive formation of the word “Ohio.” “This is considered a very great honor,” he said. During college, he also co-founded a jazz-funk band now known as the Hunteertones. In 2014, the band moved to New York, where Lampley connected with the keyboardist and singer Jon Batiste, who hired him for the band he was assembling for Colbert. Batiste left the show in 2022, and the musician Louis Cato was promoted to bandleader.

“I can’t believe that I chose to make my life out of, like, blowing through a metal pipe,” Lampley said. “The Late Show” was taping that afternoon, and he made his way to the theatre for wardrobe, hair, and makeup. Later, between Colbert’s interviews with Anne Hathaway, who zinged her “Devil Wears Prada” co-star Stanley Tucci about his foodie persona (“That bitch has not made me a morsel!”), and the comedian Josh Johnson, who recounted an amusing T.S.A. encounter (“They open my bag, and it wasn’t

brass knuckles—it was toe spreaders”), Lampley showed off his chops, soloing on a rendition of the Steve Miller Band’s “Fly Like an Eagle.”

At the taping, Colbert, hands in pockets, addressed his trumpet player. “Lampley, I want you to know that a friend of mine came to the show last night,” he said. “And she said, ‘*Wooo*, that trumpet player.’ ” Colbert grinned. “She goes, ‘If I wasn’t happily married, he’d be in big trouble.’ ” The audience whooped.

“You know what it is?” Cato interjected. “It’s the hips.”

“I think that’s it,” Colbert said. “Or it’s the embouchure.”

“Or it’s both,” Lampley said. He illustrated his lipping technique.

“You’re always, like, pre-kissing,” Colbert observed.

Afterward, Lampley and the band’s saxophonist, Louis Fouché, headed to an Italian restaurant. Lampley brought up the exchange involving Colbert’s friend, which ended up being cut before air. “Man,” he said, “I was grateful that my girlfriend was not at the taping today.”

The impending end of the Colbert era was weighing on them all. “Somebody who has been that important to the game and to the craft deserves to go out on their own terms,” Lampley said. “And that was taken from Stephen.” ♦

Dept. of Succession

Is the Twenty-fifth Amendment *Really* an Option?

After J.F.K.'s assassination, a neophyte lawyer named John Feerick was summoned to Washington to draft the provision. Now everyone wants him to weigh in on booting Trump from office.

By Diego Lasarte May 04, 2026



John Feerick, the eighty-nine-year-old law professor who, in 1964, wrote the bulk of the Twenty-fifth Amendment, is used to people asking him questions about the niceties of replacing a sitting President. Mostly, he dodges them. The other day, in his tidy office at Fordham Law School, he talked about the amendment's concept of "inability," in terms of a President's fitness for office—but steered clear of Donald Trump. "You cannot remove powers and duties from a President without the Vice-President agreeing," Feerick said, speaking generally. He has a full head of white hair, and wore a gray suit and orthopedic sneakers.

Feerick's signature creation, the Twenty-fifth Amendment, has been in the news lately, most recently when President Trump was hustled out of the White House Correspondents' dinner, after an intruder showed up with alleged plans to murder the President and top members of the Cabinet. Naturally, questions arose about the line of succession. If the gunman had been successful, Chuck Grassley, the ninety-two-year-old president pro tempore of the Senate, who skipped the dinner, would have been sworn in as President. "Half the Cabinet at least was there," the House Speaker, Mike Johnson, who is second in line and was present at the event, said. "They're going to have to reevaluate this."

Section 1 of the Twenty-fifth Amendment states that "In case of the removal of the President from office or of his death or resignation, the Vice President shall become President." (Curiously, J. D. Vance was rushed off the stage before Trump was.)

Feerick's involvement began in 1963, when he was a newly minted graduate of Fordham Law with a job at Skadden Arps, handling small-claims-court cases. He published an article in the *Fordham Law Review* about Presidential succession, an issue that had come up during the Eisenhower Administration, when the President weathered several grave illnesses. ("Eisenhower really wasn't able to function for a good while," Feerick said.) "I sent the article to President Kennedy, I sent it to Robert Kennedy, to Ted Kennedy," he said. He also sent it to Arthur Krock, the venerated *Times* columnist, who responded with an admiring note, saying, "I wish Congress were as much interested as you and I."

Weeks later, John F. Kennedy was assassinated, and Krock devoted his next column to Feerick's argument. ("Clem!" Feerick called to his assistant, asking her to find the clip, amid shelves containing books he has written. "This one—'From Failing Hands: The Story of Presidential Succession'—is out of print," he said.)

Feerick was heartsick; he'd seen J.F.K. and his wife in a ticker-tape parade in New York. Soon, the brand-new President, Lyndon Johnson, "took an interest in the subject," Feerick said. The article, which Feerick's wife, Emalie, had helped with, went viral, or as viral as something could go in the sixties. Feerick was summoned to Washington to start writing what would become the Twenty-fifth. "I had to ask the law firm if they would pay me to stay overnight and take a train or plane down there," he remembered. "I mean, I had no money. My parents were immigrants."

Feerick spent a lot of time in D.C. One day, he said, "I got there late because the planes weren't running. And I walked right up to the White House from the gate! I opened the door of the White House. Which I guess would be impossible today."

Among the twelve people enlisted to work on the amendment, Feerick was the expert on Presidential vacancies. "There were eight times when Presidents died in office and Vice-Presidents succeeded," he said. Half of these deaths were assassinations—Lincoln, Garfield, McKinley, and J.F.K. (Lincoln's son Robert was either present at or near the first three deaths. After McKinley's, Robert declined invitations to Presidential functions, saying that a "certain fatality" followed him.)

Feerick is also an expert in Presidential incapacity. "In conversations about drafting an amendment during Eisenhower, they talked about the 'insanity' of the President," he said. Section 4 of the amendment states that the Vice-President and a majority of the Cabinet can boot a President if they determine him to be "unable to discharge the powers and duties of his office." Before the Twenty-fifth, Presidents had informally handed over power to the Vice-President during medical issues or temporary absences, but always voluntarily. "An insane President would probably disagree with such a determination," Feerick said.

Last month, Trump tweeted that, if Iran did not agree to his demands, “a whole civilization will die,” prompting several calls to oust him using the Twenty-fifth. Representative Jamie Raskin introduced a bill that would create a bipartisan commission of physicians, psychiatrists, and retired government officials, which could act alongside the Cabinet in the case of the amendment being invoked.

Feerick, asked to consider whether Trump’s unhinged posts, one of which included an A.I. image of himself as Jesus, might substitute for a medical diagnosis, opted to take a long view. “There are Presidents galore from the country’s history that you can find issues with their mental health,” he said. He brought up Richard Nixon. After the Watergate scandal broke, “Nixon was having a lot of difficulty, according to reports I read, and drinking and so forth.” Senior White House staff discussed invoking the Twenty-fifth as Nixon spiralled into paranoia. But Nixon resigned, sending Gerald Ford to the Oval Office.

Feerick took pains to explain that Section 4 is not designed to be a tool used by an opposition party to remove a President. The amendment, he said, was born out of logistical concerns, such as the possibility of a President becoming “unconscious for any of a number of reasons and out of reach during a crisis,” or “if his plane went down.” After Ronald Reagan was shot, Alexander Haig, the Secretary of State, ran into the press room and declared, “I am in control here in the White House!,” even though the Twenty-fifth had not been invoked, and he was actually fourth in line.

Despite the section’s wonkily procedural intentions, it is still regularly mentioned by Trump’s opponents, and Feerick is often contacted by reporters for his expertise. “I’m not getting involved in what the Vice-President should do,” he said. During Joe Biden’s Administration, when the Twenty-fifth came up in debates about whether a President can be too old, Feerick did speak up about one vital point. He remembers saying, at a panel, “Age is individual-specific.” ♦

Art Dept.

On the High Line, Buddha Is the New Giant Pigeon

After the bird sculpture flew the Chelsea coop, the curator Cecilia Alemani oversaw the installation of a new work—a sacred sandstone colossus, based on one destroyed by the Taliban.

By Julian Lucas

May 04, 2026



Before last year, Cecilia Alemani, the chief curator at the High Line, had never heard of—much less seen—a pigeon diaper. “We had an event for National Pigeon Appreciation Day,” she said, occasioned by a giant, hyperrealistic statue of the bird, called “Dinosaur.” Conceived by the Colombian artist Iván Argote, and unveiled in 2024, the sculpture spent a year and a half staring down commuters from its perch on the Spur, a section of the High Line that looms over the intersection of Thirtieth Street and Tenth Avenue. New Yorkers embraced it as a pop-up mascot; in Alemani’s words, “They recognized themselves in this idol hovering at the city’s edge.” More than five thousand attended the appreciation, donning pigeon drag,

pummelling a pigeon piñata, and showing off their pigeon pets, diapers, “flight suits,” and all. “Dinosaur” was such a success that seven thousand petitioners tried to block its removal. “Everyone was very sad,” Alemani said. “But then they fall in love with the next one.”

She’d returned to the Spur to welcome the pigeon’s successor, a fifty-ton Buddha by the Vietnamese artist Tuan Andrew Nguyen. It was a crisp night in April. Drivers honked below, struggling to bypass an enormous crane and a flatbed truck idling by a turnoff to the Lincoln Tunnel. “On the way here, I wondered what all the traffic was about,” Alemani said. “Then I realized it was us!” The park had the air of a stage before showtime. Workers mixed mortar and drove a scissor lift to the edge of a concrete plinth surmounted by four steel rods—supports for the Buddha, whose sandstone body would slide down them in four parts, like beads in an abacus. As the first block was hoisted, Alemani darted to the railing to take a picture. “Look at those feet!” she said. “They’re so cute!”

Alemaní, who was born in Milan, has the impish face of a putto in a Renaissance painting, framed by a mop of dark curls. She’s lived in Manhattan for twenty years, but still speaks of New York with a new arrival’s ebullience. “It’s already curated,” she said, gesturing grandly at the skyline. The waning crescent moon reminded her of a “giant banana,” prompting a staffer to mention Maurizio Cattelan: “All it needs is some duct tape.”

Few have taken a bigger bite out of the contemporary art world than Alemani. In 2022, she curated a landmark edition of the Venice Biennale, “The Milk of Dreams,” which juxtaposed Surrealist masterpieces with contemporary meditations on climate and the body. (It was the first to feature mostly women artists.) Last year, she was praised for her take on Site Santa Fe. But Alemani’s heart is with the High Line, where she relishes the challenge of curating for tourists, taxi-drivers, truckers, and sundry local skeptics. “They might be provoked, they might be challenged, they might be inspired, but there’s always an active relationship,” she said. “In museums, the encounter is more prescriptive.”

Alemaní started at the High Line in 2011, but devised the “Plinth commission” years later, when the Spur was still threatened with demolition.

“There was a pyramid of bottles full of yellow liquid, and chunky old keyboards that must have been thrown from the windows of the old post office,” she recalled. “So, of course, every artist I brought here fell in love.” Inspired by the piazzas of her native Italy, and the contemporary sculptures exhibited in London’s Trafalgar Square, she persuaded the park’s leadership to transform the space into a plein-air gallery.

The inaugural commission, in 2019, was Simone Leigh’s “Brick House,” a bronze bust of a Black woman with cowries dangling from her braids. Next was Sam Durant’s “Untitled (Drone),” a replica of the MQ-9 drones used by the military. Nguyen’s work, “The Light That Shines Through the Universe,” also reflects on warfare. An imagined re-creation of one of the two Bamiyan Buddhas—ancient cliffside sculptures in Afghanistan, which were destroyed by the Taliban—it augments the original with two brass hands cast from discarded artillery shells gathered across the country.

For now, the Buddha’s feet were stuck near the top of their support poles; a man in the scissor lift struggled to push them farther apart. Alemani was undaunted. “The city is going to wake up with a new sculpture that looks like it’s always been there,” she declared, which even the pigeon diehards might learn to love: “Maybe they can think of it as a reincarnation.” ♦

In HBO's "The Dark Wizard," Dean Potter Climbs On

The *BASE* jumper died in a tragic accident in 2015, the day before he was to accept an award for performance art. A new docuseries explores his life and legacy.

By Nick Paumgarten

May 04, 2026



The morning before Dean Potter died, in May, 2015, he and his girlfriend, Jennifer Rapp, were puttering around their house in Yosemite. Potter, the world-famous rock climber and daredevil, had just returned from a trip to Germany, and Rapp had flown in from Vancouver, the headquarters of the apparel company Arc'teryx, where she was head of communications. In the living room, Rapp tried on some dresses for Potter. "Help me pick one," she said.

They were scheduled to fly the next morning to New York, to attend a gala where he was to receive something called an Action Maverick Award. Potter

disliked New York, and cities in general, and planned on staying just one night, but he was uncommonly excited about this particular honor, because it recognized him as an artist. Recently, he'd been trying, mostly in vain, to convince the world, and himself, that he performed vertiginous feats—free soloing on El Capitan, highlining over Yosemite Falls, *BASE* jumping in a wingsuit off the Eiger—not to stoke his ego or his reputation but, instead, to express an elegant swashbuckling concord with the natural world. Having been surpassed, as an athlete, by Alex Honnold, the new free soloist in the valley, Potter, then in his early forties, reimagined himself as a performance artist, of a kind. The Maverick Award was a validation.

Potter helped Rapp choose a dress: one by Missoni, with bright colors. A friend, Graham Hunt, Potter's wingsuiting sidekick, was due to drop by to do tree work on land they'd bought nearby, but, preferring to chill out alone with Rapp, Potter left a message telling him not to come. Hunt didn't get that message, though, and turned up soon afterward. "That changed the course of our day," Rapp said recently. "We wouldn't have hung out with Graham, and Dean wouldn't have died." Not on that day, anyway.

That afternoon, Potter, Rapp, and Hunt hiked out to Taft Point, a prow of granite overlooking Yosemite Valley. In their flying-squirrel suits, Hunt and Potter jumped off a promontory and swooped toward a ridge with a slot in it called the Notch. They didn't make it. Rapp, up on Taft Point, heard two thuds. A recovery team found the bodies in the Notch the next day.

The accident in the Notch is the climax of "The Dark Wizard," a new four-part HBO documentary about Potter and his demons. The film's directors, Nick Rosen and Peter Mortimer, and its co-creator Josh Lowell, also made "The Alpinist," in 2021, about another doomed mountain man, and they produce Reel Rock, a perennial travelling festival of climbing films, so they're accustomed to tragic endings. Still, the latest film, owing to Potter's emotional turbulence and some of the wreckage he left behind, was the most fraught project they've taken on.



A few days after Potter died, Rapp received an e-mail from the woman behind the Maverick Awards, a choreographer named Elizabeth Streb. Potter and Rapp had first met her at the Telluride Mountainfilm Festival, where she was promoting Catherine Gund's movie about her, "Born to Fly: Elizabeth Streb vs. Gravity." Streb's work incorporates what she called "extreme action," a lot of falling and crashing into things. She and Potter hit it off.

"He, like me, believed he could fly, and dedicated his life to that proposition," Streb said the other day. "We have a theory of the real move—it's one that once initiated you can't stop. We specialize in letting the ground stop us and training our bodies to take the hit. There's no such thing as perfect safety. There is only preparing and training."

The night after Potter died, Streb, at her gala, presented his award in absentia. "I am gathering everything together for you," she wrote afterward, in her e-mail to Rapp. "The Award itself, with his name and an inscription"; also, "a video we put together of his work [and] a video of an 'Action' my dancers performed for him called 'Head First' and a few photos of the Evening."

Rapp, in her desolation, never replied, so she never got to see the award or the videos. They haven't spoken since. Rapp doesn't have the dress

anymore. ♦

Reporting & Essays

- [Was the Declaration of Independence Better Before the Edits?](#)
- [How Americans Caught Gold Fever Again](#)
- [Barack Obama Considers His Role in the Age of Trump](#)
- [The Life and Times of an American Tween](#)
- [Comeback Kids](#)

Was the Declaration of Independence Better Before the Edits?

Amid contention, criticism, and compromise, a divided nation had to present a unified front. It came at a cost.

By Jill Lepore

May 04, 2026



Red-headed, spindle-shanked Thomas Jefferson was thirty-three years old when he drafted the Declaration of Independence, in 1776; he was so young and, as it turned out, so long-lived that he had another fifty years to think about what it meant. Over that half century, during which he served as a foreign minister, state legislator, governor of Virginia, member of Congress, Secretary of State, Vice-President, and [President \(twice\)](#), he was often asked why he held it to be so true as to be self-evident that all men are created equal and that governments are instituted among men to secure rights that include life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. Happiness! On these questions, he had a great deal to say. This year marks two centuries since Jefferson's death and two hundred and fifty years since the United States

declared its independence by issuing arguably the most important piece of prose in modern history. Jefferson thought that it began the world anew. What does it mean now that it's old?

The story of how the Declaration of Independence came to be written has been told many times but remains disputed, if not hotly, then lukewarmly. On June 11, 1776, the Continental Congress appointed Jefferson to serve on a committee charged with drafting a statement declaring independence, along with John Adams, Benjamin Franklin, Roger Sherman of Connecticut, and Robert Livingston of New York. "They unanimously pressed on myself alone to undertake the draught," Jefferson later wrote. Is this true? Adams, forever jealous of Jefferson, recorded in his diary that the committee had given Jefferson an outline of key points and that all that Jefferson had done was to "cloath them in a proper Dress." Franklin, who was the best writer on what became known as the Committee of Five, said that he declined to write the draft because, as an old man and a wise man and, above all, a man of many rules, he refused to write anything fated to be edited by committee. Adams, a man of tart and ready opinions and of emotions that extended only so far as the short span between envy and bitterness, insisted that he'd have written it himself if he hadn't thought it necessary that a Virginian should write it; also, as the famous Massachusetts curmudgeon admitted, everyone found him "obnoxious." One thing lies apparently beyond dispute: no one entertained even for a minute the possibility that Sherman or Livingston, both lacklustre prose stylists, should wield the pen. In any event, the task fell to Jefferson, who was said to have written his draft in "a day or two." (In fact, it took seventeen.)

There was a war on. Much haste was called for. But alacrity was possible because drafting the Declaration required no study. "I turned to neither book or pamphlet while writing it," Jefferson later told [James Madison](#). "I did not consider it as any part of my charge to invent new ideas altogether & to offer no sentiment which had ever been expressed before." Jefferson could be quite fulsome on this point. The whole [American Revolution](#), he explained to another correspondent, defied the deference to history implied by such research: "we were free to write what we pleased. we had no occasion to search into musty records, to hunt up Royal parchments, or to investigate the laws & institutions of a semi-barbarous ancestry. we appealed to those of nature, and found them engraved in our ~~breasts~~ hearts." He meant the

Declaration to express only “the genuine effusion of the soul of our country.” He was surpassingly proud of his authorship of the Declaration. He ordered that “Author of the Declaration of American Independence” be engraved on his tombstone, but did not wish it to mention that he was ever President. Again and again, Jefferson insisted that his purpose had been “not to find out new principles, or new arguments, never before thought of, not merely to say things which had never been said before; but to place before mankind the common sense of the subject.” In sum, “neither aiming at originality of principle or sentiment, nor yet copied from any particular and previous writing, it was intended to be an expression of the American mind.”

The soul, the breast, the heart, the mind. Readers at the time did not find the Declaration to be original, either. Richard Henry Lee said that the document was “copied from Locke’s treatise on government.” Adams fumed that there was “not an idea in it, but what had been hackneyed in Congress for two years before.”

Maybe so, but think of how badly Congress had stated those hackneyed ideas. In June, 1775, Jefferson had been saddled with the Pennsylvania delegate John Dickinson as a co-author of another declaration, the Declaration of the Causes and Necessity of Taking Up Arms, a mealy-mouthed explanation of why the Americans, having been attacked by the British Army at Lexington and Concord and at Bunker Hill, were fighting back. The preamble, written by Dickinson, begins:

If it was possible for men, who exercise their reason, to believe, that the Divine Author of our existence intended a part of the human race to hold an absolute property in, and an unbounded power over others, marked out by his infinite goodness and wisdom, as the objects of a legal domination never rightfully resistible, however severe and oppressive, the Inhabitants of these Colonies might at least require from the Parliament of Great Britain some evidence, that this dreadful authority over them, has been granted to that body.

The preamble of the Declaration of Independence expresses similar sentiments not only less timidly—a year of war had made Congress bolder—but with both more eloquence and more precision:

When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

To say that the ideas in the Declaration were not original to Jefferson isn't to say that the writing shows no evidence of his hand. Jefferson may have consulted no books, but he certainly consulted his memory, after a lifetime of reading. His draft of the Declaration begins Biblically. If not "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth," then at least "When in the course of human events." Its political theory is Lockean, and also republican and radical: "We hold these truths to be sacred & undeniable; that all men are created equal & independant, that from that equal creation they derive rights inherent & inalienable, among which are the preservation of life, & liberty, & the pursuit of happiness." Its style reflects Jefferson's literary taste. One of his favorite books was "Tristram Shandy"—it was so dear to him that he and his wife shared excerpts as she was dying—and parts of the Declaration have the quality of Sternean exasperation. "When one runs over the catalogue of all the cross-reckonings and sorrowful *items* with which the heart of man is overcharged, 'tis wonderful by what hidden resources the mind is enabled to stand it out, and bear itself up," Sterne wrote. Here's Jefferson: "All experience hath shewn that mankind are more disposed to suffer while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed."

Aside from Adams, no member of the Continental Congress was a better student of history than Jefferson was, and, aside from Franklin, none was a better scientist. The Declaration's list of [grievances against George III](#) marries the moralism of history to the empiricism of science: "The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world." But, even as he declared the independence of the United States and asserted the rights of Americans, Jefferson nonetheless feared the sovereignty of Native nations, whom he called "merciless Indian savages," and, though he was himself a slaveowner, he denounced, in his draft, the

“assemblage of horrors” that was slavery, and blamed the King for having opened “a market where *MEN* should be bought & sold” and then for having promised liberty to enslaved Africans willing to fight for the British. Finally, Jefferson, who had been admitted to the bar in 1767, also included in the Declaration a few lawyerly, I-rest-my-case zingers: “A prince whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a people who mean to be free.”

But, beyond all his influences and all that he borrowed, Jefferson was, of course, not the only author of the Declaration of Independence. Once he’d written the draft, he gave it to Adams and Franklin (“the two members of whose judgments and amendments I wished most to have the benefit”), who made suggestions in their own handwriting. It is widely believed that Franklin changed Jefferson’s “We hold these truths to be sacred & undeniable” to “We hold these truths to be self-evident,” which was tidier, less captious, and more secular. Then, on July 2nd and again on July 3rd, Congress met as a committee of the whole to revise the draft submitted by the Committee of Five. Thus began every writer’s nightmare.

The Declaration of Independence is not brief. If you were to cut it down to the length of the shortest short story—“For sale: baby shoes, never worn”—you’d get something like “Hear ye! Men are free! Mostly!” Congress struck out a few hundred words from Jefferson’s rough draft, but it never got as short as that.

The dozens of edits that Congress made have been minutely examined by historians and literary scholars. Pauline Maier, the author of “American Scripture,” lauded those congressional edits, which included swapping “neglected utterly” for “utterly neglected” and “a people who mean to be free” for “a free people” and changing the description of the injuries committed by the King from “unremitting” to “repeated.” But Jefferson found the experience of sitting there while lesser writers messed with his prose unbearable. He wrote to Richard Henry Lee, sharing both his original and Congress’s revision, to ask “whether it is the better or worse for the Critics.” He was sure it was worse.

Congress’s biggest change was to eliminate a paragraph that blamed George III for the institution of human bondage from which Jefferson’s own wealth

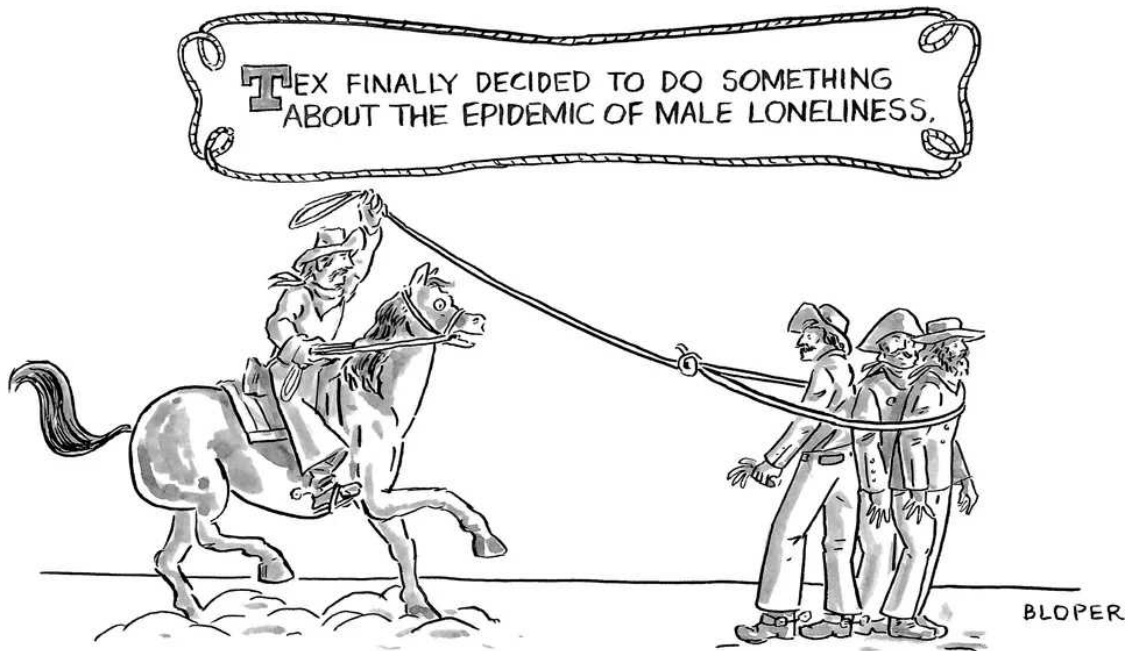
was derived, and that charged the King with having “waged cruel war against human nature itself, violating its most sacred rights of life & liberty in the persons of a distant people who never offended him, captivating & carrying them into slavery in another hemisphere, or to incur miserable death in their transportation thither,” and with having defeated the colonists’ “every legislative attempt to prohibit or to restrain this execrable commerce.” If included, this passage would have been the twenty-eighth grievance, and the longest in the document. Jefferson maintained that the deletion was made at the behest of delegates from South Carolina and Georgia; historians have suggested that it was necessary because the passage was so patently hypocritical as to be embarrassing. But it was also, as the historian David Armitage has remarked, the climax of the story Jefferson’s draft told—the worst thing of which he accused the King. And its erasure marked the beginning of centuries of political attempts to pretend that slavery never happened. (Eleven years later, delegates to the Constitutional Convention used all manner of circumlocution to avoid putting the words “slave” or “slavery” into the nation’s frame of government.)

While Congress went about its edits, eliminating adverbs, altering verbs, and slashing whole paragraphs, Franklin tried to distract the miserable Jefferson by telling him a story about why he had his rule about never writing something that other people would revise. When he was a printer, Franklin said, a friend who was about to open a hat shop wanted to hire a painter to make him a sign: a picture of a hat and the words “John Thomson, Hatter, makes and sells hats—for ready money.” Before setting the painter to the task, Thomson asked his friends for their advice on the design. The first suggested striking out the word “hatter,” as “tautologous, because followed by the words ‘makes hats.’ ” The second proposed “that the word ‘makes’ might as well be omitted, because his customers would not care who made the hats.” The third said “the words ‘for ready money,’ were useless as it was not the custom of the place to sell on credit.” And the fourth pointed out that what was left—“John Thomson sells hats”—was wordy, too. Why “sells hats,” he asked, given that “nobody will expect you to give them away”? In the end, all that was left was a picture of a hat and the words “John Thomson.”

And that, with no little irony, has been the fate of the Declaration of Independence, too.

The Declaration had many ancestors. It also has many descendants. A better picture than a hat might be a bow tie. The Declaration itself is the knot—*the soul, the breast, the heart, the mind*. The wings on either side of the knot are what came before and what came after, models for what Jefferson wrote and imitations of it.

What came before are English declarations of rights that can be traced back to the twelfth century, including, most notably, the 1689 Declaration of Rights, which charged that James II, with “the Assistance of divers evil Counsellors, Judges, and Ministers, employed by him, did endeavour to subvert and extirpate the Protestant Religion, and the Lawes and Liberties of this Kingdom.” In America, colonists had been collectively declaring their rights since the Stamp Act crisis of the seventeen-sixties. More immediately, by Maier’s count, Jefferson’s draft followed declarations of independence issued by at least ninety American towns, counties, states, militia units, and groups of mechanics between April and July of 1776, including Pennsylvania’s “Declaration on the subject of the Independence of this Colony of the Crown of *Great Britain*,” issued on June 24, 1776. It begins with language quite similar to the part of Jefferson’s Declaration in which he lists the injuries inflicted on the colonies by the King: “Whereas, *George* the Third, King of *Great Britain*, &c., in violation of the principles of the *British* Constitution, and of the laws of justice and humanity, hath, by an accumulation of oppression unparalleled in history, excluded the inhabitants of this, with the other *American* Colonies, from his protection.” *The soul, the breast, the heart, the mind*.



On the other side of the bow-tie knot, what came after the Declaration includes what Armitage has called a “contagion of sovereignty”: more than a hundred declarations of independence issued since 1776, many borrowing from the language of the American one. The first surge came in the age of revolutions. Later waves followed the collapse of empires after the First World War, the great era of decolonization after the Second, and the breakup of the Soviet Union. Ho Chi Minh, who wrote [Vietnam’s Declaration of Independence](#) in 1945, called the 1776 text an “immortal statement.”

Yet there are other declarations of human equality, freedom, and rights whose principles inspired Jefferson but whose implications he refused to entertain. In 1764, in “The Rights of the British Colonies Asserted and Proved,” the Boston lawyer James Otis argued that “the colonists are by the law of nature free born, as indeed all men are, white or black.” What would it have meant if Jefferson had written, “all men, white or black, are created equal”? What if he had written into the Declaration the language found in petitions of enslaved Black people seeking emancipation, such as one signed by a number of men from Massachusetts who, in 1773, declared that they “have in comon with other men a naturel right to be free,” or another group who, the following year, proclaimed, “We are a freeborn Pepel and have never forfeited this Blessing by aney compact or agreement whatever.” What if, instead of blaming the King for having “*waged cruel war against human*

nature itself” by enslaving Africans, Jefferson—and Congress—had declared, in their Declaration, an end to it?

This question highlights a broader omission in the writing of history, and in the memory of the nation’s founding. Lost in the red, white, and blue fireworks of America 250 is the fact that it marks the anniversary of the first state constitutions, too—the anniversary, that is, of American constitutionalism itself. New Hampshire, whose royal governor simply walked off the job, became the first former colony to write a constitution, in January, 1776. South Carolina followed in March, establishing itself as a republic. John Adams, thrilled at a spirit of independence that he described as an “Electric Fire,” composed a letter instructing eminent men on how to draft constitutions. It was at this point that his wife urged him to reconsider what elements he included in any new code of laws. “Do not put such unlimited power into the hands of the Husbands,” she wrote. “Remember all Men would be tyrants if they could.” He ignored her.

John Adams’s letter on what constitutions needed was published in April, 1776, as “Thoughts on Government.” He advised his countrymen to throw themselves into the task of “beginning Government anew” and argued that “the Happiness of the People, the great End of Man, is the End of Government.” He favored governments run by popularly elected representative assemblies, weak executives, and independent judiciaries—what he called governments “of Laws and not of men.” In Philadelphia, on May 10th, Adams urged all the states to write constitutions, and Congress passed a resolution to that effect.

Jefferson arrived from Virginia four days later and immediately sent a copy of that resolution back to Virginia’s legislature, which was meeting in Williamsburg as a convention, pointing out that devising new state governments was “the whole object of the present controversy.” He then devoted himself, for weeks—harried, frantic—to composing multiple drafts of a constitution for Virginia. Meanwhile, George Mason wrote Virginia’s Declaration of Rights, after which he, too, turned his attention to drafting Virginia’s constitution, John Adams having sent Richard Henry Lee his “Thoughts on Government” for just this purpose. Though Mason’s draft of the state constitution was somewhat more democratic than what Adams had favored (the upper house of the legislature was to be elected by the people,

rather than appointed by the lower house), Adams conceded that “Virginia has done very well.”

On June 12, 1776, the day after the Committee of Five was appointed, the *Pennsylvania Gazette* printed Virginia’s Declaration of Rights. It begins by stating “that all men are by nature equally free and independent, and have certain inherent rights, of which, when they enter into a state of society, they cannot, by any compact, deprive or divest their posterity; namely, the enjoyment of life and liberty, with the means of acquiring and possessing property, and pursuing and obtaining happiness and safety.” Jefferson, now working on the Declaration of Independence, nicely tightened that up.

He was also busy writing a document he cared about far more. Not knowing how far along the writing of the Virginia constitution was, Jefferson sent to Williamsburg his own draft. He completed a third draft of the state constitution sometime before June 13, 1776. It included a number of radical provisions, including the complete abolition of slavery (“no person hereafter coming into this country shall be held within the same in slavery under any pretext whatever”) and the stipulation that, at least as concerned inheritance, “females shall have equal rights with males.” Like “ready money” and “sells hats,” “no slavery” and “equal rights for women” were edited out. Didn’t the picture of the hat say it all?

Jefferson’s draft having arrived too late, the Virginia delegates set it almost entirely aside, though they retained Jefferson’s list of grievances against the King, placing the list between the document’s Declaration of Rights and its framing of the new government. The Committee of Five presented the draft Declaration of Independence to Congress on June 28th. Virginia declared independence from England and adopted its new constitution on June 29th. And then Benjamin Franklin told Thomas Jefferson a tall tale about a hatmaker’s sign.

If there are many more before to the Declaration of Independence than most Americans are wont to consider, there are also a great many more afters. The original parchment was rolled up and stored in the office of the secretary of the Continental Congress, but was then moved around a fair amount during the war—bouncing around towns and cities in Pennsylvania, Maryland, and New Jersey before ending up, in 1785, in New York. It then moved with the

national capital: back to Philadelphia, in 1790, and then to Washington, ten years later. It was first displayed to the public only in 1841, in what was then the U.S. Patent Office. In 1876, the document's centennial, it was carried back to Philadelphia, where it was exhibited at Independence Hall, considerably yellowed and faded—a decay that occasioned much concern and public outcry and led to decades of largely unsuccessful efforts to preserve the parchment before it was put on display at the Library of Congress, in 1924. Not until 1952 was the Declaration, with the Constitution, moved to its current home, in the National Archives, under armed guard.

The parchment lay largely hidden for more than fifty years, but printed versions circulated immediately. John Dunlap, the Continental Congress's printer, issued the first typeset copies of the Declaration of Independence on July 4, 1776, fitting it all on a page, a giant broadside. Jonas Phillips, a Jewish merchant in Philadelphia who kept a drygoods store on Market Street, folded up a copy and tucked it into a letter he sent to Amsterdam. "The enclosed is a declaration of the whole country," Phillips wrote. "How it will end, the blessed God knows!" Phillips's letter was among the bags of mail that were seized by British warships as they stopped American vessels during the war; it never reached its destination. But, in 1787, Phillips petitioned the Constitutional Convention for a provision to be made in the new federal Constitution which would guarantee religious liberty. He wrote to George Washington, who presided over the Convention, "I solecet this favour for my Self my Children and posterity and for the benefit of all the Israelites through the 13 united States of america." (In 1834, Phillips's grandson Uriah Phillips Levy purchased Monticello, Jefferson's mountaintop home, and turned it into a private monument dedicated to religious liberty. In 1923, a year before the Library of Congress displayed the Declaration of Independence for the first time, Jonas Phillips's descendants sold Monticello to a foundation, which opened it to the public.)

When Phillips mailed his copy of the Declaration of Independence to Europe, he added a bit of commentary. Other Americans offered their own edits. Sometime in 1776, Lemuel Haynes, a Black soldier who had served as a minuteman in Massachusetts and then enlisted in the Continental Army, wrote a meditation on the Declaration—essentially an amendment to it—that he titled "Liberty Further Extended," arguing that "Men were made for more

noble Ends than to be Drove to market, like Sheep and oxen,” and insisting that “a Negro may justly challenge, and has an undeniable right to his Liberty. Consequently, the practice of Slave-keeping, which so much abounds in this land is illicit.” Shortly before the Constitution was written, Haynes would become the first Black minister ordained in the United States.

That act, of amending Jefferson’s original draft, edit upon edit, has been the story not only of new nation-states declaring their independence but also of people within nation-states. In the U.S., that tradition found expression, beginning in the eighteen-twenties—the jubilee anniversary—in declarations of independence issued by groups of workingmen, of women, of farmers, of socialists. No nineteenth-century tradition was more influential than that of Black abolitionists. In Boston, Maria W. Stewart, a Black lay preacher, published a series of essays and sermons in *The Liberator*, insisting to white audiences that “our souls are fired with the same love of liberty and independence with which your souls are fired.” In 1829, the North Carolina-born Black writer David Walker, a close friend of Stewart’s, wrote a tract titled “Appeal to the Colored Citizens of the World,” asking Americans to compare the language “extracted from your Declaration of Independence, with your cruelties and murders inflicted by your cruel and unmerciful fathers and yourselves on our fathers and on us.” Building on this Black-abolitionist reading of the Declaration of Independence, [Frederick Douglass](#) would famously ask, in 1852, “What, to the American slave, is your Fourth of July?” He continued, “Are the great principles of political freedom and of natural justice, embodied in that Declaration of Independence, extended to us?” The answer was no. “This Fourth July is yours, not mine. You may rejoice, I must mourn.” He did far more than mourn. He organized a political movement, he published a newspaper, he influenced elections, and he fought to amend the Constitution.

In 1789, in the First Congress, James Madison had tried and failed to get his reworded version of the preamble of the Declaration of Independence inserted into the Constitution, as its first amendment. Instead, it was Black abolitionists who, in the decades before the Civil War, achieved that fusion by insisting that the Constitution could not be read without the Declaration. In 1848, women meeting at the nation’s first women’s-rights convention, in Seneca Falls, New York, drafted and adopted an amended Declaration of Independence, the Declaration of Sentiments. Elsewhere, Southern

defenders of slavery offered up their own edits of the Declaration, excising the phrase “all men are created equal” (which John C. Calhoun considered to be an error) and eliminating natural rights (which, in 1863, George Fitzhugh described as a “bombastic absurdity”). In 1860, South Carolina became the first state to secede from the Union, declaring its independence while insisting on the “right of property in slaves.” What pro-slavery Southerners valued in the Declaration of Independence was a single element: the right of “one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another.” The call to revolution turned into a right to secession.

“We can leave whenever we want” was the Confederacy’s six-word summary of the Declaration of Independence. And that idea thrives in the fractures and furies that drive American politics in the twenty-first century, the hatreds and the violence, the appetite for division, and the ongoing campaigns—they have never stopped—for schemes of schism (the Republic of Texas, Greater Idaho, an independent California, a proposed state called Jefferson). Disunion is as rich a vein in American political history as union is.

[Abraham Lincoln](#) tried in vain to disavow the Confederacy’s interpretation of the Declaration as rendering the Constitution meaningless. In his first Inaugural Address, on March 4, 1861, with seven states having already seceded from the Union, Lincoln proclaimed the essence of secession to be anarchy. But it was in a speech he gave less than two weeks earlier, on February 22, 1861, at Philadelphia’s Independence Hall, that Lincoln sought to say what the Declaration really meant. “It was not the mere matter of the separation of the Colonies from the motherland; but that sentiment in the Declaration of Independence which gave liberty, not alone to the people of this country, but, I hope, to the world, for all future time,” he said, speaking from a flag-draped wooden platform in front of the building’s brick façade.

In the winter cold, men climbed leafless trees to see the President-elect speak. Soldiers stood in a row, keeping back the shivering crowd.

“It was that which gave promise that in due time the weight would be lifted from the shoulders of all men,” Lincoln went on.

And then he asked, “Now, my friends, can this country be saved upon that basis? If it can, I will consider myself one of the happiest men in the world, if I can help to save it. If it cannot be saved upon that principle, it will be truly awful. But if this country cannot be saved without giving up that principle, I was about to say I would rather be assassinated on this spot than surrender it.”

He said he hoped there would be no war, and no bloodshed. And his hopes were dashed. But Lincoln was the Declaration’s most pitiless and most brilliant editor. At Gettysburg, fourscore and seven years after Jefferson drafted the document, Lincoln cut its principles down to a “For sale: baby shoes, never worn” ten words: “government of the people, by the people, for the people.” That, plus a picture of Lincoln’s stovepipe hat, remains its best abridgment. Whether the principles of the Declaration, abridged or unabridged, endure is a question that only the course of human events will determine. ♦

This is drawn from “Declare: A Civic Gospel.”

Letter from California

How Americans Caught Gold Fever Again

Soaring gold prices, viral panning influencers, macho gold-mining reality shows, and Trump's gold obsession have ignited a craze for prospecting not seen since 1849.

By Jennifer Wilson

May 04, 2026



One morning this past January, I set out in a rental car on the road to El Dorado—not the mythical city deep in the Amazon whose legendary riches lured legions of men to gruesome ends but the county in Northern California. My journey nonetheless felt perilous. As a New Yorker, I hadn't touched a steering wheel in a year, and the path before me, Route 49, named for the forty-niners, the generation who ventured to the American West during the California gold rush, snakes through the dramatic Sierra Nevada foothills. Driving along the winding, three-hundred-mile stretch, which connects the state's historic boom towns, I pictured myself tumbling into the

river below, like the miner's daughter Clementine, of "Oh My Darling" fame.

I was headed to a local state park for Gold Discovery Day, an annual commemoration of the moment when a sawmill operator named James Marshall spotted gold on the banks of the American River. Route 49, a.k.a. the Mother Lode Highway, is now a corridor of quaint, architecturally preserved cities dotted with cowboy-chic boutique hotels which have become popular getaways for Bay Area techies. At the Golden Gate Saloon, in Grass Valley, one of the oldest continuously operating bars west of the Mississippi, I scanned a menu of small plates and California wines. I told the bartender that I had expected themed cocktails with names like the Mine Shaft. "Oh, there's a bar called that in Nevada City," he said, referring to a nearby town that once drew Chinese immigrants and free African Americans looking to join the California Argonauts, as the forty-niners were also called. In the village of Murphys, I popped into a "general store" that sold, alongside Hydro Flasks, a board game about the Donner Party, the group of settlers who got trapped in the Sierra Nevada and resorted to cannibalism. I picked up snacks for the drive.

But, lately, people around these parts aren't just trading in nostalgia. Gold is having a moment. With concerns rising about inflation and the stability of the U.S. dollar, investors and central banks have flocked to gold as a hedge. In January of 2024, it was priced at a historic high of two thousand dollars an ounce; when I arrived in California, the number hit a once unthinkable five thousand an ounce.

The eye-popping price has sparked what many people are calling Gold Rush 2.0, with everyday Americans buying gold-panning kits and signing up for "pay dirt of the month" clubs. In 2023, the Bureau of Land Management reported that there were more than six hundred thousand active mining claims, or permits, on federal land, a record for this century. That figure includes Big Mining, but, this year, the Gold Prospectors Association of America, an organization for hobbyists, saw its first-quarter enrollment double from that of last year. The aurum-curious listen to podcasts like "Dig Deep" and "Unearthed" and subscribe to *The Nugget* newsletter. Membership to the subreddit r/Prospecting has increased by more than a thousand per cent since 2020. "Does anybody else ever just want to take

pyrite and punch it in the face?” a recent post read, referring to the yellow-tinged mineral better known as fool’s gold.



“It’s a good time to get a metal-detecting hobby,” Albert Fausel, an amateur gold prospector and the owner of Placerville Hardware, in Placerville, California, told me, when I visited his shop. (“Placer” gold is findable in water and in dirt, unlike “lode,” which must be extracted from rock.) The storefront, which opened in 1852, supplied early miners with dynamite and Studebaker wheelbarrows. Now it sells plastic pans and sluice boxes (troughs that use flowing water to separate gold from dirt) for the whole family—some even come in Barbie pink. By the register, there were barbecue lighters in the shape of double-barrelled shotguns for the “gunslinging grillmaster” and metal detectors hanging from a pair of deer antlers. Fausel has wide-set eyes and a gap-toothed smile, giving him a boyish appearance. “In the past couple of weeks, it’s really picked up. When everyone knows it’s five grand, it’s a milestone,” he said, before dashing off to help some customers.

A man in his thirties was looking for a digging tool; he was new to prospecting, he told me, but a friend of his, a retired mailman, had taken it up and regularly displayed his hauls on social media. Today’s gold rush is a #goldrush. On YouTube, prospecting influencers post videos of themselves

fending off bears and spelunking down old mines. A content creator with the moniker Pioneer Pauly has an A.S.M.R. video of his hand caressing a pile of gold nuggets. His videos have accumulated three hundred million views.

The man also mentioned that he watched “the gold-rush shows.” After a spike in gold prices in 2010, the Discovery Channel green-lit a slew of reality series about amateur miners. The first, “Gold Rush,” now in its sixteenth season, began with a group of men in Oregon, hit hard by the Great Recession, who banded together to mine a gold claim by Porcupine Creek, in southeastern Alaska. The show was a ratings juggernaut, becoming Friday night’s top cable series for men under fifty-five, and inspired spinoffs, including “Gold Rush: Mine Rescue with Freddy & Juan,” a Gordon Ramsey-style business-makeover show for struggling mines.

Fausel has appeared on Discovery’s “America’s Backyard Gold,” a travel show about mining destinations. In an episode on Placerville, cameras follow Fausel as he goes “sniping”—searching for gold underwater, with a snorkel. Within thirty minutes, he finds half an ounce of gold, then worth eight hundred dollars. “That’s a little better than minimum wage,” he jokes.



Gold has also got a boost from its biggest hype man since King Tut. “Gold will not be Tariffed!” Donald Trump announced in August of last year on

Truth Social. The original gold rush was full of business tycoons whose success relied on convincing ordinary men that they were millionaires-to-be; Leland Stanford, a merchant who became a founder of Stanford University, and Levi Strauss, the denim kingpin, made a killing selling dry goods and a dream to miners and pioneers. Similarly, Trump's rise to power has been based in no small part on instilling in everyday Americans the idea that they, too, could have riches like his if the country and its laws were just rolled back to an era when *men were men*.

These days, hitting the mother lode looks different than it did in 1849—brand deals, reality-TV guest spots—but there's still a belief that fortune favors the bold. In the hardware store, Fausel showed me a snuffer bottle for removing debris from underwater cavities which he had made using a 3-D printer. "Now I just need a YouTube video to go promote it," he said.

I arrived at Marshall Gold Discovery State Historic Park, in nearby Coloma, for the day's festivities. There were gold-panning lessons at ten, eleven, one, two, and three. A crowd of children were learning to sew pouches to carry gold nuggets in. A couple of older men dressed in period wear were cooking over an open fire. "Varmint stew," one grumbled, before introducing himself as Monterey Jack. "In the eighteen-thirties, we were mountain men and fur trappers in the Grand Tetons," he explained, with a theatrical twang. "We ended up at Fort Sutter. John Sutter got us payroll to bring in meat." In his real voice, he added, "Probably raccoon."

Sutter, a Swiss immigrant, arrived in the Mexican territory of Alta California in 1839 and was given land by the governor to help fend off American settlers. Sutter established a small trading colony, which he named Nueva Helvetia, Spanish for New Switzerland, presaging the area's future as a lawless monetary hub. He partnered with James Marshall, a carpenter from New Jersey, who built him a sawmill nearby in exchange for a share of its profits. Many of the workers were members of the Nisenan and Miwok tribes whom Sutter forced into slave labor.

On the morning of January 24, 1848, Marshall walked to the river to inspect the mill, now the site of the park. In the tailrace, he spotted some small glistening objects—pieces of quartz, maybe. He hit one against a rock and, seeing that it was malleable, suspected that it might be gold. He gave a piece

to the wife of a mill worker who was making soap; when she threw it into lye solution, it came out sparkling. It *was* gold, which doesn't oxidize. Marshall told Sutter, who, afraid of losing his workers to prospecting, suggested that they keep the discovery quiet.



Marshall may have found the gold, but historians credit another man with igniting the California gold rush. That spring, Samuel Brannan, a Mormon shopkeeper who owned a general store on Sutter's land, collected gold dust and took it in a bottle to San Francisco, where he ran through the streets shouting, "Gold! Gold! Gold! Gold from the American River!" (In some tellings, he had already bought up every shovel in California.) Brannan's scheme to drum up business became a useful tale of American ingenuity. (And it was American by then. On February 2nd, Mexico and the United States signed the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, in which Mexico ceded fifty-five per cent of its territory, including California.)

As the historian Malcolm J. Rohrbough writes, in "Days of Gold: The California Gold Rush and the American Nation," "The changes in California over a few short months were those characteristically associated with a plague or war." San Francisco became a veritable ghost town: three-quarters of the houses were abandoned; blacksmiths and carpenters, doctors and solicitors rushed to them thar hills. Any ship that docked in the city's harbor

risked losing its crew. Mexican nobles couldn't keep household help. "These gold mines have upset all social and domestic arrangements," the first American mayor of nearby Monterey observed in his diary, "And the *hidalgo*—in whose veins flows the blood of Cortes—[has] to clean his own boots." Local newspapers suspended production, but, across the country, the Washington *Daily Union* declared, " 'El Dorado' is certainly found at last."

Gold fever quickly became a pandemic. Among the first foreigners to arrive were miners from Chile, who brought *bateas*, or gold pans, introducing the technology to the region. The Irish also joined, becoming a potent force in the gold rush. (Edward T. O'Donnell, a history professor at the College of the Holy Cross, has suggested that the "association of the Irish with mining fortunes led to the expression 'luck of the Irish.' ") The official Chinese population of California went from three individuals in 1848 to twenty thousand four years later. In London, Karl Marx wept: the revolutions of 1848 had sown the seeds of socialism throughout Europe, and now here was capitalism roaring back like a lion, tempting the young into its den.

I wandered over to a log cabin with a sign that read "Miner's Store: Groceries and Provisions." I explained to a woman in a wide-brimmed black hat and a red wool overshirt that I was a reporter. At this, the reënactor—whose name was Jen Roger and whose real job was director of the Nevada State Museum in Carson City—went into docent mode. "The biggest myth that came out of the gold rush is that poor kids were striking it rich," she said. "It's the people who mine the miners—land speculators, shop owners—who got rich. Sam Brannan made a pile of money."

Many American corporations were gold-rush startups. Wells Fargo provided armed gold transport to banks back East. Domingo (né Domenico) Ghirardelli, an Italian immigrant, sold chocolate to miners out of a tent. Not every enterprise got past the beta stage. A reënactor named Chuck, whose day job is running a call center in San Jose, brought up a company that hawked "gold salve." "You supposedly covered yourself in it and rolled down the mountain to gather gold," he said.



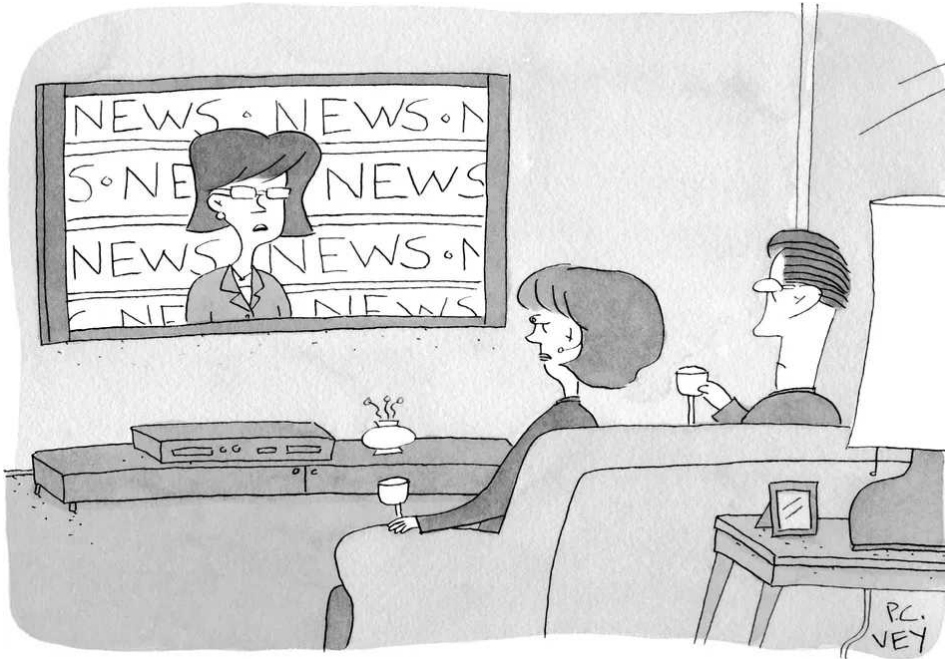
Only a small percentage of miners made a fortune. Yet the story of the toiler turned tycoon persisted. It had to—how else were big industrial mines, which quickly came to dominate the landscape, going to entice laborers to California? Passage by ship from New York cost as much as a thousand dollars, around twice the American worker’s average yearly salary. The myth that America is a place where anyone can become suddenly and astronomically wealthy has its origins in the gold rush. It’s no mistake that Jay Gatsby models himself on Dan Cody, “a product of the Nevada silver fields, of the Yukon, of every rush for metal since seventy-five.” The forty-niners didn’t conceive of themselves as settlers; they imagined that they’d get rich and head home. In reality, many couldn’t even afford a return ticket.

In the Gold Discovery Museum lobby, I met Ed Allen, a reënactor who was playing James Marshall. Tall and white-haired, he wore a yellow handkerchief around his neck. Allen has served as the park historian for twenty-three years. His position is unpaid, not that he minds. He sold semiconductors to Intel during the dot-com boom of the nineteen-nineties —“That was another gold rush,” he said—and retired at fifty. “Wow, you really are James Marshall,” I joked. Allen corrected me. “Marshall never made a dime,” he said. “People came here and demanded he show them where this gold was, as if he had some kind of Midas touch—which, of course, he did not.” Marshall’s sawmill eventually failed, and, after investing

in an unsuccessful mine, he nearly went bankrupt. “In his old age, he would tell anybody who would listen, ‘They’re going to make a big fuss over me when I’m dead.’ And that’s exactly what happened,” Allen said. “The state of California paid nine thousand dollars for a monument to a man who died in poverty.” I looked the monument up later. I don’t know what I was expecting. It was just a bronze-ish figure of Marshall pointing at the ground.

In 1864, Mark Twain was an out-of-work journalist in San Francisco when he heard about gold deposits that had been found near Jackass Hill, a mining community, and decided to try his luck. Twain didn’t have much success prospecting, but he wrote a short story called “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County,” about the loutish, hardscrabble culture of miners. It was based on an anecdote he’d heard in Angels Camp, a nearby town, about a real-life gambler who lost a frog-jumping bet in a miner’s bar, and it launched Twain’s literary career. Twain started a trend: if gold mining didn’t “pan out” (a term that dates to the era), a person could always create gold-mining content.

The hustling spirit of the gold rush lives on today in the prospecting influencers who toil in the content mines of the Internet, hoping to hit the viral mother lode. Before my trip, I watched what seemed like an endless supply of videos, mostly of men standing knee-deep in muddy creeks, with such ostensibly click-inducing titles as “We Almost Walked Past This Rock . . . Then We Looked a Little Closer!” I came across a sizzle reel on YouTube from an outfit called 530 Gold Mining—530 is the area code for gold country—which featured drone footage of three white men walking around the Sierra Nevada with metal detectors and pickaxes to the tune of “Bet on Myself,” a royalty-free rap track.



The morning after Gold Discovery Day, I joined Israel Johnson, Steve Upton, and Mike Cleary, of 530 Gold Mining, at one of their prospecting sites off Route 49. “Do you mind not telling anyone exactly where we are?” Johnson asked. This wasn’t a problem—I had no idea. We were standing in a burn scar surrounded by incinerated trees with snarled branches and ashen trunks. The Mosquito Fire of 2022 had ravaged more than seventy-six thousand acres in Placer and El Dorado Counties. In some ways, it had been a boon to miners. “We wouldn’t have been able to get into this area otherwise,” Upton, the group’s founder, said, explaining that the terrain would have been too thick with manzanita shrubs.

A common shtick of gold-influencer videos is that, with the benefit of modern equipment, prospectors can now find treasure left behind by the forty-niners. A four-part series put out by 530 Gold Mining is called “Old Timers Missed This Spot LOADED with GOLD NUGGETS!” Highlighting spiffy detectors or waterproof sniping-wear can attract brand deals, but it is also true that there have been significant technological advances since the gold rush. Cleary told me that they use the 3-D-mapping tool lidar, an acronym for “light detection and ranging,” which can reveal anomalies in topography. In December of 2025, California’s Wildfire and Forest Resilience Task Force made a state-wide lidar map available online, imagining that it would help researchers assess biomass destruction after

wildfires. But, in historic gold-rush regions, prospectors use it to identify disturbances in the landscape that are suggestive of former mining operations, in the hope of finding overlooked stores. Cleary, a construction superintendent at Tesla, turned on a metal detector and picked up a signal. Brushing away debris, he unearthed the top of an antique-looking metal can. He said that he and his partners often find gold-rush remnants: buttons, coins, bullets.

The trio has also pored over California's vintage newspapers, which are newly digitized, to find old mining companies' reports on promising hot spots. But those leads aren't always a sure thing. "A lot of these companies were publicly traded, so they were trying to raise money," Johnson explained. "They'd embellish to attract investors." Exaggeration and gold seem to go hand in hand. A lot of prospecting YouTubers are accused of staging their videos or enhancing them with A.I. Pioneer Pauly told me that his content is authentic, although it's true that he typically posts when he gets a good haul. As he pointed out, "No one wants to watch you *not* find gold."

It took, IRL, about thirty minutes for Cleary and his metal detector to come up with a speck of gold the size of a cookie crumb. "That's worth about five dollars," he told me. Fortunately, YouTube supplements the three men's earnings. They said that they monetize their channel with ads just to offset costs (mainly gas), and that selling the gold is primarily a way to support their hobby. "At heart, most guys just enjoy digging a hole in the woods," Cleary said.

Men's interests, appetites, jawlines, leg lengths, testosterone levels, and friendships or lack thereof have been the object of feverish media attention in the past couple of years. "*Why Do Men Buy Shoes That Are Too Big?*" a recent headline in the *Times* read (one guess). In the aftermath of the 2024 election, in which Trump won fifty-six per cent of young male voters, the Democratic Party began a search for a "Joe Rogan of the left" and launched a twenty-million-dollar project called "Speaking with American Men: A Strategic Plan." Yet, amid all this anthropological interest in male behavior, a world beloved by men that is organized around the legacy of kings and a single precious metal has been hiding in plain sight, like a white Wakanda.

The Discovery Channel has become appointment viewing for men aged twenty-five to fifty-four, powered by the network's cache of gold-mining reality series. The ur-show of Discovery's gold programming, "Gold Rush," premiered in December, 2010. It opens with a man named Todd Hoffman and his father, Jack, at their small airfield, in Sandy, Oregon. A voice-over says, "The recession has decimated the aviation industry," as father and son eye gold prices on a cellphone. In preparation for the Alaskan wilderness, the Hoffmans and their crew shop for bear guns, bid their wives farewell, and are prayed over by a local pastor (who decides, at the last minute, to join them). Jack, in a rousing speech, tells them, "You're all millionaires. The only thing is, you got to get it out of the ground." Five months and ten episodes later, the men's total tally was more like twenty thousand dollars, and even reaching that amount had, at times, seemed unlikely. During negotiations, an executive at Discovery had wanted the men to find gold by Episode 5. "We were never going to do that," Sam Maynard, a showrunner on the series, told me. "The real strength of the show wasn't gold—it was about the *promise* of gold."



I was surprised to learn that it was Hoffman who pitched the show. Inspired by extreme-job-themed reality programs like "Deadliest Catch" and "American Chopper," he thought he'd get a deal on mining equipment if brands knew that their products would be on TV. Hoffman had no

Hollywood connections but saw a casting call for “people who thought they could survive an apocalypse.” It had been sent out by Maynard, who was developing a docudrama called “After Armageddon,” loosely based on Cormac McCarthy’s dystopian novel “The Road,” for Raw TV, a British production company. Maynard was taken with Hoffman, whom he described to me as a “Svengali-like character,” and flew to Alaska to start shooting. “Gold Rush” was an instant blockbuster. “I remember when we beat ‘Shark Tank,’ ” Hoffman said. “It’s Middle America, that’s the fan base. It’s blue-collar guys who want to come home, crack open a beer, and go on an adventure.”

“Gold Rush” is still the network’s highest-rated program. Its breakout star is Parker Schnabel, a thirty-one-year-old who runs a placer mine in the Yukon that brought in fifty-one million dollars last year. Young, rich, and telegenic—he bears a striking resemblance to the actor Adam Driver—he’s been interviewed by *People* about his love life; he told the magazine that he had trouble explaining his job to dates “in a way that doesn’t sound like Mad Max.” When we spoke, he sounded more like Pioneer Ken, casually dropping that his family was run out of Kansas for making “bootleg moonshine during Prohibition” and that his grandfather “put everything he owned into a wooden box, got on a steamship in 1938, and moved to Alaska.”

In a harrowing “Gold Rush” scene, the British production crew nearly drowns amid a river torrent as Todd Hoffman grumbles to the camera, “They’re from London.” He told me, “A lot of them don’t even own a vehicle. They take the tube. They call it ‘the tube.’ ” “Gold Rush” may be unscripted, but it is telling a particular story of *American* masculinity.

The show has its critics, who see it as settler cosplay and plunder porn. The environmental historian Brian Leech has categorized it as “Macho TV,” a genre that features “mostly heterosexual white men, joining in small bands, braving extreme conditions, and practicing the tough work of natural-resource extraction.” But that prototype is resonating. “Men have kind of lost their way,” Maynard said. “They don’t make stuff with their hands anymore. They don’t take stuff out of the ground anymore. This show is about the sense of men’s worth in the physical world, and that worth is

encapsulated in this incredibly shiny metal that has been coveted by so many people for centuries and centuries—you know, for millennia.”

No one has tapped into the id of disaffected young men nostalgic for a bygone era as effectively as Donald Trump, who announced his first candidacy by descending the golden escalators of Trump Tower. He’s never seen a contradiction between his gilded surroundings (which now include the redecorated Oval Office) and his man-of-the-people political posturing. His hotel in Las Vegas glistens like a vertical gold bar. On the website of the Trump Store, you can buy—from the Golden Age of America collection—a gold Mar-a-Lago serving tray or a pickleball paddle emblazoned, in gold, with the Trump crest. (“Make your next round of pickleball a golden one!”) Trump’s obsession with gold has led his critics to compare him to the Bond villain Goldfinger, a bullion dealer who hatches a plan to irradiate the gold in Fort Knox in order to increase the value of his own supply. Trump once told reporters on Air Force One that he and Elon Musk were going to inspect “the fabled Fort Knox, to make sure the gold is there.” He added, “If the gold isn’t there, we’re going to be very upset.”

I always figured that Trump’s relationship to gold was purely decorative. The metal’s association with kings melds perfectly with his conception of himself as one. But the right’s relationship to gold predates its latest, and loudest, spokesperson. President Richard Nixon took the United States off the gold standard on August 15, 1971—what the historian Quinn Slobodian calls “Day X for goldbugs” in his book “Hayek’s Bastards: Race, Gold, IQ, and the Capitalism of the Far Right.” In the early seventies, goldbugs were “catastrophe libertarians,” Slobodian writes—survivalist Republicans typified by the politician Ron Paul. Newsletters such as *The Ron Paul Survival Report* warned that without gold politicians would be free to print unlimited dollars for entitlement programs. One report claimed that Haitians, lured by Bill Clinton, were “now building boats to sail to the United States of Welfaria.” (Paul has since denied writing these reports, or even reading them at the time.)



“I mean, this is all bullshit,” Slobodian, who teaches at Boston University, told me. “But the ‘great replacement’ theory requires a means of payment.” Goldbug ideology has received an intellectual sheen from places like George Mason University, a libertarian stronghold, where the Koch brothers have invested millions of dollars into research, including on gold and cryptocurrency. Today’s goldbugs commune at the annual FreedomFest conference, in Las Vegas, which offers such panels as “Bitcoin vs. Gold.”

When Trump was running for President in 2016, he told *GQ*, “Bringing back the gold standard would be very hard to do, but boy, would it be wonderful.” That is unlikely to happen, but Trump’s erratic policymaking and trade wars have given gold a different kind of currency. Barry Eichengreen, a professor of economics at the University of California, Berkeley, and the author of “Money Beyond Borders: Global Currencies from Croesus to Crypto,” said that central banks in developing countries tend to buy gold when they lose confidence in the U.S. dollar: “They’re questioning whether the U.S. is a reliable economic, political, financial partner.” But that wasn’t enough, he cautioned, to explain gold’s stratospheric rise. “I would say no one knows why the price of gold has gone up by as much as it has in the past two years, but people tell stories,” he said.

Trump's allies on the political right, here and abroad, have profited from the story of gold as a safe haven in a world threatened by currency-printing globalists. In the United Kingdom, attendees at last year's conference of the Reform Party were greeted by a cardboard cutout of the Party's leader, Nigel Farage, holding up a gold coin as a spokesperson for the precious-metal dealer Direct Bullion. Stateside, Donald Trump, Jr., a First Son and the host of the podcast "Triggered," has partnered with a company called Birch Gold Group, which helps you "convert your 401(k) into gold." It sells a gold bar engraved with a picture of a miner in overalls panning in a river; on the back, it reads "Credit Suisse."

Other than branding, what does a gold bar today have to do with the California gold rush? I couldn't imagine that any of these people, let alone someone whose diapers were probably changed on a golden changing table, knew what a sluice box was. But the Old West provides what the Harvard scholar Svetlana Boym has referred to as a "usable past." Boym, who was born in Russia, argued that Vladimir Putin and his political allies came to power by fostering nostalgia for an orderly Soviet superstate after the economic turbulence of the nineties. The forty-niners are elemental to our identity as a nation of brave, rugged individualists. Even Luke Skywalker dons a pair of beige Levi's—transformed from a miner's uniform into a symbol of rebellious cool by the likes of James Dean—to blend in with the desert sands of Tatooine, a former mining outpost. Slobodian told me that twenty-first-century goldbugs, who mingle with tech founders and bitcoin barons, "fetishize the idea of the supposedly lawless West"—a place without pesky government regulation. The amateur miners I spoke to also romanticized the Old West, but they saw in its lack of rules a chance to upend the status quo. Johnson, of 530 Mining, said he believed that the gold rush was the "first time in human history that ordinary people could touch gold. Before then, it was only for kings." Industrial gold mining, a forty-three-billion-dollar market in North America, has also realized the power of nostalgia. This year, three mining corporations looking to expand their operations sponsored, for the first time, Calico California Days, a festival at Calico Ghost Town with pretend panning and gun-drawing contests.



This isn't a history that everyone is nostalgic for. In 2022, a pair of Levi's from the eighteen-eighties, discovered in a mine shaft in New Mexico, were auctioned off; a label inside read "the only kind made by white labor." During the gold rush, politicians stoked xenophobia and pitted workers against workers, leading to the passage of the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, which effectively barred immigration to the United States from China for sixty-one years. The James Marshall monument was built at the urging of Native Sons of the Golden West, a fraternal organization devoted to preserving California's settler past; members had to be white men born in the state.

"For us, the gold rush didn't end," Brian Wallace, a member of the Washoe and Nisenan tribes, told me. Wallace is the C.E.O. of the Indigenous Futures Society, formerly the Sierra Fund. I.F.S. advocates for Indigenous ecological practices, such as controlled burns, that were erased during the gold rush. "It was a state-sponsored clearing of the land, and, in doing so, there was a systematic destruction of the ecologies that Indigenous people had stewarded for millennia," he said. During the rush, under California's first governor, the state legislature funded local militias that systematically killed sixteen thousand Native Americans, opening the territory for white settlers. More than a hundred thousand died of disease and starvation, as their waterways and other food sources were overtaken by miners. "It was a

genocide,” Governor Gavin Newsom said, in 2019. “No other way to describe it, and that’s the way it needs to be described in the history books.”

Scrolling through old newspapers like the *Mountain Democrat*, I saw ads for quicksilver, or mercury. Back then, an estimated twenty-six million pounds of mercury was used in hard-rock and hydraulic mining. During rainstorms, it is carried into rivers and other bodies of water, where it turns into methylmercury, contaminating the fish population. The Sierra Fund treated a mine site with biochar, a carbon-rich form of charcoal that can bind to mercury, containing it in place. Wallace told me that he was sympathetic to parents who wanted to take their kids out panning as a screen-free weekend activity but thought that there were other ways of communing with nature. “Let’s look forward, not backward,” he said.

Why can’t we stop looking back? In “Where I Was From,” Joan Didion writes about her maternal grandfather, whose family “migrated from the hardscrabble Adirondack frontier of the eighteenth century to the hardscrabble Sierra Nevada foothills in the nineteenth.” He once wrote a letter to the editor of a fifth-grade textbook, frustrated to see the story of California told as a “sunny progression from Spanish Señorita to Gold Miner to Golden Gate Bridge.” What incensed him, Didion writes, was the suggestion that the settlement of California had been “easy.”

So many of the miners I talked to emphasized the difficulty of their work, a difficulty they took on themselves, as a point of pride. Some were still ruffled by a successful effort, in 2015, by environmentalist and tribal groups, to ban suction-dredge mining, a vacuum-powered technology that greatly disturbs riverbed soil, releasing mercury into the water. At a hearing of the California state legislature on the issue, a miner protested, “We make an honest living!” I wanted to dismiss that posture as science denialism tinged with macho bravado. But then I imagined how I’d feel living near Silicon Valley, whose billionaire class shows up clean-shaven and well rested at Davos to pitch toxic, water-draining A.I. data centers. (Then, there’s the U.S. Mint, which sells a billion dollars in gold coins annually. A recent *Times* investigation uncovered that the Mint, which is mandated to use American gold to avoid complicity in human-rights abuses and environmental destruction, has, for decades, been loose in its sourcing, and ended up

minting coins with gold that can be traced to an illegal mine run by a Colombian drug cartel.)

I hadn't got my hands dirty, either, and the miners I spoke to told me that if I wanted to understand gold's magnetism I'd need to find some myself. At Placerville Hardware, Fausel had shown me a row of trading cards of great contemporary miners. One depicted a man named Kevin Hoagland, who had a friendly smile and a long white beard. Fausel said that if anyone could help me it was Hoagland, who lives in Arizona and writes a column for *Gold Prospectors* magazine called "Where's the Gold?" When I told Fausel that I already had plans to meet Hoagland, he gave me a clear plastic case to fill with nuggets.



A few days later, I was sitting across from Hoagland, who's sixty-four, at the breakfast buffet of the Best Western in Wickenburg, Arizona, as he told me about the first time he saw gold. He was seven years old and wandering around the Mojave Desert, where he was staying with family, when he heard a chugging sound and saw dirt flying into the air from behind a hill. He ran toward the noise and found a man operating what he called a "hand-crank dry washer with an old galvanized tub." The man shook a rusted old pan filled with black sand, and a string of yellowish pebbles appeared. He asked Hoagland if he knew what it was, and then answered for him: "Eternity."

Hoagland was hooked. His mother bought him a build-your-own-metal-detector-kit, but after putting it together he determined that it wasn't powerful enough, so he went to RadioShack. "I was constantly driving those guys crazy," he said. "I was, like, 'I need this to be able to have a lower field response.' " Hoagland, who still works as a professional miner, leads a class called Gold Trails, for the Gold Prospectors Association of America; he had agreed to give me a crash course. He also hosts a podcast, "On the Gold," and just finished a novel—"a murder mystery," he told me, about an Irish family killed during the gold rush. He appeared on "Mine Rescue with Freddy & Juan," helping an amateur miner who'd lost his day job during the pandemic turn his hobby into a career. Gold is in Hoagland's bones. He's had almost two grams of it injected into his knees, an F.D.A.-approved treatment for rheumatoid arthritis. "I'm going to be cremated, and little bits of my ashes are going to go to all my friends," he said. "They're going to pan me out at different places in the United States."

Hoagland drove us in his Jeep to his claim in the Sonoran Desert. On the way, we stopped in Stanton, established in 1863, a former ghost town that's been revived by the Lost Dutchman's Mining Association, whose members camp there in R.V.s. They play a weekly bingo game in the old opera house; the prize is pay dirt. Back on the unpaved road, we saw a jackrabbit, wild horses, and a petrified cactus, and briefly got stuck in quicksand. "I'm flooring it, and we're barely moving," Hoagland said. When we finally arrived at the claim, a patch of land on a hillside, I got out of the Jeep. I was about to pick up an interesting-looking rock when Hoagland said, "That's cow dung." He continued, "And if you're stranded overnight the best thing you can do is go out and find a bunch of it, put it in a pile, put rocks around it, and light it, because it'll give you a good hot fire." I made a mental note to do that if I couldn't find a cactus needle to jam into my jugular first.

Hoagland handed me a small metal detector—the Minelab Gold Monster 2000—and began his lesson. He told me the only thing that moves gold across the landscape is water, so we were looking for signs of rain and flooding: trails strewn with natural debris like twigs, bushes blanched by too much hydration, disturbances in the terrain. I scanned the landscape; it looked to me like we were standing on a random hill. Hoagland told me to stop thinking. "I come out here, and I'm reciting Blake's 'Tyger Tyger, burning bright,' " he said.

The sun was beating down on me. I had stupidly not picked up a bottle of water from the ghost-town community fridge. As we walked around, I noticed two grayish bushes next to a rock. I wondered if gold might have got trapped behind the rock as water flowed down the hill. I placed my Minelab Gold Monster on the ground, tried to quiet my mind, and listened. The detector emitted a wave-like sound, which, as I moved to the other side of the rock, got louder and louder. I set the detector aside and started digging, grabbing clumps of dirt with my hand and testing each clump beneath the detector until I heard what sounded like a heart about to explode. “Son of a bitch!” Hoagland said. “Gold!” I screamed.

In the palm of my hand, I held a tiny, craggy nugget. The 530 guys had told me that the first thing I would notice about gold was its heaviness, and I felt the weight of it now, in every sense. Here it was, this relic of the past, being dug up by Americans hoping for a better future, their dreams mined once again by speculators and magnates—a cycle that I hoped wouldn’t last for eternity. On the way back to my hotel, Hoagland told me that he couldn’t believe how quickly I had found gold. “Oh,” I said. “Well, I’m half Irish.” ♦

A Reporter at Large

Barack Obama Considers His Role in the Age of Trump

The former President remains one of the most popular politicians in the country. What are his obligations to it?

By Peter Slevin

May 04, 2026



In Barack Obama's final days in office, he found himself in the painful position of trying to console his staff, the Democratic Party, and millions of supporters. He attempted to convince them—even if he could not entirely convince himself—that the looming Presidency of Donald Trump was not a national calamity. In the past, he would say, the country had endured slavery, the Civil War, the Great Depression, Jim Crow, assassinations. And, though Trump was alarming in many ways, America was blessed by the strength of its institutions and the resilience of its people. The word “guardrails” was uttered constantly. In Obama's estimation, Trump would not erase all his achievements. As he put it, “Maybe fifteen per cent of that gets rolled back.”

This kind of calm was pure Obama. His appeal had as much to do with character and temperament as it did with his center-left ideology. Although Obama believed that Trump's ugliest slurs against him, particularly his deployment of the birther theory, were a racist outrage that heightened the threats against him and his family, he now took pains to set aside his contempt. Insuring that there was another orderly transition of power—that, too, was part of his rhetoric of consolation.

Such poise was not easy to sustain. When Obama met Trump for a ritual pre-Inauguration visit to the Oval Office, he was struck by how unschooled and incurious the President-elect was. Trump, Obama told people, seemed indifferent to hearing about potential national-security perils—North Korea, Russia—preferring to brag about the size of the crowds at his campaign rallies. Obama pitched Trump on preserving several of his signature achievements, including the Affordable Care Act and the Iran nuclear deal. Trump responded that he would consider the request, and Obama thought it was not impossible that he meant it.

Obama travelled to Greece and spoke about the virtues of democracy; he thanked the people who had worked on his campaigns and his supporters. With a Trump Presidency ahead, these were wearing performances. And so, to provide some relief and release, Obama also put on a series of upbeat valedictory events at the White House. Bruce Springsteen, a friend of the Obamas', played an acoustic concert for staff in the East Room. He dedicated "Tougher Than the Rest" to Barack and Michelle and ended by playing an anthem of American inclusiveness, "Land of Hope and Dreams." Obama, who had started thinking about his memoirs, hosted a lunch with some of his favorite writers: Zadie Smith, Junot Díaz, Barbara Kingsolver, Colson Whitehead, and Dave Eggers. "What surprised me was how completely unbowed President Obama was, how certain he was that the country would find its way," Díaz later wrote. "He burned with optimism and faith invincible."

The most exuberant farewell event—a dance party at the White House—took place on January 6th. It was a freezing night, and people shivered outside as they waited to get past security. There were campaign donors and loyal staffers in the crowd, but also a starry list of entertainment executives, musicians, actors, and athletes: Barry Diller, Oprah Winfrey, John Legend

and Chrissy Teigen, Paul McCartney, George Clooney, Robert De Niro, Meryl Streep, Magic Johnson. Questlove was the music director. Stevie Wonder and Solange performed. The Electric Slide was danced, with Michelle Obama very much in the lead. As dawn approached, chicken and waffles were served.

“There was laughing, there was loving, there was hugs,” Chance the Rapper said in a video he posted at 4:33 A.M. “It was historic, it was Black, it was beautiful.” And yet there were distinctly mixed emotions at the party, and it was no mystery why: the first Black President was being replaced by someone who had expressed little but scorn for him. Janelle Monáe, leaving the dance floor in a lather of sweat, told someone why she had kept at it for so long. “That’s easy,” she said. “No way I’m getting invited back to *this* house anytime soon.”

Years later, Sharon Malone, a Washington doctor and the wife of the former Attorney General Eric Holder, said, about that night, “You realized that an era was coming to an end, and it was the last moment of joy we were going to have in that White House.” She added, “We were making the best of a bad situation.”



Ten days before Trump moved in, Obama flew to Chicago, where he had launched his political career, to deliver a speech that laid out his case for why the country was where it was. Rising economic inequality had sparked the cynicism and polarization that lifted Trump into office, he said. He called on different ethnic and racial groups to listen to one another from a position of trust, and to build a new social contract. “We all have to try harder,” he said. “We all have to start with the premise that each of our fellow-citizens loves this country just as much as we do.” He finished with a promise about the battles ahead: “I will be right there with you, as a citizen, for all of my remaining days.”

A few weeks ago, I spoke to Obama about how he’s spent the past decade—and whether events have shaken the confidence that he expressed in that farewell speech. “I would be dishonest if I didn’t acknowledge that,” he replied. How Obama has used his time—including since Trump returned to office—says much about how he sees his role, its potential and its limits.

On January 20, 2017, as Donald Trump was being sworn in as the forty-fifth President, the Obamas sat on the reviewing stand. Michelle noted the predominantly white and male faces around them. At some point, she stopped even trying to smile. “There was no color on that stage,” she said later. “There was no reflection of the broader sense of America.”

After the new President delivered his “American carnage” speech—a dark address that led George W. Bush to note, “That was some weird shit”—the Obamas flew by helicopter to Joint Base Andrews, where they boarded a plane that took them to Palm Springs for a vacation. On the flight, Michelle sobbed uncontrollably for a half hour. “It was just the release of eight years of trying to do everything perfectly,” she said in an onstage interview with Winfrey in 2018. “I said to Barack, ‘That was so hard. What we just did was so hard, and I’ve wanted to say that for eight years.’ ” No small part of the pressure they felt was the threat of violence. According to the *Washington Post*, the Secret Service assessed that the Obamas had faced three times as many threats as previous First Families. One night in 2011, a gunman fired seven shots that hit the White House; one struck ballistic glass on the Truman Balcony, where the Obamas often sat.

Despite the drama of Trump's victory, Obama left office proud of his Administration's achievements: the economic recovery, the rescue of the auto industry, the Affordable Care Act, the Paris climate accord, the legalization of gay marriage, the Iran nuclear deal, the restoration of diplomatic relations with Cuba. But he relished the prospect of a new life. He told me that, during his time in the White House, he had a recurring dream about sitting on a park bench unattended, or stopping by a bodega unrecognized. "Captivity," he said, was the hardest part of the job. "That loss of anonymity is profound, and you don't get it back." Still, to be free of the pressures of the position, and to enjoy the perks of having been an enormously popular President—well, that had its appeal. John Updike once published a short, wry essay in this magazine arguing that the American Presidency "is merely a way station en route to the blessed condition of being an ex-President." Obama might agree on some days. Even before leaving the White House, he often joked with friends that "the best job in the world is ex-President."

In this, Obama had myriad examples, to embrace or avoid. George Washington returned to Mount Vernon and established a profitable whiskey distillery. Thomas Jefferson founded and built the University of Virginia. John Quincy Adams, who once remarked that "there is nothing more pathetic in life than a former President," found satisfaction back in the House of Representatives, where he was a voice for the abolition of slavery. In debt and terminally ill, Ulysses S. Grant rescued his family's finances by selling his memoirs to his publisher and editor, Mark Twain. William Howard Taft became Chief Justice of the United States. Herbert Hoover helped direct the restructuring of the executive branch but also revelled in his leisure. ("All men are equal before fish," he wrote in "Fishing for Fun," a cheerful angling memoir.) The most idealistic former President was surely Jimmy Carter, whose projects ranged from building housing for the poor to battling to eradicate guinea-worm disease in Africa. "I can't deny I'm a better ex-President than I was a President," he once said.



At first, Obama's plan was to recover and spend time with Michelle and their daughters, Malia and Sasha, far from the political fray. In those early days, the Obamas slept late. They read, they worked out, they travelled. Barack recognized the need for some marital rebalancing. "I had a big deficit with my wife and had to kind of work my way out," he said last year, on Marc Maron's podcast. But at the same time, he recalled, he started thinking, "What's my next highest and best use, and what's a new purpose that scratches that itch?"

Obama went on to build a Presidential center, in Chicago, that reflects his commitment to grassroots organizing. Slated to open this spring, on Juneteenth, it will be the headquarters of the Obama Foundation, a sprawling training and networking operation for young leaders that has been his primary focus since leaving the White House. In politics, he transitioned to mentoring and advising younger Democrats and joining candidates on the campaign trail each election cycle.

He also set out to make serious money. In March, 2017, the Obamas signed a sixty-five-[million](#)-dollar joint book deal with Penguin Random House. Obama had written books before, but he found the composition of Presidential memoirs slow going. He published the first volume, "A Promised Land," in 2020. (It was excerpted in these pages.) He told me that

he intends for the second volume to come out later this year. Michelle had more immediate success. A memoir, “Becoming,” was released in 2018 and sold more than seventeen million copies, earning back the publisher’s advance and then some. Her book tour sold out about thirty arenas, including Chicago’s United Center, where fourteen thousand people paid to see her in conversation with Winfrey. Barack and Michelle have since published several more best-selling titles.

The Obamas no longer need to make their tax returns public. There is no knowing how much money they’ve made in the past nine years—or how much money they’ve given to charity—but their receipts certainly reach nine figures, from book sales, speeches, and deals with Netflix, Spotify, and Audible. Over time, they have built a considerable real-estate portfolio. They still own the house in Chicago where they lived when Obama was in the U.S. Senate. Shortly after leaving the White House, they spent \$8.1 million on a home in the Kalorama neighborhood of Washington, D.C. Six years ago, they bought an \$11.75-million waterfront estate on Martha’s Vineyard from an owner of the Boston Celtics. They also built a beachfront house on the Hawaiian island of Oahu.

As the Trump Administration began to assert itself with such policies as the Muslim ban and family separation, even some of Obama’s most loyal constituents grew frustrated with the ex-President’s luxurious vacations. In February of 2017, the British business magnate Richard Branson posted photos of Obama learning to kite surf off Branson’s private island, in the Caribbean. The comedian John Oliver said, “Just tone it down with the kitesurfing pictures. I’m glad he’s having a nice time. America is on fire.” A few months later, the Obamas were photographed in Tahiti on David Geffen’s yacht, along with Springsteen, Winfrey, and Tom Hanks.



The Obamas' travels became regular tabloid fodder. Summers playing golf on the Vineyard. A spin along the Italian Riviera on Steven Spielberg's yacht. Well-paid speeches in foreign capitals (with V.I.P. packages selling for more than two thousand dollars apiece). In 2023, at a Springsteen performance in Barcelona, Michelle picked up a tambourine and joined the band onstage for "Glory Days." ("How cool is my wife?" Barack said from the wings.)

Meanwhile, the American prospect darkened. The daily outrages of Trump's first term and the January 6th insurrection were followed by Joe Biden's belated withdrawal from the 2024 race and Kamala Harris's frantic hundred-day campaign. Trump's second term has proved so radical that officials from his first Administration—including a former chief of staff and a former chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff—have referred to him as a fascist. And the worse things got, the more you heard the question "Where is Obama?"

Obama's first Presidential campaign was ignited by his opposition to George W. Bush's war in Iraq. And yet, when Obama won the Presidency, Bush greeted him with graceful comments of welcome, and then embarked on a retirement characterized by reticence. He raised money for a library, took up painting, and kept his mouth shut. "He deserves my silence," Bush said at the time. "I think it's time for the ex-President to tap-dance off the stage and

let the current President have a go at solving the world's problems." In fact, Bush proved to be a friend to the Obamas, despite their political differences.

In the modern Presidency, it has not been uncommon for old rivals to confide in one another. On the night that John F. Kennedy was assassinated, Lyndon Johnson, after being sworn in to office, called Dwight Eisenhower and said, "I need you more than ever now." Eisenhower visited him in the Oval Office and wrote out on a legal pad what he thought Johnson should tell an emergency session of Congress. Richard Nixon dispensed political wisdom about Russian leadership to Bill Clinton. Truman once said, "There is no conversation so sweet as that of former political enemies." But this is yet another Presidential norm that has collapsed: since entering the White House, Trump has never called Obama. (Trump, in turn, has not been invited to the opening of Obama's Presidential center.)

In the final press conference of his Presidency, Obama said, "I want to be quiet a little bit and not hear myself talk so darn much." He expected to speak out only in "certain moments where I think our core values may be at stake." Representative Pramila Jayapal, a Democrat from Washington State, told me that during Trump's first term she often wondered, of Obama, "Why isn't he out here?" She understood the former President's desire to take a break after his White House years, but as the picture grew grimmer, she said, she heard friends and constituents comment, "Our country's being destroyed, and you're doing your Netflix thing and your Hawaii thing?" She went on, "I still remember his speech on race and singing 'Amazing Grace' in the South Carolina church. There were these moments when he was able to grab the attention of the country. What if he had done that in a way that gave people a North Star at these really difficult moments?"

I heard similarly plaintive remarks from some former Obama staffers. Cornell Belcher, who was a member of Obama's polling team during his two Presidential campaigns, told me that he sees an imperative for Obama to work against "forces of darkness—not because they're Republican but because they're anti-democratic." Belcher thinks that the 2026 midterm elections will be won not just on pocketbook issues but on values and character, and by bringing people together in a multiracial coalition. "This moment calls for him to take a better and bigger position," Belcher said. "We need a return of the Jedi."



It's not just the commentariat asking. "We don't see him much, truthfully. I wish we could see him more," Jack Kahn, a real-estate manager who heard Obama speak at a New Jersey campaign rally last year, said. "He should tell people to have faith, to stick together, to get things to swing back in the right direction."

Obama's popularity is immense. A Gallup survey last year found that he was seen favorably by ninety-six per cent of Democrats. When the Institute for Family Studies, a conservative think tank, asked two thousand young men last year whom they most looked up to in the worlds of politics, entertainment, religion, and tech, Obama came out on top. John Della Volpe, who directs polling at Harvard's Institute of Politics, conducted a survey for a private research firm he runs and found that Obama's favorability rating among young people was sixty-four per cent, with only eleven per cent seeing him very unfavorably. Obama's standing, Della Volpe told me, is "literally the opposite of where Trump and other Democrats are right now."

But, as popular as Obama is in many circles, Democrats are divided on whether he is an appropriate avatar for the Party as it labors to advance new leaders. "Is it realistic to think that Obama—on the horizon, rising from the ashes—is going to lead us forward?" Senator Tina Smith, a Minnesota Democrat, said. "I would say that we are all a little naïve if we think that can

happen again. There's nostalgia for him. Yet—how can I put this?—in the political world that I'm in, there is an understanding that we are in a different time.” As she thought about the pleas for Obama to assert himself more in the public arena, she recalled a piece of wisdom often attributed to H. L. Mencken: For every complicated question, there's an easy answer that's almost always neat, plausible, and wrong.

Maurice Mitchell, the national director of the Working Families Party, which operates to the left of much of the Democratic leadership, sees Obama as a “rich, famous guy.” But Mitchell points out that the former President still commands “tremendous trust” from a large portion of the electorate. He said that he wished Obama were making a more robust effort to expand the progressive coalition. “This is a time to be part of the united front against fascism,” Mitchell told me. “What he could do, and I think few people could do, is signal that disruptive, insurgent leadership is actually a requirement in this moment.”

Presidents once devoted life after the White House to living peaceably, under a “vine and fig tree,” as George Washington put it. “Obama is in a position that no other President has really faced,” David Axelrod, who helped engineer Obama's political ascent, said. “Because people are so desperate for leadership at a time when they feel like Trump is running amok, they turn backward and say, ‘You know, Obama should be that guy.’ He's still searching for just the right formula.”

I met with Obama at his new Presidential center, on the South Side of Chicago. He is sixty-four, and his close-cropped hair has grayed. He has also made that terrible, if inevitable, transition of late middle age from the joy of sports to the obligation of exercise. There is a basketball court in the new complex, but he conceded, “I've hung up my full-court game out of concern for popping my Achilles. When I left the Oval Office, I thought, ‘I've been pressing my luck.’”

In our conversation, Obama made it plain that he no longer harbors illusions about the nature of the Trump Presidency. His early prediction that Trump was capable of rolling back only a modest percentage of Obama's achievements, and that political norms would prevail, has not remotely proved to be the case. Trump has used the Justice Department to prosecute

his political enemies. He has politicized the Pentagon. He flouts every definition of political decency as he threatens to bomb Iran back “to the Stone Ages.” Yet what, exactly, can Obama do about it? As he called out to a heckler last year, “Sir, I’m not the President of the United States currently. So there’s no point in shouting at me.” In other moments, he compares himself to Michael Corleone, in the “Godfather” movies, who never quite manages to escape the family business, and says, “Just when I thought I was out, they pull me back in.”

I asked Obama whether he considers what else he could do. “I think about it every day,” he said. He believes that if he spoke out much more often—if he tried to combat every outrageous utterance and misbegotten policy from the Trump White House—he would quickly diminish his impact.

“For me to function like Jon Stewart, even once a week, just going off, just ripping what was happening—which, by the way, I’m glad Jon’s doing it—then I’m not a political leader, I’m a commentator,” Obama told me. In fact, he insisted, he is doing more than people realize. “The media environment is so difficult that people don’t even know all the stuff I am doing, right?” he said. “And, I think, when they do see me, then the sense is Well, why isn’t he doing that every day instead of just during a midterm election, or during a referendum campaign around gerrymandering, or what have you?”

Trump’s recklessness has drawn Obama to work in politics “more than I would have preferred,” he said. He has campaigned around the country in each election cycle since leaving office. He has hosted fund-raisers and recorded dozens of video ads and robocalls. When he talks about his role in helping to oppose Trump, he argues that his influence should be gauged not only by the number of speeches he gives or by his appearances in legacy news outlets but also by the audiences he reaches in other ways. He markets Netflix projects that carry messages of liberal uplift. He has met with numerous podcasters and influencers. (His senior adviser Eric Schultz referred to this as showing up “in unexpected places.”) He has spoken with the twenty-seven-year-old Uruguayan American Carlos Eduardo Espina, who has more than twenty-two million followers across platforms and gets billions of views a year on TikTok. He has sat down with Victor Fontanez, a heavily tattooed young barber and influencer better known as VicBlends. Fontanez interviewed Obama in 2024 while giving him a haircut—a

conversation that got more than twenty-four million views on TikTok. A talk with Hasan Minhaj drew more than 8.5 million YouTube views.

“People who are going to be decisive in elections going forward do not seek out information about politics—they *encounter* it,” David Plouffe, Obama’s longtime strategist, told me. “Obama will talk about things, and there will be video clips that are interesting to people, because it’s not like a droning on in a political speech.”

Still, Obama parcels his time with care. He told me that the demands of his schedule are of great concern to Michelle: “She wants to see her husband easing up and spending more time with her, enjoying what remains of our lives.” Of the pressure on him to be on the campaign circuit, he said, “It does create a genuine tension in our household, and it frustrates her. I’m more forgiving of it, in the sense that I understand why people feel that way, because people aren’t looking at me in historical comparison to other Presidents. They don’t care about the fact that no other ex-President was the main surrogate for the Party for four election cycles after they left office.”

Ever the optimist, Obama shifted out of his defensive posture. “The fact that people want me to be ‘doing more’ is a *good* sign,” he said. It indicates that “there has not been as decided a shift in American attitudes as we are making out. And that’s part of the reason people are frustrated. Sometimes it’s directed toward me, which is fine because they kind of sense, Wait, how can we be doing this when I know that’s not who we were? And I don’t think it’s really who we are now.”

“When George Bush was elected, it was very close,” Obama continued. “I think there was a *Zeitgeist* of, like, You know what? We’re kind of in a conservative mood. We went through the Clinton years, and now we kind of want this change. And then, when I was elected, I think there was a genuine shift in attitudes. You look at surveys—people had become more progressive around a whole host of issues that had been divisive. I think it’s fair to say there’s some shift that took place between when I left office, in 2016, and today. There was maybe some marginal overreach—or, at least, people weren’t ready to go as far as the Twitter left wanted to go on certain issues. But you look at surveys, it’s not like suddenly people said, you know, ‘We

don't believe in gay marriage.' They didn't suddenly say, 'Yeah, we think it's O.K. to discriminate on race.' ”

Obama has encountered Trump in person from time to time, most recently at Jimmy Carter's funeral, in January of 2025, when they sat chatting amiably before the service. It is not lost on the Obamas that Trump continues to show them disdain, often referring to Obama as Barack *Hussein* Obama, as if to suggest otherness. Last year, he said that Obama was guilty of “treason” and unspooled a conspiracy theory that Obama had manipulated intelligence in an attempt to undermine Trump's election in 2016. “One of the greatest political scandals in American history,” Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, called it. “A years-long coup,” Tulsi Gabbard, Trump's director of National Intelligence, added. The President [posted](#) a fake video of himself smiling as Obama was arrested by the F.B.I. The accusations provoked a rare, testy reaction from Obama. “Our office does not normally dignify the constant nonsense and misinformation flowing out of this White House with a response,” a spokesman [said](#). “But these claims are outrageous enough to merit one. These bizarre allegations are ridiculous and a weak attempt at distraction.” More recently, Trump's Truth Social account shared a racist video depicting the Obamas as apes. Leavitt called criticism of the video “fake outrage.”

“I don't take it personally,” Obama told me. “I mean, I'm always offended when my wife and kids get dragged into things, because they didn't choose this. . . . That's a line that even people whose politics I deeply reject, I would expect them to care about. I would never talk about somebody's family in that way.” Obama said he was more concerned about A.I.-generated videos Trump has posted that treat war “like a video game” and show “excrement dumped on ordinary citizens.” Obama laughed ruefully. “I mean, I'm a fair target in the sense of, yeah, you can feel free to pick on me, because I'm your own size,” he said.



Obama speaks about affronts in a register of deliberate calm. Still, he has said that the country is in “a political crisis of the sort we haven’t seen before.” He told me that, when people ask him whether he sees the *MAGA* movement and Trump’s consolidation of power in Washington as a repudiation of his Presidency, he replies, “ ‘No, actually, sixty per cent of the country still agrees with me.’ So I don’t take it personally. But it does remind me of the fact that if you have an activated and empowered right wing that first captures the Republican Party and then gets ahold of the federal government, that can do a lot of damage pretty quickly.” Obama described himself as “dismayed” by Congress’s obedience to Trump and by the Administration’s disregard for democratic fundamentals. “We believe in voting and elections, and we believe in democracy—even though we don’t always exercise it perfectly, at least we try to fake it,” he said. “We believe in not politicizing the criminal-justice system or politicizing the military.”

In fact, there is little that Obama has left unsaid about Trump in the past fifteen years. He and Michelle had prime-time roles at the Democratic National Conventions in 2020 and 2024, where they made clear their abhorrence of the man who rose to political prominence through his lies about Obama’s birth and, once in office, laid waste to so many values that they had done their best to honor. Michelle has felt particularly liberated in speaking her mind. At the 2024 Convention, she posed a stark question

about Trump: “Who’s going to tell him that the job he is currently seeking might just be one of those ‘Black jobs’?”

“It’s his same old con,” she continued. “Doubling down on ugly, misogynistic, racist lies as a substitute for real ideas and solutions that will actually make people’s lives better.”

At the same Convention, Barack Obama called the modern G.O.P. “a cult of personality.” Trump, he said, “hasn’t stopped whining about his problems since he rode down his golden escalator nine years ago. . . . There’s the childish nicknames, the crazy conspiracy theories, this weird obsession with crowd sizes.” As he said this, he moved his hands closer together, seeming to suggest a distinctly modest penis size.

In the past year, Obama has watched with disbelief as Trump has used his office to enrich himself and his family, and almost daily commits some sort of travesty. At times, often late at night, Obama will fire off a text or an e-mail to a friend about “some dumbass thing Trump did,” Ben Rhodes, who served as Obama’s deputy national-security adviser and is now a consultant to him, said. “What drives him insane is the double standard: ‘What if I took a Qatari jet?’ It’s not even just sour grapes. It’s objectively insane. If Barack Obama did any of these things, he would have been obliterated on sight.”

Obama has told Rhodes and others that he is sure he could have beaten Trump. “He’s frustrated,” Rhodes said, explaining that the former President has made comments to the effect of “I’d love to just be in the ring with this guy.” No such prospect is in the offing, of course, and dwelling on it is of little use. As Michelle Obama told Stephen Colbert, in 2022, “Rage without reason, without a plan, without direction is just more rage. And we’ve been living in a lot of rage.”

In the greater public, a dangerous, inchoate rage directed at Barack Obama persists alongside the widespread affection for him. And that rage demands vigilance. When Obama first ran for President, he received Secret Service protection earlier than any candidate before him, apart from Hillary Clinton, who had a permanent security detail as a former First Lady. After Trump was grazed by a bullet in Butler, Pennsylvania, in 2024, Obama’s security team made sure that campaign rallies he attended were held indoors, where

audiences would pass through metal detectors. Such precautions, of course, did not prevent a gunman from sprinting through a security checkpoint outside this year's White House Correspondents' Association dinner. As with all former Presidents and their spouses, the Obamas have twenty-four-hour protection at home and wherever they travel.

The security is "the most intrusive thing," Jonathan Wackrow, a former member of the Obamas' Secret Service team, told me. But he added that it is a necessity: "The threat environment is not linear. It's asymmetric and it's very dynamic." In 2023, police arrested Taylor Taranto—a January 6th defendant who was pardoned by Trump—after finding him with guns and several hundred rounds of ammunition near the Obamas' house in Washington, D.C. (He was sentenced to time served.) Arne Duncan, the former Secretary of Education and a friend of Obama's, said, "Could someone try and do something crazy tomorrow? Tragically, that's the time we're in. That's where we are as a country."

Around Election Day, Obama amps up his schedule of public appearances. Last fall, he spoke at a rally in Newark for Mikie Sherrill, now the governor of New Jersey. Dressed casually, in a blue shirt with the collar open and the sleeves rolled up, he offered a reel of recent lowlights in Trump's Presidency, from the two-hundred-and-thirty-million-dollar payment that Trump is seeking from the Justice Department to the masked *ICE* agents leaping out of unmarked vans and "grabbing people off the streets, including U.S. citizens." With smiling incredulity, Obama riffed on Republicans' demonization of diversity-equity-and-inclusion initiatives: "You got a flat tire? Must be D.E.I. Your wife kicked you out? D.E.I. Who knew?" The crowd hooted and laughed. "I'll admit it's worse than even I expected," Obama said. "But I did warn y'all. I did."

Obama took a breath and announced that he was "going to bring it down a little bit." He then embarked on a survey of the country's political history, recalling Black people who were enslaved, women who could not vote, Irish and Italian immigrants who could not get jobs. The United States is living the duelling stories that flowed from the injustices of its founding, he said, "a pecking order of who makes decisions and who obeys, who gets opportunity and who is obliged to serve. And that story is policed by fear and by force, and it tries to convince people that for their group to win

another group has got to lose.” This is Trump’s world, he said, and that’s what *MAGA* wants, “even when they don’t know what the hell they’re doing.” When he finished, he slapped the side of the lectern and headed for the rope line as Springsteen’s “Land of Hope and Dreams” played.

That same day, Obama had a call with Zohran Mamdani, who was on the brink of winning the New York City mayoral race. Mamdani came out of the Democratic Socialists of America and once lambasted Obama as “pretty damn evil” and dishonest. But Mamdani has since renounced those remarks, calling them “the stupid tweet of a college student” and has welcomed Obama’s counsel. Recently, the two visited a pre-K center in the Bronx together, singing “The Wheels on the Bus” as they promoted the Mayor’s push for free universal child care. The event was out of the ordinary for Obama, who rarely appears with politicians off the campaign trail. But the former President has said that he is impressed by Mamdani’s ability to get across a clear political message, often via social media, and by his talent for inspiring young volunteers. Obama conceded that someone like Mamdani is a far better spokesman on issues like affordability than he is, not least because the former President no longer faces such problems. “I strongly believe that my highest and best use now is to help find the next set of leaders who are going to move us forward,” he told me. “And part of it is because I think the very best leaders can tap into the Zeitgeist of the moment.”

With the 2028 Presidential race approaching, Obama has shown no interest in early endorsements. His mentoring efforts so far have mostly been further down the ballot. Representative Yassamin Ansari, of Arizona, received an unexpected call from the former House Speaker Nancy Pelosi last fall. Pelosi wanted Ansari, the president of the freshman Democratic class in Congress, to tell her fellow first-years that it would be worth their while to attend an upcoming gathering at Representative Rosa DeLauro’s house. When Ansari learned that Obama would speak to the group, she was thrilled. She was sixteen years old on the night he won the Presidency, and she remembers sobbing. “I watched his victory speech over and over and over again, and it changed the trajectory of my life,” she said.



Thirty-five members of Congress attended the gathering. “I get feeling discouraged sometimes,” Obama acknowledged to them. “I get feeling worn out, tired, and embattled.” He reminded them that Democrats had been in similar straits twenty years earlier, after the 2004 election, when Republicans controlled the White House and Congress. Barely four years later, he was elected President, Democrats ran the Senate, and Pelosi was the first female Speaker of the House. He urged them to resist cynicism and defeatism. Ansari told me that his message was “Keep going. We will overcome this. There will be a world beyond Trump.”

Beto O’Rourke, a former Texas congressman who ran for the Senate and the Democratic nomination for President, said that conversations with Obama had buoyed him when he lost successive races. (O’Rourke figured that Obama knew what he was going through, having lost a 2000 congressional primary to Bobby Rush by thirty-one points.) “This is the darkest hour in modern American history,” O’Rourke told me. “I don’t think the stakes have ever been this high, and to know that Obama will continue to be in this fight gives me some comfort.” He thinks that Obama is wise not to go head to head on a regular basis with Trump, who lives for such brawls: “If he were to do it in a big, public, confrontational way, it would be counterproductive.”

Obama has occasionally extended his counsel to foreign leaders. He had several conversations with Keir Starmer before his election as the U.K.'s Prime Minister. Starmer's Labour colleague David Lammy, who arranged the talks, thought that Obama could offer useful advice to Starmer, the son of a working-class toolmaker. "It was Obama who encouraged him to lean into his relatively humble beginnings," Lammy, now the Deputy Prime Minister, said. "Obama urged him to move to the center ground, to simplify his message, and think about what builds momentum." He said that the former President had similar discussions with progressive opposition leaders in other countries.

Calls have come to Obama, too, from university presidents, corporate executives, and law partners who want advice on how to respond to Trump's latest beyond-the-pale demands. He typically listens, acknowledges the conundrums, and urges the callers to find ways to resist. "What's required in these situations is a few folks standing up and giving courage to other folks," Obama told Marc Maron last year. "We all have this capacity, I think, to take a stand." He added, "If convictions don't cost anything, then they're really just kind of fashion."

In Obama's post-Presidency, he has relished the chance to wander deep into the weeds of policy subjects that interest him. He and Eric Holder, the former Attorney General, founded a project, called the National Democratic Redistricting Committee, that works to steer states away from gerrymandering. Obama raised millions of dollars, produced a raft of advertisements, and took the unusual step of endorsing dozens of candidates for state legislative office. Then, last summer, the governor of Texas, Greg Abbott, acting on a request from Trump, pressed the state legislature to carve out five likely G.O.P. congressional districts, in the hope of keeping control of the House. It took Obama "less than a nanosecond" to decide to fight back, Pelosi told me, despite his long-standing support for nonpartisan electoral maps. In comments that received national attention, Obama said, "We cannot unilaterally allow one of the two major parties to rig the game."

Soon, Obama became the face of a California ballot measure, called Proposition 50, that would allow the legislature to create five new Democratic districts in the state. "With Prop 50, you can stop Republicans in their tracks," he said in one ad. Strategists tested his reputation alongside

those of other well-known Democrats. “Not even close,” Addisu Demissie, a senior adviser to the Prop 50 campaign, said. “His favorability was 89–10, with seventy-five per cent very favorable. Jesus Christ is probably 93–7.” The measure passed by a margin of nearly two to one. Obama played a similar role last month in Virginia, where voters narrowly authorized the Democrat-led legislature to draw new congressional maps that could cost Republicans as many as four seats. Michael Smith, the president of the progressive group House Majority Forward, which spent roughly forty million dollars on the effort, said, of Obama, “This victory simply would not have happened without him.” He expects that the former President will be active in the upcoming midterm campaigns “in big moments when we need someone to step in and make the difference.”

Lately, Obama has been immersed in questions about the science and the ramifications of artificial intelligence. He’s devoted “hundreds and hundreds of hours, quite literally,” to the subject, Rhodes told me. The topic captured Obama’s attention in the White House, ahead of the increasingly intense debates surrounding A.I.’s promise and perils. Jason Goldman, a onetime Google and Twitter executive, has helped to guide his explorations, joining him in meetings with Silicon Valley specialists and Biden-era federal employees.

“He’s kind of a geek,” Goldman told me. “The happiest I’ve seen him is when there’s a meaty problem on the table, it’s an unsolved problem, and there are a bunch of different people around the table who have a framework for how to approach the thing.” Behind the scenes, Obama [played a role](#) in developing Biden’s 2023 [executive order](#) on A.I., which, among other things, required companies to conduct safety tests on certain new products and share the results with the government before releasing them. “Anyone working to harness the power of these new tools has to make a choice: ignore potential problems until it’s too late, or proactively address them,” Obama [wrote](#) at the time. Trump rescinded Biden’s order on the day he took office.

In our conversation, Obama said that he plans to help formulate an A.I. agenda for lawmakers and researchers, one “that is not simply a knee-jerk ‘Screw the billionaires in tech,’ because the genie’s out of the bottle. But, rather, how do we have a smart, enforceable strategy for steering this toward

the common good, as opposed to just private gain? If we do not have an agenda for that, then I think some of the populist impulses that have been there already can go in all kinds of stray directions that are either not going to be particularly successful in helping ordinary people or can reinforce some of the anti-democratic trends that we've already seen.”



Obama also sees storytelling as a way to advance an agenda. In 2013, nearly a year into his second term, he told a group of entertainment professionals that their films and TV shows “transmit values and ideals about tolerance and diversity and overcoming adversity” that shape the world’s culture. For years, he courted the deep-pocketed celebrities who flocked to him and fuelled his campaigns, holding private audiences with them. In the final year of his Presidency, he began mulling the idea of forming a Hollywood production company that would acquire, promote, and sometimes create films, along with audio and video series, that would advance ideas important to him and to Michelle, and give him a lucrative foothold in the industry.

The Obamas named the company Higher Ground, after the Stevie Wonder song, and signed an exclusive deal with Netflix. (Obama recently said that when that contract ends, next year, the company will become independent.) Higher Ground’s projects have ranged widely, from “Descendant,” a documentary that traces the legacy of the Clotilda, the last slave ship to

reach the United States, to a podcast series about Fela Kuti, the Nigerian Afrobeat innovator, which this year received a Peabody Award. “Crip Camp,” a 2020 documentary that was nominated for an Oscar, focusses on a summer camp in the Catskills for disabled teen-agers which helped spur the disability-rights movement.

Obama estimates that he spends ten per cent of his time on Higher Ground. In some cases, he reads a script or views a cut and sends notes to the director. A project that he nurtured from the start is a four-part Netflix series called “Working,” inspired by Studs Terkel’s 1974 oral history. Terkel conducted long interviews with Americans about their jobs, and in the series we hear from such people as a Mississippi home health aide, a Pennsylvania delivery driver, and a California robotics engineer. Higher Ground recruited a little-known director, Caroline Suh, who said that Obama’s involvement and the seriousness of his approach to the project persuaded her to take it on. “He cared about not stereotyping people and not relying on tropes. He was very sensitive that we not be lazy about that,” Suh said. “He’s forceful and direct but always calm. He was very respectful of the fact that this is what we all do for a living.”

Though Obama has not lived in Chicago since 2008, he is keen to show his continuing connection to the city where he began his political career. The Obama Foundation—his most ambitious and, he feels certain, most lasting post-Presidential project—is based on the South Side, where he worked as a community organizer and later served as an Illinois state senator. One program, called My Brother’s Keeper, provides training and mentorship to young people of color; it grew out of Obama’s efforts to support Black boys and young men following the acquittal of Trayvon Martin’s killer. “Some communities have consistently had the odds stacked against them, and that’s especially true for boys and young men of color,” he said, in 2016. The program, which operates in fifty-five communities around the country, works with tens of thousands of young people.

Last year, Obama met in Newark with eight young men who had flown to Brazil for a cultural-exchange program, as part of My Brother’s Keeper. In an hour-long conversation, Obama told them that they were “dealt harder cards than others” and referred to moments in his own adolescence. “I got high, I got drunk,” he said. “I liked basketball and girls, and that was

basically my focus for a while.” He went on to talk about how he shaped up and found focus. He finished by telling them, “I’m proud of you.”

In December, Obama spoke to dozens of college students, who had come to Chicago from across the country as part of the foundation’s leadership-development program. The next day, at a South Side public library named for the Black aviator Bessie Coleman, he met with two dozen children who were part of My Brother’s Keeper-run literacy programs. Obama was wearing a Santa hat, but, rather than selecting a Christmas tale, the library staff had him read the story of Coleman’s determination to surmount racism by proving her excellence: “Bessie said, ‘Oh yeah? You just wait and see! There’ll be a black female pilot. And it will be ME!’ ”

More than fifteen hundred people from around the world have passed through the Obama Foundation’s Leaders Program, a multimillion-dollar training and networking project, started in 2018, that Obama considers a long-term bet on progressive change. One of them is Nika Kovač, a Slovenian activist who led a campaign that persuaded the European Union to help underwrite the travel and medical costs of women who are forced to leave their countries to obtain abortions. Kovač attended her first Leaders Program sessions virtually, during the pandemic. “It’s hard-core training, but at the same time they give you a feeling that you can do big things,” Kovač told me. Her campaign involved gathering more than a million signatures; many were collected by Obama Foundation alumni. “The people leading the program are the first people you call when they attack you on the street or when you win an election,” she said.



These programs will soon operate out of the Obama Presidential Center. The campus, which is spread across nineteen acres, cost an estimated eight hundred and fifty million dollars to build. It's situated on the grounds of a park originally designed by Frederick Law Olmsted and includes a museum, a playground, and a man-made sledding hill. It's not called a library, partly because Obama's Presidential documents are being held separately, by the National Archives and Records Administration. (By the foundation's estimate, ninety-five per cent of the records originated in digital form.) But there is a branch of the Chicago Public Library on the campus, and among its offerings are thirty-five hundred books that reflect the Obamas' interests, including Chicago history.

The center is designed to be open to the community, "a physical manifestation of their life's philosophy," a staff member said of the Obamas. It is fitted out with a teaching kitchen, a podcast-production space, a large classroom called the Democracy in Action Lab, and a recording studio. Maya Lin and Richard Hunt are among the artists whose work is displayed, and elements of the campus are named for John Lewis, Harriet Tubman, Elie Wiesel, and Hadiya Pendleton, a fifteen-year-old girl killed in 2013 by gunfire at a South Side park. After attending her funeral, Michelle Obama said, "Hadiya Pendleton was me, and I was her."

On the blustery day when I first visited the center, hundreds of workers were scattered around the site, moving dirt, installing wiring, fitting the interlocking floorboards of the basketball court, and tending to a two-hundred-and-twenty-five-foot structure, clad in gray-swirled New Hampshire granite, that wags have nicknamed the Obamalisk. Inside are museum spaces that tell the story of Obama's Presidency, grounded in the country's tormented racial history. On the top floor, in a room designed for visitors to reflect in after they have worked their way to the end of the Obamas' White House years, the largest windows face south and west, a nod to the city's Black neighborhoods.

At the building's peak, five-foot-tall concrete letters spell out a hundred and three words of a speech delivered by Obama in Selma, Alabama, in 2015, on the fiftieth anniversary of Bloody Sunday, when John Lewis and other civil-rights activists were beaten at the foot of the Edmund Pettus Bridge. Obama's remarks, written with Cody Keenan, his chief White House speechwriter, acknowledged the raw facts of conquest and slavery, hierarchy and domination, but also paid tribute to a heroic vision embodied by the civil-rights coalition of activists, Pullman porters, rabbis, ministers, and college kids facing down billy clubs and police dogs. "America is not the project of any one person," Obama said in the speech. "The single most powerful word in our democracy is the word 'We.' 'We the people.' 'We shall overcome.' 'Yes we can.'"

A hulking gray tower was not what the center's architects, Billie Tsien and Tod Williams, had in mind when they competed for the job. Their work, which includes the Barnes Foundation, in Philadelphia, and the low-slung additions to the Phoenix Art Museum, is often defined by a "quietness," Tsien told me. She and Williams caught the Obamas' eye by proposing a campus, rather than a single building. But, in a series of meetings that began while Obama was still in the White House, he pushed them to go bigger. "He was saying we should up our ante," Williams said, acknowledging that the repeated demands made him uneasy. "Yet another time, he drew on one of my drawings, made a strong mark, which indicated that he didn't think I was being bold enough. Those little things sting. But they also moved everything forward."

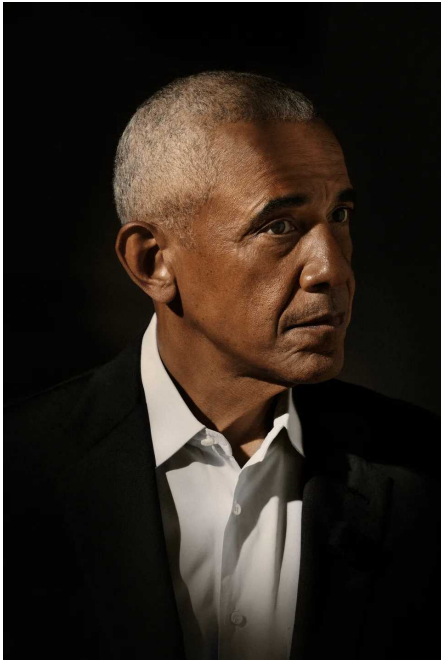
At one point, Obama asked the architects to think of the works of Constantin Brancusi, the modernist sculptor known for his inventive shapes and textures. “What the hell does he mean?” Williams wondered. The architects puzzled over the reference before concluding that it was an invitation to design a building “to be seen as an art piece and not just as architecture,” Williams said. “That really cranked it up for us: ‘Oh, my God, this is serious shit.’ He wanted us to do something that we had not done before, and that is hard. He didn’t let it rest.” After Obama instructed them to experiment with different shapes, they returned several weeks later with twenty-five variations, later winnowed to one. And still Obama wanted changes. As Williams put it, the result is “very much a product of his vision as well as ours.”

Near the end of our conversation, Obama and I turned to the subject of the war in Iran and the erosion of American alliances under Trump. “I do think that repairing the damage that’s been done to the international order is going to be even harder than some of the domestic repairs,” Obama said. “I think one way to think about it is that the post-World War Two order was one of America’s better moments.”

Obama noted that postwar arrangements, including the Marshall Plan, *NATO*, the World Bank and Bretton Woods—“that whole system, for all its flaws and all of its contradictions”—helped insure that “the world was less violent, healthier, wealthier, more equal, more respectful of human rights. Because the most powerful country in the world said, ‘We are not just going to throw our weight around for the sake of it. We’re not just going to go ahead and demand tribute and bully people. We’re going to be part of some larger consensus around how things should work.’ ”

Trump disrupted all that by pulling out of the Paris climate accord and the Iran nuclear deal, and by imposing tariffs and threatening to seize Greenland. America’s allies, Obama said, “can no longer count on us being the hub of that international order.” (He mentioned the Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney’s speech at Davos calling on “middle powers” to combat Trump’s arrogance, describing it as “a pretty good summation of how our closest allies feel right now.”) The tragedy of this, he continued, is that “there still is no one that can replace us. If we don’t talk about human rights, human rights don’t get talked about that much. If we aren’t concerned

about climate change, truthfully, other countries can give lip service to it and do some things, but they're not really going to tackle it. So our leadership is still going to matter enormously, but it's probably going to start with leadership by example more than anything else, rather than dictates."



I asked about the effect of Trump's recent threat to the Iranians that, if they failed to capitulate, "a whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again." Obama took a breath and refused the low road: "I believe American leadership, as represented by the American President, has to reflect a basic regard for human dignity and decency, not just within our own borders but beyond. That's part of the responsibility of leadership. If we are not giving voice to those core values—that there are innocent people in countries with terrible governments and we have to care about those people, that we can make mistakes if we are not guarding against hubris and pure self-interest . . . If we don't have those things, the world can break in very bad ways."

Trump, in an attempt to make a new deal with the Iranian regime, is now entertaining many of the trade-offs that he blasted when Obama was in the White House. Obama, for his part, told me that Benjamin Netanyahu, the Israeli Prime Minister, had made the same arguments for armed confrontation with Iran to him that he did to President Trump. "I think my

prognosis was accurate,” he said. It may be that Netanyahu has “gotten what he wanted. Whether that’s what is ultimately best for the Israeli people, I would question that. Whether I think it’s what is good for the United States and America, I would question that. I think there’s an ample record of my differences with Mr. Netanyahu.”

It has been a decade since Obama delivered his farewell speech in Chicago, in which he told his dejected supporters that he was “more optimistic about this country than when we started.” He does not say that now, but, even as he admits that his confidence has been shaken, his approach to politics remains largely unchanged. As we walked through a museum dedicated to his faith in a perpetual, however jagged, path forward, I was reminded of something that Michelle said of her husband when she addressed the 2012 Democratic National Convention: “He reminds me that we are playing a long game here, and that change is hard and change is slow.”

These days, Obama spends a lot of time talking with younger people. With them, he is an elder refuting the notion that things have never been worse. “I say, ‘No, you know what? Civil War—really bad. Jim Crow—tough. You know, our parents, our grandparents, our great-grandparents went through stuff that was profoundly tougher than what we’re going through,’ ” the former President said. “And I say that not to pull rank on them but, rather, to pull them out of any kind of hopelessness about the situation.” ♦

Profiles

The Life and Times of an American Tween

In some ways, the world is cooked. But being a twelve-year-old still kind of eats.

By Anna Wiener

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Every Wednesday, at exactly 2:15 *P.M.*, the electronic bell at San Francisco's A. P. Giannini Middle School sounds with a dull, droning buzz, and hundreds of students stream from the building. They wear big pants and bucket hats, cropped tanks and cargo jeans, Athleta sets and Air Force 1s. They carry ergonomically unsound backpacks dripping with bag charms and key chains: athletic affiliations, memorabilia, miniature stuffies. They pull thick socks up over their leggings; fix hydrocolloid stickers, star-shaped and cutesy, atop angry, interloping zits. Their lip tint is red and thickly applied. Their water bottles are status symbols. Their press-ons are shellacked and combat-ready. There are boys, too, small and gangly. They move in packs, magnifying their bulk like synchronized minnows. They look dressed by

their mothers. On early-dismissal days, the afternoon yawns with possibility. The students dash to the bus or wander the nearby commercial drag, which has little going for it save the hardware store, where there is candy. They exchange their allowance for matcha ice cream at Polly Ann; gobble Domino's to no intestinal detriment. They buy boba and punt each other with tapioca bullets. They flock to Starbucks for magenta Cannon Ball Drinks, creamy Pink Drinks, sludgy Dubai Chocolate Mochas. They chug the unchuggable. Twelve blocks to the west, the Pacific Ocean glitters and threatens, waves dragging out in the wind.

On a Wednesday afternoon, I was joined outside A.P.G. by Mira, a sixth grader with an open, angelic face and an ebullient presence. It is often chilly and overcast in the Outer Sunset, but this was a warm and clear day, and Mira, who is interested in matters of fashion, wore low-slung cargo sweatpants and a white tube top. Her hair, which is long, dark, and curly, had recently been treated to a bathroom Manic Panic job, and the front strands were dyed a light peach. She smoothed a strand as one might the tail of a cat. Mira is good company: frank, funny, and self-deprecating in a way that suggests confidence rather than its lack. At four feet eight, she is small for her age, but manages to occupy space laterally. She moves with a noodle elasticity, and is prone to breaking into dance moves while going about her business: a full-body wave from wrist to wrist, an entire sequence from a Katseye music video. The first time we met, we were mid-conversation when she inexplicably dropped into a side split, grabbed her ankles, and rolled backward, placing her toes on the floor behind her head. "At the beginning of the year, I couldn't do an aerial"—a hands-free cartwheel—"and I can kind of do one now," she told me, harrowingly assuming the starting position.

Mira is twelve years old and lives in the Avenues, San Francisco's foggy western neighborhoods, with her mother, Michalle, who is a nurse practitioner, her father, Patrick, who is a full-time parent, and her sibling, Dylan, who is nine. (Last year, Dylan requested to use they/them pronouns, which the family mostly remembers to honor.) Like most kids her age, Mira exists in the murky, thrilling bardo between childhood and maturity. She is a gracious host—quick to offer guests a Spindrift—who totes a lunchbox adorned with a sticker of a unicorn. She is learning to cook, mostly quesadillas, but if she could she would live on Cheetos, boba, Trü Früs, and

Coke. She razzes her parents in a way that makes them laugh, but no longer tells them everything. Mira's first middle-school dance was coming up, and there was discussion among her friends about dresses and hair styles. I was excited to see which of her dance moves would make an appearance.

For years, Mira has been agitating for more independence. Last August, she began commuting to and from school alone, hurtling around the edge of the continent on the public bus. Since fifth grade, she has worn a silver Apple Watch, a glorified tracking device, which she pushes to the outer limits of usability. She is a member of several large group chats, including one called "4th Period Baddies," and regularly consults Siri, summoning facts and images from the ether. ("Photos of hazel eyes." "What does A.S.M.R. stand for?") Still, the watch is no phone. A phone would be much cooler; would be, perhaps, the coolest thing. An Apple Watch was a bridge from childhood to adulthood. A phone would be a portal.



That Wednesday, Mira went to Polly Ann with her friends Kaitlyn and Sloane. At the counter, the girls realized no one had brought money. They began plumbing their wallets—pink, pleather, flat—for stray coins. Sloane called her mother on her Apple Watch and, in a mix of English and Mandarin, requested a transfusion of Apple Cash. She hung up just as Mira and Kaitlyn discovered, miraculously, that if they pooled their assets they

could afford to split something. “Never mind we found money exclamation point,” Sloane said into her watch.

“Sloane, no!” Mira said. “We were going to get money!” Giggling, the girls ordered a pint of watermelon ice cream, requested three spoons, and dropped their last dime into the tip jar. They headed to a playground, a regular hangout spot for their peers, and settled onto a boulder. Smaller children from a nearby elementary school were availing themselves of climbers, slides, and beams. But by the boulder the real action was social and discursive. Two sixth-grade boys appeared, one tall and floppy-haired, the other wiry and blond. “Mira, I have a question for you,” the floppy-haired boy said. “Are you straight?” Mira looked at him, her face grave and blank. “No, no, not for me, for one of my friends,” he said, putting his hands out in front of his body, as if to distance himself from any association with crushing. Mira wanted to know who had dispatched him, but the boy wandered off to a playground structure, singing Jimmy Eat World to himself.

Across the way, at a picnic table, two slightly older students, a boy and a girl, were entwined, snakelike, engaging in light frottage: not kissing, but hugging and caressing, petting each other’s cheeks, collapsing into each other’s laps. To the sixth graders, this behavior was repulsive and compelling. I asked Sloane what was up with them. “Girl, I *know*,” she said. “They told Mira they were cousins.” Some of the sixth graders began heckling. “I don’t think you should be doing that if you’re cousins!” Floppy Hair shouted. He turned to his friends. “I’ll give anyone twenty dollars to go over there and ask if they can join,” he said.

“I’ll do it!” a girl said.

“You two should touch asses!” Floppy Hair yelled. He turned to the blond boy. “We should start making out. And then, when they look, say, ‘Yeah, how do you like me now?’ ” He sat down near the older students. The blond boy followed, plopped down into Floppy Hair’s lap, then popped back up and pogoed away.

The wind was picking up, and the playground was starting to empty. On the edges of the park, middle schoolers could be seen raising their wrists to their mouths, requesting more time. Mira and two friends moved to a low wall

and huddled around their own smartwatches, whispering and laughing. “We’re catfishing someone,” Mira explained. The girls had called a male classmate on Kaitlyn’s watch, but another girl had done all the talking. “We’re, like, ‘We know who you are,’ in an evil way,” Mira went on. “And it’s funny because he doesn’t know who we are.” I laughed: this sounded more like old-fashioned prank-calling than catfishing. But Mira gave a sombre little nod. “This is what we do with our time,” she said.

The literature on adolescence marks middle school as a turning point, a time when kids begin to pull away from their parents, discard childish pursuits, and pursue, full thrust, the exhausting project of individuation. It is a period of intense, hormonally driven emotional flux. Self-consciousness sets in. The adult world is studied and emulated in a manner that suggests praxis but no theory. There is an aspect of camp to it all: a kind of *LARP* or drag, as young people transition from play-acting adulthood to inhabiting it. Actual adults are ancillary. Tweens and teens look to each other for clarity and guidance on how to behave and how to feel, all the while gambling with each other’s social confidence and self-esteem. It is natural, and it is psychotic.

The psychoanalyst Erik Erikson described the period between twelve and eighteen as one of essential identity formation: a time of trying on personas and roles. Writing in the mid-twentieth century, Erikson was sensitive to the ways that society could shape personality, but no one could have anticipated the explosion of potential identities, interests, aesthetics, subcultures, and life styles that children would be exposed to by globalization and, later, the internet: now there are clean girls, tomato girls, vanilla girls, office sirens, femboys, e-boys, looksmaxxers; one can be avant basic, old money, new money, quiet luxury, cottagecore, goblincore, fairycore. Adolescent anxiety and depression have been on the rise for years, and there is abundant public debate about why: economic inequality, strained family ties, sleep deprivation, smartphones. Childhood has never been easy, but these days the on-ramp to adulthood seems somehow shorter and more perilous.



Mira's parents, Michalle and Patrick, met as college students and have been together for almost twenty years. "My mom grew up pretty poor," Mira told me one day, unprompted. And then, with learned dismissiveness: "My dad grew up as a rich white boy." Michalle is petite, good-natured, and very pretty, with dark eyes and a radiant smile. She was raised in Marin County, the daughter of Salvadoran immigrants. Patrick was raised between the Pacific Northwest and the suburbs of Silicon Valley, and was on the University of Chicago debate team. He is sincere, analytical, and ripped—the kind of dad whose biceps come sheathed in a T-shirt reading "Find Yourself," over a picture of Waldo meditating. (Mira picked it out.)

Mira was an amiable baby, a daredevil toddler, and, once Dylan arrived, a menace. When asked if she had memories of the transition from being an only child to having a sibling, she said, dryly, "I remember peace, and then awful screaming." As a little kid, Mira was "spunky" (Michalle), "assertive, directorial" (Patrick), and "blunt, stubborn, annoying" (Mira). But her parents were wary of overdoing it on discipline, especially with a girl. "It's easier to work with a fire than try to build one up later," Patrick said.

During *COVID*, Mira's elementary school moved to remote learning, but Michalle, an essential worker, was able to enroll her children in a series of camps. Mira received minimal educational instruction—"You can't learn

handwriting through a screen,” she said, witheringly—but thrived socially. She has earned straight A’s in middle school, including in P.E., which for a time she was “essentially failing.” (She had a B.) Her rowdiest class is English language arts, which operates on “mutual respect,” and where students regularly talk over the teacher, walk around, and flick paper darts into the ceiling tiles. Her favorite class is dance. “That one is amazing, because it’s all girls,” she said.



A few years ago, Mira’s family moved into a new apartment, in part to give her and Dylan separate bedrooms. The place, a rental, is furnished without pretension—cushy sectional, vintage Tabasco poster, board games. A whiteboard leans against the wall of the dining area, with a running list of movies for the family’s weekly movie night. “My dad does squat things down here,” Mira told me, prancing through the hall. “Before, he was just an average person. He would just be regular. And then he was, like, I’m going to be healthy, because this is not a good life style if I want to keep it for when I’m a hundred years old. So he stopped drinking, and drinking caffeine. Now he counts all his calories, every night—it’s kind of annoying.” For most of Mira’s life, Patrick worked in product management at a large tech company. In 2024, after a revealing sabbatical, he quit. “He’s more of a chauffeur now,” Mira told me. “He’s been jobless for two years.”

“Job-free,” Patrick, who was within earshot, corrected.

“Jobless,” she said.

One afternoon, I found the kids hanging out in the dining area, banging around near a sideboard that held decorative ceramics. Dylan, who is dimpled and impish, with long eyelashes and a curtain of dark bangs, picked up a small container and examined it. Patrick, laughing, warned that the vessel held cremains. “This is Grandad,” he said. When Patrick’s father died, two years ago, Patrick and his siblings divided his ashes among themselves, and a portion rested in a columbarium; the urn was small.

“Do you think this is just, like, an eyeball?” Mira asked, holding up her paternal grandfather. “If he was a ghost, it would just be, like, his arm, floating?”

“It’s probably a small amount of lots of parts of him,” Patrick said.

“Like little bits of flesh,” Dylan said, chuckling.

Patrick, who is prone to gentle didacticism, tried to turn the conversation into a teachable moment. “In the early internet, the internet speed was pretty low, so when images would load, it would load rows interlaced, so you could tell roughly what it was while it was loading, as opposed to waiting for the whole asset to load the way it does now,” he said. “It’s like that. It’s like a low-resolution picture of Grandad.”

“*Weird*,” Dylan said.

For any adolescent, a private bedroom is both sanctuary and mood board. It’s a safe haven for experimental selfies, a shelter for incognito-mode Google searches, an internal switchboard for the exchange of secrets and dreams. Over the winter, Mira conducted a “room refresh” and parted with her childhood desk, some toys, and the bunk bed she and Dylan once shared. The room now held a gleaming white loft bed, with a small den of executive function underneath. “I don’t get homework yet, but if I did, this is where I would do it,” Mira said, gesturing at an under-bed desk. When I first visited, last fall, the room had been graced by a larger-than-life-size cardboard

cutout of Taylor Swift, but it had since disappeared. “She died,” Mira said. “Dylan broke her. A few times.” Dylan, who shares a room with a leopard gecko, is still steeped in the unambiguous stuff of kid-world. (“I think mythical creatures can crossbreed with anything,” they mused one afternoon, apropos of nothing discernible, over a mayo-slathered bagel. Then, seconds later: “Never go near a dead whale. They can explode!”) Like many younger siblings, Dylan is both antagonist and accomplice: privy to everyday intimacies, but not allowed to hang out in Mira’s room. “If they do, I will shun them,” Mira told me. “I will go—HYAH!—get out.”

On the other side of Mira’s room was a proud vanity, replete with Hollywood mirror and leather-topped stool. It was covered in a tantalizing explosion of tubes and dupes, gloops and glops: setting sprays, concealer, eyeshadow palettes, Unicorn Snot body glitter. “This is the pink drawer,” she said, excavating a Trader Joe’s gummy-bear-flavored overnight lip mask. “It’s just whatever’s pink.” Over the vanity hung a neon sign in curlicue magenta script. “Mira,” it glowed.

I picked up the concealer. “What are you concealing?” I asked.

“I have bags under my eyes,” Mira said. I looked at her face, which had the interior illumination of a Renaissance portrait, and felt we were somehow both being gaslighted. “I like to read at night,” she said. “I’m supposed to get ten hours of sleep, but I get nine.”

During the week, Dylan and Mira are not allowed to have screen time, but when the iron curtain is lifted, on Friday nights, the children enjoy unlimited access to a shared laptop, or “the Dylan family computer,” as Mira calls it, because Dylan tends to hoard it to play a dizzying, headachy civilization simulator called WorldBox. (“I’m making monoliths to make humanoid versions of animals,” they explained one afternoon, incomprehensibly.) There is also a family iPhone, which connects to Wi-Fi but does not have a data plan. This is Mira’s—de facto, not de jure. “Mira doesn’t let me use the phone,” Dylan told me. “She kicks me out of her room before I can get to the phone.” Mira is not allowed to have TikTok, Instagram, Snapchat, or other social media. “I’m allowed to officially have a phone when I’m fourteen,” she said. “Probably fifteen for social media.” (Patrick denied this, saying that it “hasn’t been litigated yet.”) Her activities of choice are

perusing Pinterest and surfing YouTube Shorts—essentially a high-latency TikTok. “There’s this whole thing called *BookTube*,” Mira told me, singing the last word while arcing her arms in the shape of a rainbow. Recently, scanning BookTube—dupe BookTok—I found myself in the Venn diagram between nerdy and thirsty, where young women in matte makeup memed in front of bookcases stuffed with romantasy. Mira also enjoys content from the influencer Salish Matter, a sixteen-year-old with an intra-Target Starbucks habit who shares a channel with her father, also an influencer. I watched a bunch of the Matters’ videos (“Hiding from 24 *BOYS* in 24 *HOURS*”; “My Daughter Survives *TEN BROTHERS*”) and, feeling demented, decompressed by scrolling through Shorts and watching a woman eat her way out of a bathtub filled with popcorn.



Mira’s favorite narrative trope is “enemies to lovers,” in which hatred is transmogrified into passion. “Me and Mom read a lot of the same things,” she told me. “Well, when I can read them, because they’re all smut novels.” (“That’s not true!” Michalle said. “My favorite book is ‘[Cutting for Stone](#).’”) Mira loves the “[Once Upon a Broken Heart](#)” books, which are twisty, whimsical, and wildly popular among young women. For romance novels, they’re also pretty tame: one chili pepper out of five, for chaste kissing and no action below the neck.

We settled on the floor of her room so that she could show the books to me. Homemade fan art of Jacks, the series's love interest, fluttered out of a collector's-edition case. "A kiss worth dying for," I read out loud. "If you kiss him, and you're not his soulmate, you will die," Mira explained. We did not dwell on the sexual politics of this conceit. "It's very dark," she said. "He doesn't tell people that he kills people when he kisses them, but he also doesn't not tell them. People want to because"—her voice rose to a high, fluttering falsetto, a falsetto that suggested a superior world of sophistication in which one did not deign to do kissing—"he's so dreamy." But Jacks was not without his flaws, promiscuity among them. "He has technically murdered thousands of people," Mira said.

I asked Mira what drew her to the books. "I really like the writing style," she said. "Also, he's blond. That's very unique."

"It's unique that he's blond?" I asked.

"People like them dark," she said, and sprang up to stand by the bookcase. "We shall go through." She began tapping the spines of her books. "Brown hair, brown hair, brown hair, brown hair, brown hair," she said, then paused, finger suspended in midair. "I don't know what color hair he has. Brown hair, brown hair, brown hair. This doesn't have a love interest. Brown hair, brown hair. Brown hair."

In the winter, Mira told me that her celebrity crush is a waifish actor from "Stranger Things" named Finn Wolfhard (brown hair), who has high cheekbones, minimal facial hair, and looks a bit like [Miranda July](#). Wolfhard is the ideal middle-school celebrity crush: sexually nonthreatening and pretty, like Joseph Gordon-Levitt in 1999. Civilian crushes were a different story. "I don't really like anyone," Mira told me. "All the guys in my school are, like, either jerks, ugly, or both. There's not great variety." I inquired about another sixth grader Mira had mentioned previously, but she waved the idea off. "We're ninety-five per cent sure he's gay," she said, as if this had ever precluded the affections of a middle-school girl. "He's really zesty." She and her friends had been joking with him about this, but Mira reassured me, "I'm bi, so it's O.K." She was drinking a strawberry matcha, a slurry of fruit, milk, and L-theanine, and slurped the jammy dregs. I asked when she first understood that she was bisexual. "Because men are just

annoying,” she said, shrugging. This spring, she said that her celebrity crush was [Sabrina Carpenter](#).



In the weeks leading up to the spring dance, Mira had been experimenting with hair styles, including braiding her hair into tiny little hearts against her scalp. But to hear her tell it—at least, to me—Mira’s interest in romance was purely literary. She was masterly at deflecting: once, when I asked if she was excited about potentially dating in the future, she changed the subject to a specialty-pie bakery we were passing. I took her point. Maybe crushes were happening, maybe not; none of my business. Maybe widespread openness toward sexual identity and gender weren’t enough to offset the raw vulnerability of wanting to be special to someone. I asked Mira if she’d followed up with Floppy Hair, who had delivered news of a crush by proxy. He still wouldn’t tell Mira who it was, and she couldn’t be bothered to get it out of him. “It’s so much work,” she said. “I could be listening to an audiobook instead of doing that.”

One evening, I asked Mira if she ever felt anxious in social situations. What I had in mind was pedestrian: cliques, drama, new people. She was leaning in the doorframe of her kitchen, eating dessert, and took a moment to think. “When there are men,” she said. “Old men. Like Dad’s age and older.”

Patrick and Michalle, who were sitting with me at the dining table, looked surprised.

“Why?” I asked.

“Because I don’t like men, they’re weird,” she said. “We live in a world of pedophiles and rapists. And I don’t want that.” Recently, she explained, she’d been at Maple’s house, and they had put on the Netflix documentary series “[Jeffrey Epstein](#): Filthy Rich.” “It was really disgusting,” Mira said. (“We haven’t talked about the Epstein files,” Patrick said.) Her distaste extended to American politics, and to the President. “I think he was mentioned more times in the Epstein files than Harry Potter was mentioned in all eight books,” she said. This statistic was somewhat inaccurate: there are not eight Harry Potter books; there are seven. After the first episode, the girls had switched to watching a rom-com.

From Mira I learned about Merit Beauty and “Pop Star Academy: [Katseye](#).” I learned that the trick to a manicure is to wait for the first hand to dry before doing the second, though that’s hard if you’re impatient; that “KPop Demon Hunters” is good the first time but dulls by the fourth; and that, to do the wave, you have to go fingers, fist, down, elbow, shoulder, chest, shoulder, elbow, down. I learned that Taylor Swift spends, like, thirty-five million dollars a year on her cats. I learned that Lucky Charms cereal is, like, seventy-five per cent sugar, bananas are poisonous to monkeys, and you should rinse Popsicles before eating them to avoid losing taste buds. I learned that you can kind of just say “slay” whenever, as filler, that you can address both your girls and your dad as “bro,” and that, at least in Mira’s telling, her whole life doesn’t revolve around her mom, but her mom’s whole life revolves around her. (“As it should be,” Mira said.)

Every week, Mira receives an allowance of twelve dollars, a cute amount commensurate with her age. With Patrick’s help, she tracks and budgets her assets in an Excel spreadsheet. In fourth grade, shortly after discovering online shopping, Mira found a cheap, appealing dress on Shein. She showed it to Patrick, and asked him to buy it for her using her allowance. Instead, he offered a lesson in Xinjiang internment camps and the global supply chain. “Turns out there’s, like, lead in their things, and child labor, forced labor, thirty-two cents a day, not great,” Mira said. Patrick, who framed it as a

moral choice, handed the decision to Mira. “Great thing to do for a fourth grader,” she told me, sarcastically. After wrestling with it, she decided to swear off Shein—but only once she’d bought the dress.

Mira’s politics are still primarily shaped by her parents, but the culture creeps in. She is nervous about the prospect of “World War III”—“Still got a few years, you never know,” she said—and she harbors some anxiety about global warming. (“We’re not gonna make it,” she told me, knowingly.) Once, we were on the light rail and passed a billboard advertisement for a software company, touting a new A.I. product. “Boooo, A.I.,” Mira said, as we rattled along. “Boooo. It’s killing the polar bears.” I asked if the ad hadn’t been for Patrick’s former employer. “Mm-hmm,” she said. “He did hard and/or *software*.” She leaned forward in her seat. “They’re so similar. Why make them so different, but so similar?” At school, Mira is participating in a marine-science program called Ocean Ambassadors. Learning about seal malnutrition has been sobering. “I’m not helping,” she acknowledged. “I still buy from Amazon.”

One afternoon, I picked Mira up from school and we drove to Stonestown Galleria, a mall on the edge of San Francisco. She sat in the front seat, as she is wont to do, despite not clearing the recommended height. Whenever we spent time together, I experienced a kind of duality: relating to Mira, while being very much a middle-aged mom. As she climbed into my car, I had a brief moment of dissociation: how could we be driving, when we were only twelve? “I don’t like it here,” she said, as we passed through a neighborhood of detached, single-family homes. “Why is there so much space in between the houses? You could make it taller, and then you can have more people that live there.” Any doubts I might have had about Patrick’s *YIMBY*-ism vanished. We passed a Volkswagen Beetle, and for the second time in ten minutes, Mira punched me in the arm. “Sorry,” she murmured.

In the Stonestown parking lot we circled, looking for a spot, and found ourselves stuck behind a Waymo. “You can’t honk at it, because it won’t do anything,” Mira advised. Her friend Fiona sometimes took Waymos, but Mira had never experienced one firsthand. A Waymo was cool. There were no parents in a Waymo, no little siblings. A Waymo was the next best thing to having your own car. “I wanna go in a Waymo!” she cried, in a cartoonish voice of anguish.

We parked, entered the glossy, brightly lit tomb of the mall, and piloted to Sephora like two homing pigeons. Each new generation adopts the consumer tendencies of its time, and Generation Alpha has demonstrated an unquenchable desire for skin-care products: on TikTok, tiny influencers with Minnie Mouse voices and infinitesimal pores post “Get ready with me” videos in which they offer squeaky endorsements for products like retinol and eye cream. Mira has a multi-step skin-care routine, which she performs every night, using the materials at hand. First, face wash, procured by her parents from Costco. Then toner, usually Glow Recipe’s Watermelon Glow. Next, she conducts a targeted strike on the skin beneath her nostrils. “I *had* a really dry nose, around here,” she told me, touching her face, which betrayed no history of any aberration. “It was, like, crispy,” she said. “So I do that so it doesn’t come back, because it’s evil.” Her product of choice is Target-brand petroleum jelly—“dupe Vaseline,” she joked. Finally, she applies peppermint lip butter.

It would be easy, having made it safely past the shores of puberty, to make light of these rituals and ablutions. But the rituals are very important—in fact, they’re everything. They’re experiments with externalizing private self-perceptions, and dalliances with potential selves. They’re a way of projecting into the future: to imagine being noticed, maybe even seen.

That afternoon, Mira was in the market for a tinted sunscreen, but distractions abounded. At the display for Milk Makeup, a self-described “clean beauty” brand, she sampled a tube of Cooling Water Jelly Tint, a jiggly blush-slash-lip stain the color of rubies and the texture of aspic. As I tried to imagine the adult woman who would put this on her face, Mira poked the goo and smiled. “Jelly,” she said, in a weird voice. We entered the sunscreen section, and examined a product called Supergoop! Glowscreen. “Nineteen dollars for a mini,” she said remorsefully, and set it back down.



We made our way to Salt Tree, a Californian chain boutique. By this point, I had read enough prescriptive nonfiction about raising adolescent girls that I understood sexy clothing to be distinct from sexuality in practice; I had consulted parents of teen-agers, who explained that their daughters' revealing clothing was not a capitulation to the male gaze but a refutation of its power. This did not prepare me for Salt Tree. The store was blazingly lit; metal racks overflowed with petroleum-based fabrics and shivered to the bass line of throbbing pop music. There were crop tops in fuchsia mesh, tube tops in cheetah print, chain-mail halters, and puff-sleeved sweaters. There were plaid miniskirts in multiple colorways, pleather shorts, and denim corsets. There were distressed jeans, and cargo jeans, and jeans studded with pearls and rhinestones. There were tiny shirts that said "Be Kind" and "Tequila Made Me Do It," and nostalgic shirts with vintage lettering that read "'76" and, appallingly, "'93." There were body chains. It felt like an A.I. hallucination of nineties fashion. I was immediately transported to my own preteen cabinet of horrors: Mystique Boutique, just off Canal Street in Manhattan, a wild cornucopia of stretchy basics and barely-there going-out clothes, everything slashed and shrunken. In a season of knockoff Kate Spade bags, bar-mitzvah pencil skirts, and gratuitous training bras, it had produced in me a sick, horny covetousness: not for the clothes themselves, but for the idea of womanhood—flirty, filled-out, smoochable—that they implied.

In the early eighties, Neil Postman, the media theorist and critic, argued that the boundary between childhood and adulthood had long been one of information asymmetry—adults had secrets, whereas children had only their natural instincts and limited experience—and it was eroding, which he largely blamed on television. Children were exposed early to death, sex, violence, and money; one consequence, Postman claimed, was an undifferentiated culture in which children acted like adults and adults acted like children. (Postman died in 2003, too early for family dance challenges on TikTok to kill him.) At Salt Tree, I wondered about the vision of adulthood the clothes conveyed, and the women I had imagined when I was small. Did they exist, or were they always just twenty, only ever twelve? I hadn't grown up and spent my life knocking back Diet Cokes, voluptuously, at the club. But kids didn't aspire to dress like work-from-home moms in machine-washables. This was one of the raw edges of adolescents: in their eager imitation of maturity, they conveyed an incomplete but inevitably uncomplimentary reflection of adult life.

Mira had recently been to Salt Tree with her friends to shop for the dance. Initially, she had wanted a dress there with a tulip hem and an off-the-shoulder neckline—like Aurora's dress, from Disney's "Sleeping Beauty," she told me—but she ultimately rejected it, because it shed glitter. That dress, which cost thirty-eight ninety-nine, still hung limply in the store, twinkling. Instead, she had chosen a dress that was blush pink, with three tiers of ruffles, a strappy back, and a ruched bodice. It was coquettish for a woman, and perfect for a girl.

In the sale section, we appraised a bustier with a photo of a Yorkshire terrier on it. "No," Mira said, shoving it back into the rack. Also "No" were neon-green tank tops ("Too eighties"), a long denim dress patterned with embroidered flowers ("A mother dress"—whose mother?), and a ruffled white polka-dotted situation ("Not O.K."). Mira pulled out a fifties-style blue frock. "This has Sabrina Carpenter vibes," she said, flipping, perusing.



A few moments later, I lifted a high-necked, long-sleeved, ribbed skater dress from the rack, and said, horribly, “This feels a little bit like ‘Taylor Swift in the winter’ vibes.” Mira looked at it, then at me, and chose grace.

“Maybe,” she said.

For a while, Mira thought she might want to be a backup dancer, probably for someone like Sabrina Carpenter. “I don’t want to be famous, but I want to be friends with famous people,” she explained. Her ambitions changed after she consulted Siri and learned that background dancers aren’t particularly well remunerated. “Then I wanted to be a physical therapist, but I figured out they get paid the same amount as background dancers,” she said. “So, a dermatologist could be cool.” In the future, she pictures herself living like Patrick’s mother, JJ, a retired marketing executive who travels often and has two cats. But, unlike JJ, Mira will not live in the suburbs—especially not the suburbs of Sacramento, where her parents may move someday, because they would like to own a home—and she will not get married. “More hassle,” she said. Children were also not in the picture. “They’re annoying, and they steal your money,” she said. She was seated at a toddler-scale table by the living-room window, making a valentine in the shape of a notebook, which she planned to keep for herself.

“Maybe it’s worth it,” I suggested sentimentally.

“Not for me,” she said, cutting, gluing. “I want a low-responsibility life.”

That week, San Francisco public-school teachers were on strike, and Patrick’s “Daddy day care” was in session. Mira and Dylan had gone to support their teachers on the picket line; a cardboard sign decorated with hearts and the words “Teachers Deserve Better,” written in careful script, leaned against the living-room wall. The school dance had been postponed. It was a rainy afternoon, and Mira was waiting on a delivery from Amazon: a nail kit with a salon-style U.V.-light dryer. At fifty-nine dollars, the purchase had drained about half of her savings, but she planned to leverage it. “I’m starting a nail business,” she told me. “It’s fifteen dollars for gel, and then twenty-five dollars for Gel-X.”

Patrick turned on the Winter Olympics, and Europe’s fernlike male figure skaters took turns gliding across the ice. Mira began absent-mindedly rolling and unrolling a fine-tooth comb through her curls. After a few minutes, she said, “It’s stuck.” The comb dangled mid-forehead.

“Oh, Mira,” Patrick said. He crossed the room and tugged gently on the comb, which did not budge. “This is just who you are now,” he said, shaking his head.

“This is just who I am now,” Mira agreed.

Michalle arrived home from work, appraised the situation, and burst out laughing. “Mira, you’re not allowed to use combs without supervision,” she said. She sat down next to Mira, who bowed her head. “I’m sorry, Mira, we’re gonna just have to cut some of this,” Michalle said. She retrieved a pair of small scissors, and the room fell quiet.

“No!” Mira shouted. “No, NO!”

Slowly, Michalle began to snip. Patrick said, “You’re gonna be somewhat limited—or, potentially have new opportunities for how you do your little . . . What do you call the little front styling that you do?”

“It’s called a front strand!” Mira said, annoyed. The comb came free, and she examined herself in the mirror. The damage was minor, but not invisible. She smoothed and tucked, shaking her head. “You know, another reason I don’t want kids is this,” Mira said. “I’m a great example of why I don’t want kids.”

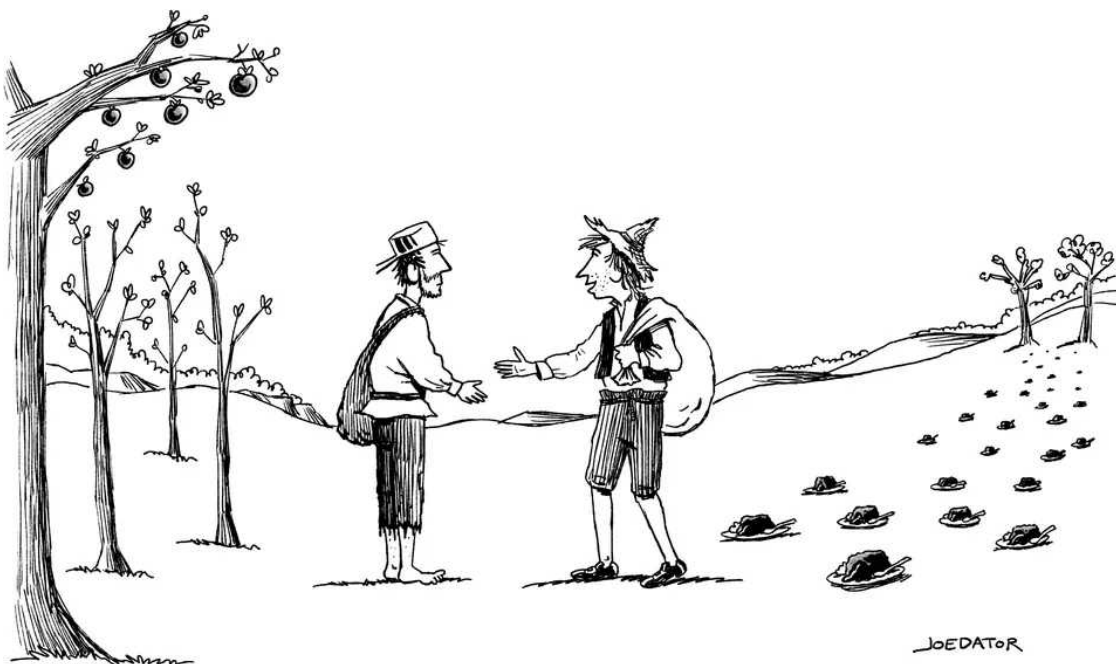
Mira is not exactly overscheduled, like many children of her generation; rather, she is locked in. Five days a week, she travels to the San Francisco Circus Center, where she performs feats of unfathomable abdominal strength. (A bi circus performer: San Francisco’s not dead.) Mira’s specialty is the aerial hoop, in which she executes tricks and contortions on a suspended metal circle, and she recently joined the center’s in-house performance troupe. Most of the other troupe members are already in high school. When I asked what was different about hanging out with older kids, she replied, thoughtfully, “They’re usually the base.”

One afternoon, I joined Mira to watch her aerial-hoop class, taught by a Russian master. She dashed into the large, brightly lit gymnasium, and I settled onto the wooden bleachers, which were painted cerulean and speckled with yellow stars. After half an hour of mat stretches, Mira and two other students climbed onto Swedish ladders, hung with their backs to the wall, and did a set of leg lifts, tapping their feet against their heads. Finally, Mira chalked her hands, boosted herself onto a dangling metal hoop, flipped upside down, and hung from a single knee, arms spread out like a rotor. She twirled slowly, her face fixed in an expression of focus and resolve. Alone in the bleachers, I watched as her childlike elasticity was transmuted into something I knew she would draw on for the rest of her life: a determined, hushed discipline.

Middle school is, famously, a time of petty cruelty and small-scale social Darwinism. Mira has seen “Mean Girls” the movie and “Mean Girls” the movie musical, but her own social experience does not reflect them. She has known most of her friends for years, and has an easy social grace. Still, hanging out with sixth-grade girls, I recalled the time as one of great sensitivity, in which carelessness could feel like a slight. Around Mira and her friends, my own insecurities were heightened. Did they think I was cool, because I had a phone? One evening, Patrick drove me and Mira to the middle-school musical; I sat in the back seat, regressing. When we got to the

lobby, she raced into the theatre, leaving me loitering by the concession table. I found her close to the front, sitting with her friends Fiona and Evie. They had not saved me a place, and did not seem concerned about finding me one. (“You’re *still* getting interviewed?” Fiona asked.) I sat down several rows behind them, watching their backs as they huddled together, laughing. I wondered what they were talking about, and hoped it was not me.

One night this winter, Mira hosted a “movie party” for some friends. When I arrived at the apartment, she and two other girls were curled on the couch in fluffy socks and athleisure, talking. The doorbell rang, and two more girls arrived, piling onto the couch. Sloane was missing, however, and no one knew where she was. “Where are you?” Mira growled into her watch, excitedly. “We’re all waiting for youuuuu-uh!”



“Oh, my God, Ellis ate ice out of a girl’s mouth the other day,” someone said. The couch erupted in “whoa”s and “ew”s. “He was, like, can I have some ice, and then she spit it out, and then he *took* it. She meant it as a joke, but he took it!”

That evening, through a confusing hybrid of democratic voting and random selection, the girls were watching “[The Devil Wears Prada](#),” a morality tale about a frumpy aspiring journalist, Andy (Anne Hathaway), who wishes to

afflict the comfortable and comfort the afflicted, but instead lands a job at a fashion magazine modelled after *Vogue*, working as an assistant to its editor-in-chief, the domineering, mercurial Miranda Priestly (Meryl Streep). The film is ostensibly about the hazards of sacrificing one's values for professional ambition, but it is actually a movie about [outfits](#). As soon as it began, so did the running commentary, a Greek chorus of reheated Gen Z slang. "O.K., slay," Bayla said, as Andy embarked on the first of several makeovers. "Girl, she's eating."

"I mean, she did have kind of a chopped look," Mira noted.

The doorbell rang; it was Sloane. All five girls jumped off the couch, stampeded toward the apartment door, and tumbled into the building's stairwell, stepping on each other's heels. "O.K., here's a summary," Mira said, excitedly. "So she's working for, like, a billion-dollar company. She does not like her job, and she's so ugly. But then she got a glow-up, and she kind of likes her job."

When I first saw the movie, twenty years ago, it seemed obvious that Andy's live-in boyfriend, Nate (Adrian Grenier), who primarily serves to call Andy out for betraying her own values, was meant to be the film's moral compass. In 2026, however, the gender politics hit different. "Clock the tea, girl!" Mira cried, when Andy criticized Nate for being unsupportive. "He is just, like, not giving. I feel like he wants to be first, but she likes her job."

On the chaise side of the sectional, Fiona and Izzy were giggling under a blanket, playing a makeover game on Fiona's phone. Onscreen, Andy was being seduced by a heavily jawed man with blond hair. "Would you rather have him with her, or the other guy with her?" a girl asked.

"I'd rather not have any of them with her," Maple, whose parents are divorced, said. "Single baddies forever," she cried, flopping back on the couch.

"Yaasss," Bayla slurred.

Onscreen, the seduction was working. "Go get some Botox plastic surgery," Mira heckled at the blond jaw. "He is so chopped. Get away, you crusty,

dusty man!” The blond kissed Andy on the cheek, and the “ew”s kicked up again. “Her outfit is eating,” Bayla said.

The children munched on pizza and Caesar salad. After a montage in Paris, Miranda, eyes full of tears and face stripped of makeup, confessed to Andy that her marriage was over. “She got divorced?” Fiona said, looking up from her phone.

“Now she’s free. Baddie,” someone else said.

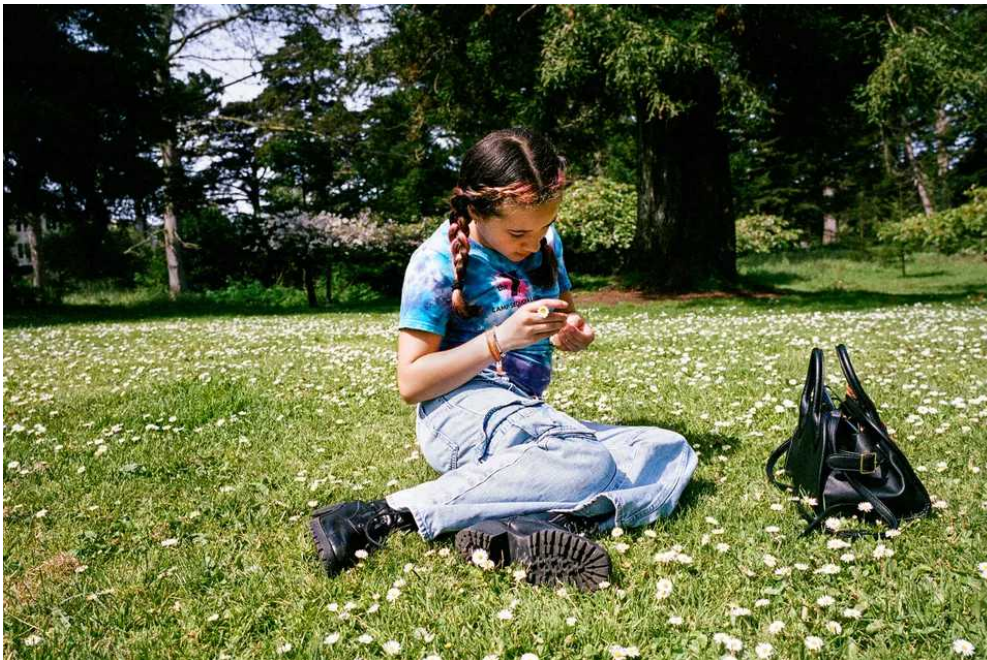
“Single baddies forever,” Maple said quickly.

“I feel bad for her,” Mira said. “She’s just a cool baddie that focusses on her fashion.”

By the time the movie finished, half the room was still watching, while the other half was on Fiona’s phone. “I like that she’s with nobody in the end,” Maple said, but the rest of the group had already moved on, comparing notes on cheaper alternatives to the Dyson Airwrap, imagining their hair being somehow more volumized, beautiful, tamed. The girls, buzzed on miniature cans of soda, lingered in the liminal space between rolling credits and parental pickup. “We could go to my room,” Mira suggested, and the group leaped from the couch and chased each other like puppies, a flurry of hair and limbs and cotton-poly blend. They piled in and closed the door.

In late March, A.P.G. finally held its spring dance, with the theme “Under the Cherry Moon.” After school, I bumped into Mira and her friends, who were on their way to get ready at Bayla’s house. They were loitering giddily on the sidewalk, shouting at Sloane, who was tearing across the parking lot—barefoot, for some reason—back into school, to retrieve her high heels from her first-period classroom. The dance had been called for three in the afternoon, but the group planned to arrive fashionably late, at three-thirty. It had been hard to gauge Mira’s expectations. “I might just stand in a corner,” she told me. Most of her friends didn’t have dates, though Maple was going with a girl named Sasha, and Sloane was going with Leo, a boy from their grade. “He’s liked her since, like, third grade,” Mira said.

I was unfashionably early, and toured the sixth-grade wing of the school. A pedestalled bust of A. P. Giannini, the founder of Bank of America and the school's namesake, was stashed behind a recycling bin. I tried to imagine what he saw, down in the atrium where the children slayed. Early adolescence was a sustained state of cognitive dissonance. It was a time of learning to take yourself seriously while wearing Unicorn Snot; of being clothed and transported by your parents while seeing them as critically as anyone ever would. It was a period when you could be aware of violent, sexual, criminal abuses of power; immediately identify the sexism of a "vintage" workplace dramedy; and mostly find the boys in your own life annoying. It was exhilarating, exhausting, and fleeting. Young people changed quickly and not on any predetermined schedule. From the relatively static vantage of adulthood, it could feel like any given day with a kid was your last day with that version of them. Along one wall ran hundreds of gray, two-tier lockers. The locker was both ballast and canvas. Inside, magnets and passed notes and Instax Mini prints marked the passage of time, breadcrumbs on the trail taking each child further and further from home. One of the most salient features of twelve, after all, is that it comes right before thirteen.



Inside the cafeteria, which was painted with cheerful murals of paper cranes and various translations of the word "together," the linoleum floor was

strewn with plastic cherry-blossom petals and white balloons. Pink streamers looped haphazardly from the ceiling. Two girls from the “Mixerz” lunch club, which meets twice a week and is devoted to the art of d.j.’ing, stood behind a folding table labelled “*DANCE FLOOR*,” cuing up Kendrick Lamar and PinkPantheress. The overhead lights were off, for ambience, but midafternoon daylight streamed through the windows. The air smelled faintly of lunch and feet. Outside, on the patio, boxes of Jenga had been set out for the wallflowers.

The cafeteria began to fill with students: girls in miniskirts and chunky sneakers; mididresses with ribbed ankle socks; summer dresses over jeans; strappy sandals and florals. Their bra straps showed; their hair and faces were glossy. Most of the boys, it seemed, hadn’t bothered to change, though a number wore bright Hawaiian shirts. Some of them matched, whether by intention or by e-commerce algorithm. They batted the balloons into the air, kicking them and bopping each other on the head until a chaperon, tooting on a whistle, intervened.

Mira arrived with her friends, wearing the pink dress and a pair of Air Force 1s. Sloane, who was dressed elegantly in a brown sheath, carried a little purple flower in a plastic cone proffered by Leo, who wore tuxedo pants and kept a restraining-order distance. The group quickly availed themselves of the refreshments—pizza, lemonade, lunchbox-size bags of chips. There was the sense that nobody quite knew what to do next. It was a far cry from the middle-school dances I remembered from the late nineties, where classmates ground against each other to R. Kelly and otherwise performed a fetid, M.T.V. sexuality they did not quite inhabit in ordinary, lights-on life. (“It should have started at five,” Mira said.) Then the d.j.s put on “Golden,” from the “KPop Demon Hunters” soundtrack, and suddenly the floor was swarmed with children hopping up and down, chanting the lyrics, shaking the linoleum. They formed a circle, holding hands, pulling each other around as if they were doing the hora.

The d.j.s announced a best-dressed contest, and Mira and her friends lined up for judgment. The idea struck me as cruel, but then “Single Ladies” came on, and one by one the kids ran to the front, stunted, and were received by a roar of positivity. When it was Mira’s turn, she did three theatrical twirls, ruffles swirling, and her classmates screamed in appreciation. Sloane won,

and was mobbed. Mira and her friends began shoving Sloane toward Leo, with no success. The dance floor split into two groups: the girls danced in a circle, while the boys formed a conga line, looping nervously around them. Mira entered the middle of the circle, pirouetting and curtsying, kicking her leg above her head. When Tommy Richman's "Million Dollar Baby" came on, she dropped to the floor and, in a display that was oddly moving, did the literal worm.

Watching Mira and her chatty, cheerful gaggle, it was strange to know, with no necessary qualifications other than having once been a preteen girl myself, that within the next year, or two, or three, they would be pulled into all manner of minor dramas and major insecurities, make transformative cultural discoveries, experience lifelong personal revelations. They'd have crushes, keep secrets, be teased, or be cruel. They'd be tempted to betray themselves or others. They'd outgrow their own taste, pull away from their siblings, stop laughing so hard and so freely at their parents' jokes. They'd toss the heavily flavored balms and bottles of candy-scented spritz in the subsequent room refresh, time capsules from the final season of childhood.

Around four-thirty, someone initiated a game of limbo. The speakers were blasting Zara Larsson, and the vibe was high. Mira leaned back, shimmied under the limbo ribbon, then popped up, grinning, and shot her arms out triumphantly. She rejoined her friends, looking radiant and exhilarated, and did an exaggerated sprinkler at the end of the limbo line. Her smile was wide; her outfit was eating. She wouldn't win, but it didn't matter. She'd gone under, and made it safely to the other side. ♦

Comeback Kids

The distinctly American and remarkably intense world of high-school debate.

By Eli Durst, Jay Caspian Kang

May 04, 2026



One of America's sunnier national convictions is that when people disagree it is useful, even virtuous, for competing sides to make their cases to the public. We wrap this belief in decorum and sometimes in misleading history—the famed Lincoln-Douglas debates looked more like soccer-hooligan meetups than like any genteel vision of measured discourse in wood-panelled rooms. We do, though, believe in debate, and not merely out of a hope that we can talk through our differences, but because the combat of ideas feels intrinsic to the national spirit. Debate has a duality; it is simultaneously conciliatory and domineering. We believe we can resolve our differences because we believe that a good new idea can trounce a bad old one.



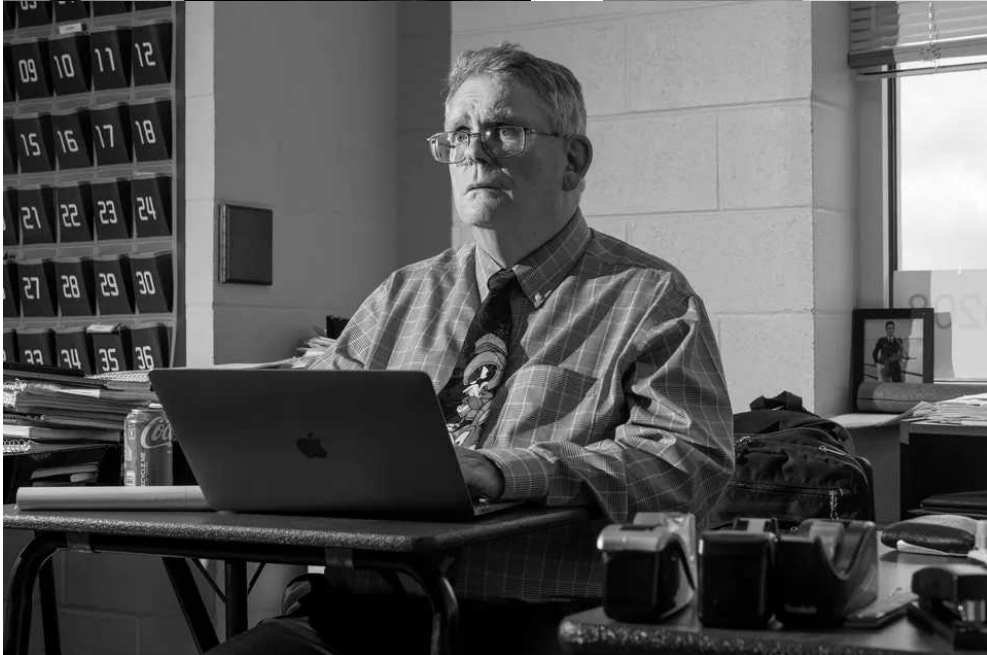
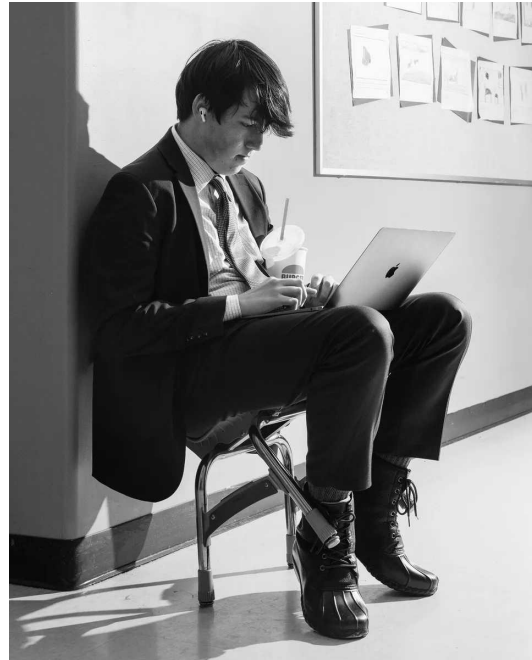


The kids in these photographs are from Arkansas, California, Florida, and Pennsylvania. They travelled to district and national tournaments to debate legislation about Venezuelan oil and the morality of nuclear weapons in space. If you ask them what they love about debate, as I did recently, they will speak about the value of “multiple perspectives,” but other interests will also surface. Mallory Cloud, from Russellville, Arkansas, wants to be a state representative. Carter Nelson, of Palm Beach County, told me, “I’ve always loved competition in general.”



My high-school years were spent much like theirs. On weekends, I put on a button-up shirt and my dad's tie and rode in a van to debate tournaments in Greensboro and Raleigh. These were held at high schools filled with gawky kids in suits that always fit badly but never in the same way: the tie was too long, the pants or the skirt too small, the jacket was borrowed from an older sibling. I'd post up in the corner of a cafeteria that smelled of industrial cleaner and old French fries and visualize the trophy I was about to win. I did Policy, a tedious and somewhat insane form of debate, in which a team

of two presents a plan to uphold that year's resolution—this year's is “The United States federal government should establish national health insurance”—and the other side uses everything from procedural fouls to nuclear-war scenarios to show that the plan is a bad idea.





There are other forms at these contests: Lincoln-Douglas, the classic; Congressional Debate, which simulates the passage of legislation; and, more recently, Public Forum, which was originally called Ted Turner Debate, because it's modelled on the panels of pundits you see on CNN. But those seemed better suited to people who wanted to win hearts and minds through stirring oratory. Policy favored the monsters who plot in the background, more Kissinger than Kennedy. Each speech in Policy is time-limited; kids speak like gasping auctioneers to cram in arguments their opponents must try to rebut. The judge—sometimes a teacher, sometimes a parent who may not understand a word that the overstimulated speed-readers in the front of the room are saying—tries to track all the shouting and scores the result.



Within a debate round, nothing is assumed. If you assert that unhinged rantings on social media are more trustworthy than an article in the *Times*, your opponent can't simply scoff. Similarly, if you want to argue that health care should not be expanded because more people need to die to prevent resource wars that could wipe out humanity, you're free to do so, and to confidently cite Thomas Malthus's 1798 "Essay on the Principle of Population" in the effort. This freedom from conventional assumptions was, for me, both the draw of debate and its abiding lesson. Debate also taught

me about extraordinary renditions and about the nutritional value of spirulina. It forced me to read everyone from William F. Buckley to Judith Butler. And it taught me that I did not have to respect the institutional freight that accompanied any particular author or article.



I'll admit that I was not thinking, back then, about the discursive spirit of America. I just wanted to win, and to say crazy things about the impending end of the world. I suppose one can argue that converting ethical and political questions into a high-speed game for arrogant children is bad for society, especially given how many former debate kids have filled the halls of our dysfunctional Congress. Maybe children should not learn to regard truth in such a flexible way; maybe they should not embrace Malthus just to beat their rivals from Northwest Guilford. But what these kids are learning is how to build an account of the world from the ground up. And nothing—particularly in a polarized country a mere two hundred and fifty years old—feels more important than insuring that new ideas find their way into the minds of young people in bad suits. ♦



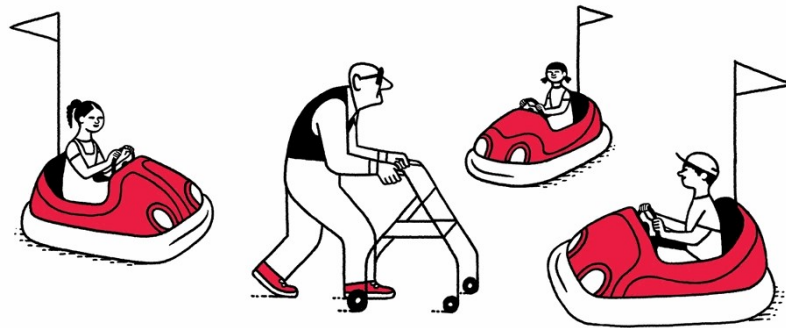
Shouts & Murmurs

- [Senior-Discount Disneyland](#)

Senior-Discount Disneyland

By Ian Frazier

May 04, 2026



NOTE: You must be at least seven and a half decades old to go on these rides.

Pirates of the Caribbean Cruise

This attraction has no Caribbean per se and no real cruise to speak of, but it does offer pirates who will plunder everything that isn't nailed down in your semi-private residential unit while you are at your weekly clay class.

Before the end of the voyage, a lucky few will be swept away to a new wing where there's said to be less theft.

Mr. Toad's Wild Ride to the Urologist

Hop into the passenger seat of Mr. Toad's jazzed-up roadster as he careers through gardens, farmers' markets, rotaries, strip malls, children's birthday parties, and crowded parking lots, finally arriving just in time at the

urologist's office, where Mr. Toad's appointment has been cancelled but they couldn't get in touch to tell him because the network was down.

The Tunnel of Nap

A gondola floats you into a dark channel as you drift, gently rocking with the current, while music plays, but nobody can hear it, because your snoring is so incredibly loud. At nine o'clock this morning, you got out of bed and dressed, as you have been told to do every day, and you remember eating breakfast at nine-thirty, and the clock at the entrance to the Tunnel said 11:30 *a.m.* when you went in, and the clock at the exit of the Tunnel said 3 *p.m.* when you came out, and you must have somehow napped through lunch, and can that possibly be right?

Dodge-'Ems Bumper Cars Crosswalk Scramble

White lines on the pavement and brightly flashing yellow lights on prominent signs insure that every bumper car, no matter how fast it is going or what other cars are bumping into it, will stop when you step into the crosswalk—because *that's the law!*

Laugh in the Dusk

Enter a foggy party-time land where voices say things that might be jokes, but you can't be sure, because in all the exciting ambient noise it's hard to pick out any one thing that anybody is saying, so you laugh at everything, just to be on the safe side. Wellness guidelines recommend that all seniors laugh at least twice a day for good health, but they don't say what to laugh at, or even whether you need to hear or understand, just as long as you laugh.

The "Found Your Glasses!" Joyride

Someplace nearby yet far away, your glasses are lost, and there's no one to help you on your journey to find them, because you know you did something with them yourself; and, halfway through the ride, you seem to remember that you left them in your handbag, and the ride swoops in for a closer look, but they're not there, *they're not there*, and where can they be? And now the ride's end approaches, and still no glasses, but maybe you left them in the car, and the ride swerves by the garage, and you open the car door, and you feel in the cup holder, *and there they are! You have found your glasses!* And you put them on, and you are so happy, because you were starting to think

you would never find them, and would have to go back to Nogales for a new pair; and even better, your senior-discount ticket is unlimited, so you can (and will) have this happy sensation again and again.

The Cyclone

This is an actual midlatitude Category 4 cyclone (weather permitting). Our Sensurround Widescreen shows you Fort Myers, Florida (or wherever the storm makes landfall), in real time, and you can rejoice because you knew enough not to retire in Hurricane Alley, for God's sake, unlike the poor Hildebrandts.

Matterhorn Mountain Log-Flume Splashdown

Put on your rain pants and waterproof parkas for this one—rain gloves and waterproof boots and a sou'wester hat would be a good idea, too, and pack plenty of thirsty towels in a waterproof tote, and a flask of brandy, and the emergency number of the Swiss Alpine Hypothermia Team—and prepare for an experience.

Authentic Old-Time Small-Town Main Street

Stroll this period-perfect Main Street where they still have a Beefsteak Charlie's, a Bell Atlantic office, a Chemical Bank, and other nostalgic features.

If you will be travelling to Senior-Discount Disneyland by air, stand in one of the security lines that stretch out the airport doors, argue bitterly with your spouse, rent a car, take I-95 to the Sprain Brook Parkway, and head south. Near Orlando, turn left onto Water Tower Road, slight right onto Water Tower Road (The Sequel), then hard right to rejoin Water Tower Road. Begin weeping. Through your tears, see a brief, shimmering vision of What Might Have Been. Continue straight until "Wrong Way" sign threatens severe tire damage. Remember it's only a rental. Proceed. ♦

Fiction

- [Mapping Trump's America](#)
- [Standings](#)

Fiction

Standings

By Chang-rae Lee

May 03, 2026



My given name, Jeon-Gi, with a hard “G,” was one that some of the kids in my apartment complex enjoyed deforming. Chun-ky, Chun-ky. As kids do, they were weaponizing a truth, for I was a chunky child, bordering on fat thanks to my one-a-day habit of a large Snickers bar. My mother would stock boxes of these for me as long as I ate the food she made, which I happily did. She and I were a tight pair that way, co-conspirators in a plot to insure that my whims were fully indulged, as I was her firstborn and her only son. In the ensuing years, I would become uncomfortably aware of the expectation behind that spoiling—to be No. 1 in my studies, in my sports, even in my citizenship, such as being elected class president—all of which I wanted very much to realize for her and lavishly envisioned for myself but could never achieve, given my natural laziness and lack of resolve, let alone talent. But back then, in the spring of 1976, a couple of months away from turning eleven, I had no idea that it might be tough to get there.

Cove Gardens, where my family lived, was a sprawling red brick rental complex built after the war for the light-industrial, service, and clerical workers who were saving up for their own houses in a better area. Our neighbors were Blacks and Puerto Ricans, working-class Irish and Italians, and some Jews who hadn't yet moved on, plus the legions of us new immigrants, from Asia and Eastern Europe and the Caribbean, who'd ended up in this commuter town north of New York City. The whole diverse lot of us, before diversity was an operative notion, made a mix that seemed natural and right, despite how tense and fraught it could sometimes be. Was our gang all "friends"? I suppose we were. We were mostly boys and young enough—we ranged in age from eight to twelve—that the bonds felt fierce, like in a tribe, tourniquet tight, yet our tribe was fuelled by constant disagreements, contentions, sometimes outright bloodletting, which made everything seem dire and fragile. I rarely saw anyone's parents or guardians, or ventured into their apartments, and it was easy to believe that we somehow existed on our own.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

Our apartment-complex alpha, Cleon Washington, was a handsome, tall, soft-spoken kid who had his own devoted crew and was a champ at every sport and game, and although he didn't always join in, we couldn't help but saunter in his way and speak in his laconic style and attempt to impress him with our physical zeal, if not skills. He often sported a pick in his perfect halo of an Afro, and my mother was perplexed by my request for one, which she bought me anyway, and which I'd futilely try to perch in my limp, straight hair. A totem to ward off the others. To be a kid, though, was to be bullied. No exceptions. Even Cleon had to deal with his much older brothers and their crew.

But when it came to my family, to life with my parents and my younger sister, Ella, I knew only a princely feeling, its weekend herald my mother's velvety voice calling from our kitchen window, which looked out onto the playground and abutting patch of field.

Jeon-Gi ya! Jeon-Gi ya!

Wa-suh chum-shim muh-guh!

Come and eat lunch!

On Sundays, my father would often drive us across the Whitestone Bridge to a Gothic-style Presbyterian church in Flushing, Queens, that leased the afternoon-service slot to a Reverend Hahn for his growing ministry. My parents were happily secular people, but they badly craved hearing their native language, even if it came in sermons and hymns, and eagerly awaited the post-service tea hour.

While our parents socialized, my sister and I played out in the parking lot with the other kids, all recent Korean immigrants like us, and although you'd think we'd instantly bond, there was always a momentary whiff of contempt before the start of our games, all of us sizing one another up to determine who was fresher off the boat, more foreign and weird. These were fine discernments, often coming down to the strangeness of some kid's sneakers or shirt or haircut. I don't recall any of the sort of taunting and name-calling we had at the apartment complex, but there was patent discrimination, the ones who couldn't yet speak any English usually picked last for dodgeball or stickball, at least until they'd proved their skill. The friendships were fleeting, necessarily occasional, as there were always church newcomers and samplers and people moving away. I could never keep track of the other kids' names, and I was always reminding them of mine.

But back home at Cove Gardens, without even realizing it, I had completely acculturated to the tumult and machinations of our gang, even if that meant suffering the not so random bouts of terror and misery.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[*Listen to Chang-rae Lee read "Standings."*](#)

Along with Cleon and his running mates, there were the Irish-heritage kids and the Italian-heritage kids and the Jewish Joshuas, plus a gaggle of other kids whose names I can't quite remember. I am grouping us now as I grouped us then, which is loosely by ethnicity or ancestry, the only ways that made any sense to me. I would have been happily grouped with another Oriental—the only polite term by which I knew myself—but there were no others around my age, and so I had to bear alone any diatribes, epithets, stereotypes, all flung about with great bluster and ignorance in the context of

our bristling group friendship. The few times that being Oriental was to my benefit were when there was a question of numbers (like the comparing of individual batting averages in baseball teams' starting lineups, which I studied daily in the sports section of the newspaper) or doing real math, which I was assumed to be good at. To be honest, I was only ever good at basic math but was swift in my calculations and recall, and this helped me gain the confidence of a popular boy, Paul Dipinto, a cheerful, voluble kid who still used his fingers to figure out three plus four and entrusted me with his one-dollar or two-dollar or sometimes five-dollar bill (his dad owned a deli and regularly gave him cash) to pay the Good Humor man for the two of us. I would add the twenty-five or thirty-five cents I owed for my ice-cream bar and then give Paul the change, but one time I accidentally shorted him by a dime—I found it on the sidewalk after he skipped away obliviously scooping at his Screwball—and after that I would slip ten or twenty-five or even forty of his cents in my back pocket. I liked Paul and Paul liked me, but because I loved ice cream and because I could, I skimmed him almost every time.

I was constantly afraid he'd confront me, but he never did. And the funny thing about it was that I ended up thinking him pitiful because of what I was perpetrating—I saw him as being too trusting and weak, saw that he had no idea of how things truly were, not in the way I did, and was thus doomed to being taken advantage of again and again. Even as his esteem of me grew I began to despise him.

My problem with Joshua Messing was somewhat related, as it stemmed from the general perception that he and I were the smartest kids in our gang, which certainly wasn't true (Cleon Washington was the smartest, in every way, including, it was known, by his report card), and this notion somehow cast us as rivals despite the fact that very few of our Cove Gardens activities had anything to do with brains. Joshua Messing was admired for his ballsy, aggressive style of play and for the many jokes he told and puns he made in his distinctively husky voice, which sounded almost like a grown woman's. We couldn't help but pay attention to him, if not heed him, which was usually fine because he told funny stories and enjoyed deploying anatomical insults that we loved learning, as in "Your smile is like a rectum." He had older sisters and so could extemporize with brio about various types of tampons and bras, and he could belch and fart at will.

I didn't want or need to be rivals, nor did Joshua, but the idea of our tangling for supremacy wormed deep into his head and he began insulting me, though without the usual verve. He'd make good-natured fun of my sometimes "garbage can" breath (if I had eaten kimchi at lunch) and the "pukey colors" of my trousers (an inexpensive Sears brand my mother bought me called Toughskins, which came in scar red and pus yellow and death-mask blue, and which were decidedly not tough skinned, as I eventually split every pair in the crack), but one day during a water-fountain break I saw him mugging anticlally for a couple of boys while making slanty eyes with his fingers. Then they saw me and snickered, Joshua turning and facing me for a long second before dropping his hands.

I planned to ask him about it the next day, but when the time came I couldn't, mostly because I had convinced myself that he wasn't specifically targeting me, and thus it didn't matter. Besides, I could almost understand why one wouldn't want such eyes, for who really would? I'd been asked both innocuously and maliciously whether I could see through mine. It had happened enough that I once spent an entire afternoon opening my eyes as wide as I could, to see if that made any difference, and succeeded only in giving myself a bad headache. A few days later, in the middle of a three-on-three basketball game, I forcefully nudged Joshua under the hoop to give myself space to shoot, and he shoved me hard and knocked the ball from me, crying, "Offensive foul, chinky chow!"

The game stopped. Joshua appeared as surprised as any of us, craning around as if the words had been blurted by someone on the periphery. I was struck silent, as I still am when challenged. I'd been called names before, but always by someone outside our gang. We'd all done it to other unfamiliar kids. A present-day onlooker would be appalled by the infinite variety of racist and ethnic slurs we lobbed at each other at that tender age, terms that we didn't fully understand but employed with the most casual élan.

Yet to have one lobbed at me intramurally, and by a good buddy like Joshua Messing, made my gut feel as though it were packed with wet sand, too heavy even to vomit. Finally, Cleon, who'd been flipping baseball cards with Berto and Juany courtside, picked up the loose basketball and zipped it to Joshua and muttered, "Just play the game, punks." John Wayne would be Cleon if John Wayne could ever imagine being that cool.

After a brief interlude of distracted play, the game got vigorous and testy. When either of us had the ball, we drove ferociously to the basket, shoulders and elbows leading, ankles flared to trip the other, and tried to score right away. Thrilled by our warring, our respective teammates took up the vibe and kept feeding us the ball, and by the time I scored the decisive basket the contest had become so intense and consuming that Joshua and I couldn't help but slap each other a hearty low-five, albeit with our eyes averted. He seemed to have got the message that he had crossed the line. But I wasn't ready to forgive him. Instead, I felt the compulsion to act upon my little world and thereby alter it, whether for better or worse. So, when Joshua asked me if I'd form a fresh squad with him after mine lost our next game, there was no hesitation.

"Sure thing, kike."

I'd never uttered such a word before, though apparently I was aware of it. I had no idea what it meant. But you could tell by Joshua's expression, one I instantly recognized, that a special button had been pushed, a button that powers everything down, momentarily untethering him from gravity and time so that he was floating distressingly free, to be batted about like a cheap party balloon. It simultaneously pleased and frightened me, to see such raw, just-birthered astonishment in someone else.

"*What'd* you say?"

"Nothin', kike."

He pushed me hard, and I pushed him hard back, and then he jumped me, clawing at the back of my neck and ear. Kids were shouting, "Fight, fight!," and I could hear Berto and Juany cackling as we flailed and tangoed in our clumsy baby-cub tussle. Finally, someone pulled Joshua off me. It was Cleon.

"You gotta settle this right," he said, holding Joshua by the collar with one hand and stiff-arming me with the other.

"Let's get 'em in the Ring!" Juany suggested, and it seemed everyone else cried out in assent.

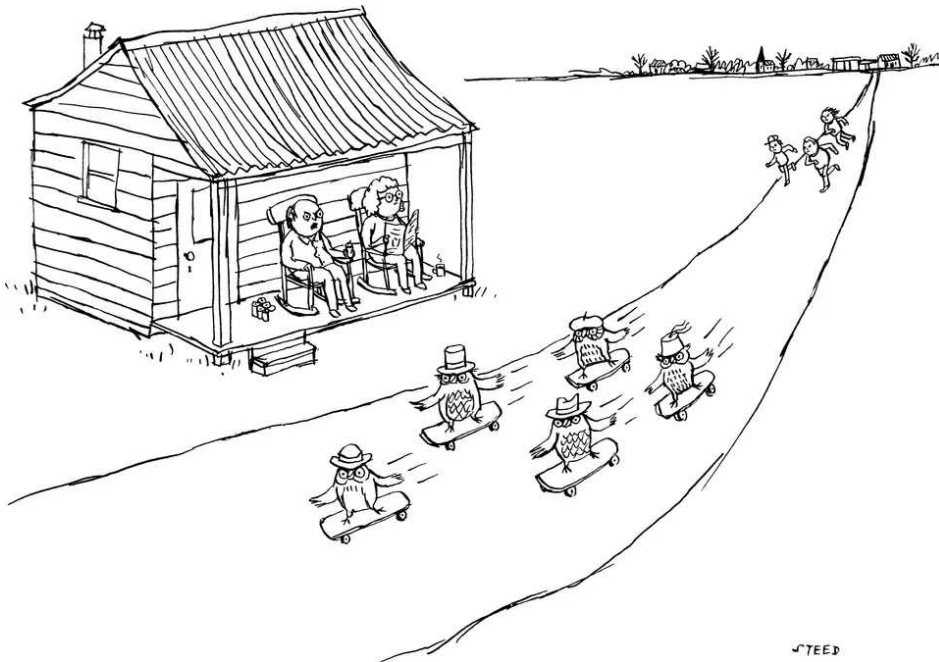
“You want to do this?” Cleon asked us. “The Ring” was a kind of fight club that Berto and Juany would arrange for kids who had serious beefs with each other or maybe just felt like fighting, with Cleon serving as the referee. Fighting with Joshua Messing was not something I could decline with everyone standing by, and especially with Cleon asking.

I nodded, as did Joshua, both of us unable to muster any new slurs or brave words.

“Juany will set it up,” Cleon announced. “You punks, be ready.”

Tommy Reilly wasn’t part of our gang, or anyone else’s. But he, too, was troubling me. He lived in the uppermost building of the apartment complex, in C, which we referred to as the Fort, as it was perched on an exposed granite rise that had a commanding vista over the grounds. I underscore where Tommy lived because that’s how I mostly saw him, positioned on high, gazing down at the rest of us as if we were mere crawly creatures that were riddling his realm. Something was profoundly wrong with him, I can see that now, but back then the many ornate ways that he was haywire appeared to constitute a pure, hard menace. He was frightening enough that he seemed to be more a wraith than an actual person, let alone a stocky, baby-teeth-missing, ginger-haired kid just one grade above me.

I first met him at our elementary school, which happened to be only an eight-minute walk (or a three-minute sprint) from the west side of Cove Gardens, the route passing through a man-size tear in a cyclone fence that opened onto an often marshy stretch of cattails that then bordered the baseball field of the school. The U-shaped school building framed the baseball diamond, and before and after the school day there was usually a group of us running around the bases, vying for the fastest lap, the time kept by a kid who had an official stopwatch, lanyard and all. I never won but I regularly came in third or fourth, sometimes second, which stung less than you’d think because (if he was there) the winner was always Mehm, a wispy Turkish kid who ran in these rhythmic, almost slow-motion-looking strides that kicked up no dirt, his fisted hands held high in front of each shoulder.



Anyway, it was very lightly raining that day so most of the usuals, Mehm included, weren't there. It was just me and Stopwatch Stu and a couple of tubby younger kids I knew I could beat. The dirt-only diamond was loamy and soft and home plate was totally submerged in a muddy puddle, a tributary of which also snaked down the third-base line. With a stick, Stu drew a plate in the mud alongside the puddle. The little porkers huffed through their laps, their footing giving way at various points, and then I ran mine, vigorously but prudently, slowing and widening my turn before each base so I wouldn't slip and fall. When I touched Stu's triangular home plate I knew there was no contest.

Then this kid who was my height but much more muscular appeared in the backstop. "My turn now," he said, wiping his nose with his wrist. His orangey hair nearly matched a color in his brand-new Miami Dolphins jersey, the number thirty-nine spangly and bright. He got down like a sprinter on the blocks next to the puddle and dropped his bluejeaned knee right in the muck. Stopwatch Stu squeaked "Go!" and he bolted, his back sneaker gouging a foot-long trough in the mud. It seemed certain that he would spin out, but his stockiness and short, powerful strides centered him as he pounded around the bases. He kept gaining speed and, as he turned for home, I knew I had no chance.

I expected that he'd skid on the drawn plate or maybe slow down and triumphantly stomp on it, knowing he had time to burn. Instead, he kept coming, low to the ground, rocketing down the third-base line as though a catcher were there with the ball already in his mitt and had to be bowled over. And whatever any of us had in mind was instantly erased by how he finished, which was by sliding chest first into the submerged home plate, sending out plumes of brown water like a ferocious little seaplane landing in a swamp. I don't know if Stu ever clicked his stopwatch, because nobody bothered to ask. We were stupefied, watching this kid hop to his feet as if nothing had happened, the front of his new jersey and his jeans thickly mortared with infield mud.

Stu asked him with hushed awe what his name was, and Tommy simply cracked a grin and like a prizefighter stuck his nose in his own armpit while tapping at the bulge he was making of his biceps.

Afterward, he came up alongside me while I was walking home. The late-spring sun had broken out and his clothes were still sodden—you could smell the live funk of wet earth on him, as though he'd crawled up from the depths. He didn't say anything until we passed through the opening in the fence onto the Cove Gardens property.

"Where are you from?" His voice was harsh and nasal, delivered from the throat, like a kid version of the Burgess Meredith portrayal of the Penguin in "Batman," which was my favorite TV show.

I pointed to Building A. I didn't have to ask him where he lived, as I now recognized him as the kid who hung out on the rocky crags of the Fort.

"I mean, where do you come from?" He peered hotly into my face. "Are you Chinese?"

I shook my head, knowing from experience how this exchange would go: he would now ask if I was Japanese; I'd say no; then what was I, he'd wonder; "Korean," I'd say; he'd ask, "What is that?," to which I'd offer, "Kind of in between," not knowing exactly how or why or what that meant, to which he'd murmur, "Korean," usually in a confused, skeptical tone.

Tommy, however, did none of this.

“Uh-uh,” he grunted, touching his dirt-caked knuckles to my chest. “You look Chinese.”

“I’m not,” I protested, if weakly.

“I already figured that you are,” he said, and then with his thumb he pushed me, not hard, not angrily, but squarely enough on my sternum that his force radiated through the rest of me.

“Later, alligator,” he said, without a speck of friendliness or irony. He walked away, then bounded up the concrete steps that led to his building, taking them in twos, then threes, his exhalations whistling through his missing teeth.

Once I got home and my mother asked how the school day had been, I told her nothing much had gone on. In fact, I blocked out this very odd boy, stress-napping during “The 4:30 Movie” on Channel 7 despite it being “War Week,” featuring Second World War films like “Flying Leathernecks” and “Air Force.” I loved those movies for the very reason they were made—namely, because they highlighted American war machinery and the righteous fight against tyranny, even if some of the maniacal “dirty Japs” piloting the opposing Zero fighter planes looked like my father and my nightmares had him grabbing at his face with black blood gushing between his fingers after getting shot up by a square-jawed American ace.

While I kept my eye out for another appearance by Tommy, I began to hear rumors about him from kids in the playground. Someone knew someone’s brother who dated Tommy’s second cousin who lived in Building B. It was true that he had no friends in the complex. He’d only moved into Cove Gardens the year before, and never came down to play, at least with others. His parents (or maybe grandparents) owned several gas stations and were always out dealing with their employees and picking up large volumes of cash, which was why Tommy was kind of wild, having essentially raised himself, and why he wore expensive pro-sports jerseys and brand-new Pumas and had cool stuff like a medieval battle-axe, with which Gregory Fluss swore he saw him splitting a pumpkin up on the ledge.

It was the heart of spring, a couple of months remaining in the school year, and I was occupied enough by homework and chess club and piano lessons and Little League practices and my extra reading—my teacher and my mother and I decided I would participate in as many reading competitions and library groups as possible, to make certain that I fully mastered English—that my after-school playtime shrank to brief games of catch or flipping baseball cards with some of the Cove Gardens gang. I was also getting ready for my fight with Joshua Messing, jumping rope, shadowboxing, doing sit-ups and pushups, even staring at myself in the mirror and picturing my face bruised up but steely and valiant. The fight, though, kept getting delayed. We both had plenty of excuses. He had Hebrew school on Saturdays, on Sundays I went to Queens, we both had birthday parties and family outings, and there were rainy days when nobody wanted to do anything.

One day after school, just as I had emerged on the Cove Gardens side of the cyclone fencing, I heard a rustling behind me in the chronically neglected, weed-choked grounds. Then something ticked to the side of me, closer. I scanned the thickets of crabgrass and clover, listening for any movement, but I could hear only the tiny sawing of bumblebees alighting and hovering. I took a step, then another. Suddenly I felt a sting on the back of my calf and then watched as a fat drop of dark-red blood emerged from the center of a fresh welt.

Another tick in the grass, and almost simultaneously a cracker-size shard of stone ricocheted up from the hard dirt and glanced off my hip. I instinctively flashed with anger for Joshua, but I looked up and saw Tommy positioned on one of the rock ledges. He was bent on one knee, in a shooter's pose, exactly like that of some of my green plastic toy soldiers, and was pulling back the long band of a slingshot, smiling wide. I wanted to run but I couldn't; it seemed I had no limbs. Then he launched it. The stone, a little white-hot comet, flew in a tight, mean line across the expanse. It must have been a pure animal reaction, because something instructed me to tip my head slightly to the side, and I tracked the stone as it travelled soundlessly past my temple, a disturbance registering only in my deepest inner ear.

“That’s dangerous!” I wailed, this sounding of my own fear finally prodding me to scramble, that and Tommy’s gargly cackling at my panic. I ran half crooked, my neck and back tensed against an imminent strike. When I got

home, I went straight to the bedroom I shared with Ella, who was playing teatime with her dolls. I told her to get out. She protested, saying that everything was already set up, but I shouted at her and she calmly collected the teacups and plates and fake cakes in the straw tray she kept it all in and left, her face soured.

That evening, after dinner, my mother came into the bathroom while I was brushing my teeth and sat on the seat of the toilet. She checked my hair to see if I needed to wash it and casually asked me if something was wrong. I shook my head, keeping the toothbrush working vigorously and long enough that she simply kissed me good night and left. I had nightmares that I couldn't remember but which made my heart thump me awake. As for Tommy, I was obsessing not so much about him as about the staggering potential of what he'd done. What if one of those sharp-edged stones had hit me directly? I could have been blinded or worse!

Heading to school in the morning, I took a different route to the hole in the fence, widely skirting the playground and basketball court, all the while scanning the airspace and ledges of the Fort for any suspicious movements, projectiles, ginger-hued hair. Nothing. If anything, it was scarier not seeing any signs at school of Tommy, whom I didn't happen upon that day in the building. After dismissal I didn't stick around. My mother was surprised to see me back home so early but she didn't show any outward concern. Instead, she fixed a snack for me and my sister, a salami-and-pickle sandwich, and watched as I idly nibbled at my half.

"You don't want to go play?" my mother wondered aloud as she was dusting the TV.

"I don't know. I have a lot of long division to do."

I was glad that the next day was a school day, as I could simply run there and back and in between keep my head down during class. I was planning a repeat for the next day, Friday, and was relieved to hear from my mother at breakfast that we would be spending the weekend in New Jersey with our family friends the Lims (even though I didn't like having to play with their too friendly, babyish kids), but after school, just as I passed through the hole in the fence, a voice called out.

“Bruce!”

It was Tommy, standing at the base of the Fort.

“My Bruce!”

There was no one else around, but even if there had been, I’d have known he was addressing me. Periodically I’d get called Bruce by friends and strangers alike, in both friendly jest and as a taunt. It was pointless to try to correct them about Bruce Lee’s roots versus mine, plus sometimes it was advantageous to allow them to attach to me the spectre of deadly inborn skills; my hero Cleon even once took me aside and asked if I was good at kung fu. I smiled and didn’t answer. With Tommy, though, it was different. I desperately wanted to flee, but everybody knows you shouldn’t run from an aggressive animal—in fact, you had to make yourself bigger somehow and stand your ground or even advance on the beast. Was that still true if the animal had been patiently waiting for you?

He tossed something that landed near my feet. I froze, simply trying not to look at him.

“Come on, champ, pick it up.”

It was a brushed gunmetal ninja star, five-pointed and surprisingly heavy, the kind martial-arts actors hurl at their foes. This throwing star was especially sinister; it could feature in a sadistic underworld rite, the knife-sharp inside edges of its hollow star-shaped middle painted a glossy blood-red.

“You’ve thrown ’em before, right?”

I tried to shake my head, but my body was vibrating with what it already understood would happen next: Tommy held up another ninja star and waved it.

“Doesn’t matter,” he said, taking a step toward me. He lifted his shirt. His torso was just like a G.I. Joe’s, hard-looking and defined, not to mention a pale putty color. “I’ll let you go first.” He touched a point of his star to his heart. “If you get me right here, you could kill me instantly.”

I don't know what frightened me more, the imminent duel he was proposing or the spellbound tone of his pronouncement.



Tommy advanced another couple of yards, the distance between us maybe the span between the mound and first base. He set his feet, taking up his notion of a hero's stance, his bared chest puffed out, his teeth clenched, ready to be spiked up on the cross of his own dark design.

"Hey!" he yelled. "Let's go!"

"I don't want to," I peeped, hardly audible even to myself.

"Yeah, you do!" he commanded.

In my panic, I began to curse, not at Tommy but at myself, in Korean no less. I cursed from the position of my father, who never actually got cross with me when I committed a genuine wrong (and instead sat me down and soberly explained why he was disappointed in me), but would merely faux-scold and gently noogie me with his index knuckle.

Of course, Tommy had no idea of what I was saying, or why. He let his shirt fall back down. The foreign sounds made his face crimp, as if somebody right next to him had farted. I could see the disgust building in him, this

stiffness in his brief stretch of thick, terrierlike neck, and although I might still have been gibbering, I had bent my head low in full submission to my fate, this last dazed moment in the abattoir.

“What you standing there for, little man?”

It was Cleon, accompanied by Berto, heading for the court with a shiny new red-white-and-blue A.B.A. basketball under his arm. I started to whimper and reached out to Cleon as if for a lifeline, but Berto barred me from him as though I had the plague.

“Yo, don’t let him touch the ball! Punk is bleedin’!”

I quickly scanned myself, and, to my shock, there were a couple of drops of bright-red blood on the white rubber toe cap of one of my sneakers. I crumpled to the ground, listing against my book bag. Tommy had nailed me and nailed me good.

“Hey,” Cleon said softly, kneeling by my side. “What you got there? Come on, now.”

I would have hugged him around the neck right then, as if he were the solicitous, protective big brother I always longed for, but Cleon flinched at my momentum and firmly grabbed my wrist with one hand and with the other carefully pried the ninja star from my fingers.

“Damn, J.-G., what the hell you doing with this?”

For some reason I cried, “I found it!”

He tested the points with his fingers.

“This shit is *sharp*.”

He wasn’t complimenting me; I had been gripping the star so tightly that I’d cut my index finger on one of the edges. I looked back toward Tommy, but he’d disappeared. Cleon slipped off his red terry-cloth wristband and had me press it against the weeping slash.

“I’m sorry,” I blubbered. “I’ll get you a new one, I promise.”

“No sweat, slick,” Cleon said. “We’re cool. Just heal up.” He gave the star to Berto, who inspected it closely before slipping it into the back pocket of his jean shorts.

Berto said, “You still gonna fight, right? Get in the Ring? Or you gonna pussy out?”

“I’ll fight,” I insisted, though my words sounded as if they were someone else’s unconvincing promise. “I’ll heal up. I’ll be ready soon.”

“Go easy, champ,” Cleon said, as he and Berto headed to the courts. “Peace.”

When I got home, I went directly to the bathroom and dabbed on the antibiotic ointment my parents always seemed to be plying us with and put a bandage around my finger. As much as I wanted to keep it, I threw the bloodstained wristband in the wastebasket, covering it with tissue paper. While my mother served me and my sister an after-school snack of Danish butter cookies and milk, she asked what had happened and I said I had accidentally nicked myself with the paper cutter at school. She used the occasion to remind me that I should be extra careful in everything I did, as usual expanding on the precept that we were alone in this country, that we couldn’t count on anyone to help us. I kept turning through the possibilities. What if Cleon and Berto hadn’t been on their way to the basketball court just then? What if Tommy had launched, as he had with the slingshot, an unannounced first strike? How would I have shielded myself, or struck back? All I had was my pussy Batman book bag with its matching plastic pencil case and batwing-shaped rubber erasers.

Meanwhile, Ella was explaining to my mother why the teacher had sent a note home with her and recounting how her friend Stacy had played kitchen with a new girl during free time at school and allowed Ella to join them only for the cleanup part. All of this was driving me mad; I had my own troubles.

Finally, I snapped at Ella, telling her that she should just forget about Stacy.

“She’s my best friend!” Ella hollered back.

“What kind of best friend is that?”

“She can braid my hair!”

“Wow, that’s super.”

“You don’t know anything about anything!”

“Yeah, I know you’re not Stacy’s favorite.”

Ella shoved me, making me spill some milk on the table. For her, this was practically homicidal aggression. Our mother yowled—she reviled every kind of mess—and ordered me to do my homework. She and Ella would walk to the nearby convenience store for a loaf of bread.

“When we get back, you’re going to clean up your bedroom together,” she decreed. “And if you do a poor job, you’ll clean the bathroom as well.”

Ella stuck her tongue out at me, and as they left the apartment, I covertly flipped them the finger while I crossed my arms, a move I’d learned from an unruly kid in my class. I felt sordid and foul and instantly wanted to take it back, but once I was alone the shame hardened into an ingot of rage, rage not toward them but toward the situation with Tommy, which, in addition to petrifying me, revealed the truth of how little control I had over my own life. I might as well have been one of the ants or beetles that my friends and I regularly surveilled with a magnifying glass, the articulations of their antennae and joints and the filigreed armor of their bodies wondrous enough to make them seem sacred and yet they were nothing under a hard thumb or the lasering ray of the lens, the scent of burnt carapace vaguely fishy and grim to inhale but quickly gone.

I picked through my bin of sports equipment in our closet to see what I could use against Tommy or to protect myself with. The most useful thing would have been my football helmet and shoulder pads, but I certainly couldn’t walk to school suited up like that, or stroll into class wielding a baseball bat.

I headed to the kitchen. I often found myself there, because I was hungry or bored or simply wanted to watch my mother at work; her shapely hands were always purposeful, efficient, artful, or ruthless depending on the task. I knew every tool she stocked. In the drawer next to the utensil drawer was where she kept it, beneath a large serving spork and a pie spatula. The Knife. She had other knives on the counter, a typical chef's knife and a filleting knife and some small paring knives she used for fruit, but the Knife had to remain tucked away, I always thought, because it was especially dangerous. It was a stainless-steel carving knife with a cream-colored plastic handle and its own cardboard sheath (illustrated, in fact, with miniature drawings on its use and care). The blade was at least ten inches long and double-edged, honed on one side with a wavy scalloped finish, the other a jagged toothing like a lumberjack's saw. I'm still uncertain what one was supposed to cut with such acute serrations. Cords of gristle? Hides and bone? The first time I saw it, when my father brought it out for our inaugural Thanksgiving celebration in this country, I startled, being afraid both of and for him.

I had furtively handled the Knife before, the blade throwing sunlight about our kitchen, its menacing flash suspending my breath. I'd place it back exactly as it had been, shivering ever so slightly. Now my mind was ratcheting, torquing the screws of a thousand rageful thoughts as I unsheathed it. The Knife was in fact quite cheap, surprisingly bendy and light. I gripped the handle tighter and tighter as I pictured pressing it against Tommy's freckled, stout neck. Would he wail and shake? Or would he beg for mercy, knit his hands together or bow his head? The main question was whether I wanted him to be scarred for life or simply dead. Regardless, he needed to suffer in some profound way. Soon I couldn't sense any distinction between my sweaty palm and the plastic handle. I slashed and stabbed at the air. I could almost taste the dense tang of blood, the evil syrup that was fuel for my fury.

I understood then what I needed to do. Instead of putting it back, I replaced the other implements that had been atop it and shut the drawer. I re-sheathed the Knife and went to the bedroom, where I slid it between workbooks in my schoolbag. I shouldered the bag and stood before the mirror that hung on the back of our door, closing and opening the bag's flap, startled, for a moment, to see what I looked like, this steely, dead-faced boy.

On the next school day, I carried my knife-laden book bag with the expectation that Tommy would accost me on the way there or back. It was a warm day in early May, but I had chosen a long-sleeved shirt to wear, some part of me seeking any measure of protection, and by the time I reached the main schoolyard filled with kids madly shouting and sprinting around before the first bell, I was perspiring so heavily that I had to blink away the sweat from my brow. I was breathing too fast and felt faint, and I realized that I was already spent, that I was beginning to lose my nerve.

I moved to the cooler, shaded corner of the asphalted yard. Unless he was tardy or out sick Tommy should have been there, but I couldn't find his squat form in the mosh. It was then that a boy named Osvaldo approached me. It was his first year at the school, and I knew that he was clever and concerned about his image, but because he wasn't very sporty or charismatic he wasn't yet popular, though he desperately wanted to be. Like me, he was ambitious, but he could get pushy, constantly seeking any opportunity to better his standing. I was our grade's playground monitor for that month, and he'd been lobbying me daily to choose him as one of the two kickball or dodgeball captains. I don't know when or why this clearly flawed mechanism had been instituted by our teachers—perhaps there had been arguments, even physical tussles, over captaincy—but there it was, and Osvaldo, who detected something corruptible in my character, had begun bribing me with candies like sour balls or lollipops. Nothing was stipulated, nothing was promised, and like mobsters we inked the pact with an oblique look, a wrinkle of the nose. Osvaldo's problem was that he couldn't stop nudging, and even after I chose him to be a captain twice in one week, he kept on me, treats in tow, finally offering the newly available Bicentennial commemorative quarters, which I palmed for a few days without making him captain, in order not to attract scrutiny but also, I admit, to remind him who was boss.

“Hey, J.-G., check out these cool new ones I got!” Osvaldo displayed a handful of shiny quarters. I couldn't have cared less. I could only focus on the background behind him, searching for Tommy. It was no longer that I wished to ward Tommy off, to scare or intimidate him. That now seemed an infantile idea. No. He had to be torn open like the odd raccoon or stray cat we sometimes found curbside after a foggy or rainy night, its belly garishly flared. I could almost feel the teeth of the blade tip chucking into the flesh of

Tommy's raised palm, the splintering of the hard point of his shoulder. And I saw it, as before, pressed against his bared pale neck, but this time the knife cut in, if bloodlessly, Tommy's beady eyes disbelieving right up to the moment I held his detached head by the hair, just as the palace executioner had done with John the Baptist's in a movie I'd watched with my parents.

"You can have all of them, O.K.?" Osvaldo said, trying to push the coins into my hand. I didn't want them. I was going to make him a captain at recess anyway, but I didn't say anything and he kind of freaked out and tossed them, the quarters weakly caroming off me and scattering on the asphalt.

"These are yours!" he cried, scrambling to pick them up. "I have some for Joshua."

"Messing?"



From his knees Osvaldo nodded, his face crooked with long suffering. "He knows! He said he'll tell Miss Stavros if I don't keep giving him the same thing." Miss Stavros was our teacher. "So if you don't want them, I'll just give him yours!"

I was livid already and hearing this should have been an accelerant, but just then I noticed Tommy entering the schoolyard. I felt some vast piece of me fall away, like an ice shelf calving. Was it seeing him now as quarry? Was this how a predator self-vanishes? For, as I drifted toward him, numb save my grip on the knife handle inside my bag, I was awed by the momentum, to be so utterly discharged from myself. I felt so pure and free. But who was this with him? There were the grownups beside him, a woman with blond hair thickly flowing down to the narrow waist of her flared bluejeans, a man with long hair, too, but curlier and dark, like his brushy handlebar mustache. Walking a half step to the side of them was a beefy older man in a crisp white short-sleeved dress shirt and slate-colored trousers, a cap tucked under his arm. He opened the metal entrance door for the couple—the woman’s face looked flushed, puffy—and, as he turned, I saw a holstered handgun studding his hip. Tommy kept his head bent low as the man ushered them into the building.

You would have thought that it was a vindicating sight, that I’d be thrilled to witness a cowed Tommy and his parents being escorted into school by a policeman. But for what? The very idea that there might be others—I hadn’t allotted room for anyone but myself to be a victim—somehow made my shame sharper, more caustic, and not because I cared an iota for them. It was that the mantle of my martyrdom had been stripped away, leaving me exposed in a foolish fantasy of revenge. Weapon or not, I was still terrified of Tommy and always would be. My plan was all an act, or more, an enactment of an act that would never be performed. I know. A coward revels in rehearsal. Still, I was shaking, and all I could do was walk away past Osvaldo, heading to the opening in the schoolyard fencing. I was ill and I had to get home. Osvaldo pushed at my back and without turning I batted him away.

“Hey!”

But it was Joshua Messing, standing close enough that I could smell his milk-laced cereal breath. Osvaldo was behind him, if not allied with him, then curious about what might be unfolding.

Joshua poked me in the shoulder. “You think you’re so smart. You think you got it all going, huh?”

Maybe I did think those things, because I needed to, but I didn't believe any of it.

"Well, I'm choosing captains today," he decreed.

I started walking.

"And will until the end of school."

I turned and faced him. "Fuck you, Josh."

"Yeah, FUCK YOU, J.-G.!"

He punched me hard in the chest, knocking me back a step. For a second I couldn't breathe, it was as if my heart stopped, but then a flash of paleness crossed his face. I had already leaped at him, grabbing him by his shirt collar. My head was exploding with the iciest cold. They say I screamed, in Korean and English.

You wanna die? Ju-gu-leh? You wanna die right now?

Apparently, I was wielding the Knife, holding it high. I can feel it still, sometimes.

To this day I've never seen a person so scared.

The Messings, to their credit, ultimately agreed that a social-rehabilitation program was the appropriate path for me. This was after their initial shock and outrage, and demand that I be detained for arraignment and trial and possibly held at a juvenile correctional facility, all of which I was legally subject to, for under the statutes of New York State back then, offenders as young as seven could be tried in the criminal-justice system.

No one could blame them for wanting me locked away. Although Joshua and I had been friends before we grew antagonistic, neither of us had ever visited the other's apartment, so I had never met his parents; they didn't know the first thing about me except that I had threatened to decapitate their only child with a ten-inch carving knife that I'd brought to school in my book bag. Joshua himself was unharmed, at least physically. I was

immediately suspended from school for the rest of the year, and Joshua, I heard later, stayed at home the next school day and returned the following, but then didn't want to go anymore even though he knew I wouldn't be present. I found out from some of the Cove Gardens gang that he didn't come out very often, and if he did would just play a quick game of H-O-R-S-E and maybe get something if the ice-cream truck came by, but at some point would slip away without a word. No one gave him trouble about it, you'd have to be a big jerk to do that, and in truth the rest of the gang was spooked by my actions, too, and likely glad that I was out of circulation. The only one who came to see me was Gregory Fluss, who lived one floor above me, and who was returning a G.I. Joe I'd let him borrow a month before.

"I thought you might want him back now," he said, extending the action figure from where he stood on the far side of our doormat. He was examining me closely, as if checking to see if I was suddenly transformed, had maybe sprouted nubs of horns, or an extra eye. I took the G.I. Joe and thanked him, and Gregory's expression softened, and I told him he should come over later if he wanted, as my parents hadn't yet specifically forbidden that.

"I'm not sure," he said, leaning back a half step. "I have to ask my mom."

We stood idling for a bit. Before he left, he reached into his back pocket and gave me a piece of wrapped bubble gum. The gum, which I put in my mouth right after I closed the door, was misshapen and warm from being in his pocket, but I extracted every last molecule of its sweetness, chewing it long after it had turned hard and flavorless, this lump of useless putty that was more or less how my only society now viewed me.

The big question is why I never told anyone about Tommy Reilly, when doing so would surely have made my life less fraught and complicated in the aftermath. I can still see the reaction of the secretary at the first psychologist's office, the reflexive tightening of her lips when she realized I was *that boy* from J.F.K. Elementary School. At any point I could have spoken up. Yet it seemed right to me not to disclose Tommy's aggressions, even after it became known why he and his parents had been summoned to school that day: apparently he'd threatened two fifth-grade girls on school grounds, not with slingshotted stones or ninja stars but with an actual pellet

gun, an air pistol that he shot into the trees and then aimed at them. Somehow, I was certain that I wouldn't be believed, that I would be seen as simply claiming victimhood to excuse myself.

Was I remorseful? I felt bad for causing everyone such unhappiness, but whether I felt remorse for the act itself was unclear. I didn't feel too sorry, if at all, about Joshua, for in my mind he deserved to have peed his pants just as he did right then in the schoolyard. In fact, I was almost liking him again, renewed by the idea that we were as allied as ever, now that we both knew what it was to fear so purely.

Tommy, it turned out, wasn't wholly at fault, if at all. He was also suspended immediately and processed through a similar series of assessments and evaluations, but we heard soon enough that he was undergoing care for a serious anxiety disorder, which was merely the first indication of what would be diagnosed in his early teen years as full-blown schizophrenia, complete with paranoid thoughts and visions. In this regard we were all fortunate that he didn't follow through with some truly harmful assaults.

Tommy, of course, must have suffered more than anyone. Years later, long after we'd moved away, when Tommy should have been working his first job after college, Paul Dipinto—whom I bumped into at a bar in the East Village—told me that he saw him pacing at a bus stop in White Plains, loudly haranguing no one in particular. Poor kid. But it's like that sometimes for the rest of us, too. Waiting for a ride to where you want to go but never getting on. ♦

This is drawn from "[A Tender Age](#)."

The Critics

- [The American Revolution Wasn't the Main Event](#)
- [The Idea That Reshaped Identity Politics Has a Complicated Backstory](#)
- [Briefly Noted](#)
- [The Artist Who Made America Look Like a Promised Land](#)
- [Harriet Clark's Début Is a New Kind of Coming-of-Age Novel](#)
- ["Schmigadoon!" and "The Lost Boys" Are Killer Revamps](#)
- ["The Devil Wears Prada 2" Gives the Decline of Magazines the Glossy Treatment](#)

A Critic at Large

The American Revolution Wasn't the Main Event

Americans have long imagined that they set off a global age of revolt. Seen within the era's wider wars of empire, the story looks rather different.

By Daniel Immerwahr

May 04, 2026



Historians deal in secular truths. Slavery is an appropriate explanation for the Civil War; God's will is not. Still, some occurrences are so improbable they can make it hard to believe that we're entirely alone, that there are no fates or hobgoblins pulling the strings.

Thomas Jefferson's death is one. That Jefferson, an ailing octogenarian, should die in his bed was unsurprising. That he should die on the same day as his fellow-Founder John Adams was perhaps a tad eerie. But that both should die on the Fourth of July, 1826, the fiftieth anniversary of the Declaration of Independence, which Jefferson had written and Adams had signed? This was coincidence beyond belief.

From his deathbed, Jefferson reflected on the Declaration's meaning. More than announcing a separation, it had repudiated the age-old notion that some people were born with "saddles on their backs" and that others were born with boots and spurs to ride them. The message was meant for the entire world, Jefferson felt. It would extend "to some parts sooner, to others later, but finally to all."

It was a bit grandiose of Jefferson to suppose that a document he'd written in less than three weeks would liberate all of humanity. But Adams, his political rival, seemed to agree. [The post-Declaration era](#) should be called "the Age of Revolutions and Constitutions," Adams proposed. The French Revolution started in the first months of [George Washington's Presidency](#). Then came revolts and revolutions in Ireland, the Swiss cantons, the Rhineland, the Netherlands, the Italian states, and the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth. In the early nineteenth century, more than a dozen colonies in the Americas gained their freedom, including Haiti, Mexico, Brazil, Argentina, Colombia, and Peru. Kings were killed, rights proclaimed, independences declared. "We began the Dance," Adams gleefully insisted.

The American rebels had their own [MAGA hat](#): the soft red liberty cap, based on the headgear of freed Greco-Roman slaves. (It's what the Smurfs wear.) Soon, it was everywhere. French republicans adopted it as their symbol, as did Latin American ones. It appeared on the emblems of France, Bolivia, Argentina, Colombia, El Salvador, Haiti, and Cuba.

America's influence went beyond haberdashery. Several of the world's leading revolutionaries had spent time in the country. The English-born Thomas Paine started his radical career writing ["Common Sense"](#) in Philadelphia before serving as a delegate to France's National Convention. Tadeusz Kościuszko, Henri Christophe, Francisco de Miranda, and the Marquis de Lafayette all fought the British in America before becoming heroes in Poland, Haiti, Venezuela, and France, respectively. Lafayette named his only son Georges Washington.

Americans watched liberty's growth with parental pride. After the French Revolution, many donned tricolor cockades and started addressing one another as "citizen" and "citizeness." After Simón Bolívar led several of Spain's Latin American colonies to independence, U.S. parents christened

sons “Bolivar,” hence the Civil War general Simon Bolivar Buckner. All these overseas uprisings could be seen as part of the “novus ordo seclorum,” the new world order established by the United States and announced on its great seal. (Look under the eye-pyramid on the dollar bill.)

Belief in the American Revolution’s transcendent importance persists. It was “the most significant event in human history since the birth of Christ,” the documentarian Ken Burns has repeatedly proclaimed. Two recent books, however, put that to the test. [“Republic and Empire”](#) (Yale), by Andrew Jackson O’Shaughnessy and the late Trevor Burnard, presents the Revolution from the British vantage. [“Freedom Round the Globe”](#) (Doubleday), by Sarah Pearsall, follows it all over the map—Jamaica, France, India, China. These fascinating, mind-scrambling books show familiar events from unfamiliar perspectives. But, in doing so, they lead you to wonder whether the stories Jefferson and Adams told were true. What if, in the age of revolution, America just didn’t matter that much?

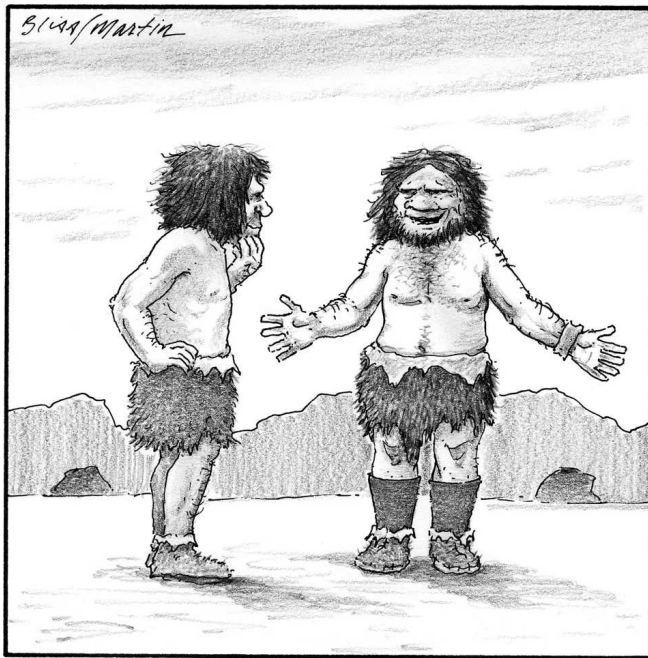
To eighteenth-century Europeans, North America was essentially a wilderness. Although on paper the continent was divided into British, French, Spanish, and Russian territory, this was a preposterous cartographic fiction. In reality, the land was mainly Indigenous. Even populous British colonies like Virginia and Pennsylvania grew blurry on their western frontiers, where indistinct borders were protected by a few lonely forts.

For the British Crown, such frontiers were smudges on the edge of the map. What truly mattered was protecting Britain’s trade with the European continent against French interference. So, when French colonists built forts in the contested borderland of the Ohio Valley, near Pittsburgh, King George III went through the motions of shoing them away. This task was unimportant enough, however, to fall to an American-born major who’d been in uniform less than a year, a twenty-one-year-old named George Washington.

Sending Washington wasn’t exactly sending the big guns. When he ordered the French to leave, they refused. He returned the next year to build a fort. As he prepared to do so, though, the Seneca leader Tanaghrisson approached Washington, warned him that the French were near, and proposed an ambush. Washington went along, and the two managed, with their combined

forces, to capture a French unit. But things spun out of his control when Tanaghrisson drove a hatchet into the French commander's skull and his men began killing the wounded. In another fates-or-hobgoblins moment, a discombobulated Washington had started a war.

A huge one. In the United States, it's known as the French and Indian War, but that was just the American portion of the conflict. The Seven Years' War drew in all the great Western powers. It reached Europe, Africa, and Asia, leading Winston Churchill to call it "the first world war." As in the later World Wars, Britain's side won. Lagos, Le Havre, Quebec, Quiberon Bay —"Our bells are worn threadbare with ringing for victories," Horace Walpole wrote.



George Washington, trudging through a muddy Pennsylvania forest, had inadvertently set cannons roaring from Prague to Manila. This surely confirmed the colonists' sense of their own importance. But it also revealed them to be cogwheels in a vast imperial machinery, one they neither controlled nor comprehended.

In the traditional telling, the Seven Years' War drained British coffers, prompted higher taxes, and placed the grumbling Americans on their path to freedom. That isn't wrong: the first surge of revolt across the colonies, in

response to the Stamp Act of 1765, led rebels from Maryland to Massachusetts to hang Crown officials in effigy. But that standard story rarely mentions the British Caribbean, where the Stamp Act fell hardest. A crowd in St. Kitts pushed the tax collector to the ground and threatened to string him up if he didn't resign. After he fled to nearby Nevis, furious colonists followed him there, burning houses and baying for blood.

If St. Kitts and Nevis seem odd sites for unrest, that's because most narratives of the Revolution present a tightly cropped picture. John Adams is frequently quoted as describing how America's disparate colonies became a nation: "Thirteen Clocks were made to Strike together." In fact, Britain had twenty-six American colonies, and only half of them rose up. The physically largest, Quebec, remained loyal, as did the most lucrative, Jamaica. And East and West Florida, though they would be absorbed later, didn't join the rebellion, either.

The rebels were fully aware of these other colonies and sought to include them. The Continental Congress distributed a letter in French imploring Canadians to rise up "in the defence of our common liberty." (It was signed "Jean Hancock," le "Président du Congrès.") The Articles of Confederation made provisions for other colonies to join. In his draft of the Articles, Benjamin Franklin listed the colonies he had in mind: Britain's Caribbean and Canadian holdings, Bermuda, the Floridas, and Ireland. In 1778, U.S. diplomats signed a treaty with the Lenapes (also known as the Delawares) that, had Congress approved, would have made the Lenape Nation a U.S. state.

The Founders portrayed themselves as reluctant revolutionaries, patriots who had endured such "a long train of abuses and usurpations" (as Jefferson's Declaration put it) that they were forced by their principles to seek freedom. But, in a wide-frame shot with Britain's whole empire in view, it's hard to see them as especially aggrieved or especially liberty-loving.

Their burdens, at least, were light. The well-fed colonists avoided the famines that recurred in Ireland and British India. (Pearsall describes one in Bengal that killed at least a million people and possibly far more.) Indeed, American settlers enjoyed incomes "equal, or slightly superior, to those in

England,” Burnard and O’Shaughnessy write, adding that, even at the same level, American incomes “bought a great deal more” than English ones did. The historian Robin L. Einhorn has observed that American colonial taxes were lighter, more progressive, and less aggressively collected than levies in Europe.

Perhaps the thirteen colonies were uniquely allergic to tyranny? This would have come as news to the Highland Scots who invaded England in 1745 or the Irish Whiteboys who terrorized landlords and tax collectors a few decades later. The seventeen-sixties, in particular, were a time of empire-wide defiance. That was when the enslaved population of Jamaica staged a vast uprising, a Native confederacy fought the British from Virginia to present-day Michigan, and the Sultan of Mysore, Hyder Ali, launched the first of four wars against Britain’s East India Company. Next to these, American protests of the Stamp Act looked almost sweet. “There is not a single native of our country,” Ben Franklin could claim in 1768, “who is not firmly attached to his King by principle and by affection.”

Neither Burnard and O’Shaughnessy nor Pearsall attempts a grand explanation of why thirteen American colonies ultimately sought independence while thirteen others didn’t. In the Caribbean, slavery was an obvious factor, Burnard and O’Shaughnessy note. Because sugar plantations were so large and enslaved populations were so preponderant, whites feared that any tumult would end with their heads on pikes. They wanted more British soldiers around, not fewer.

Nationalist rebellion was likelier in Canada. Indeed, the first colonists to attack a statue of George III were in Montreal; they blackened the King’s face and garlanded him with a rosary made from potatoes. (They later beheaded him.) The Catholic-Protestant divide impeded North American solidarity. Still, Pearsall argues, had the U.S. invasion of Canada in 1775-76 gone better—more heartening victories, fewer supplies confiscated from the locals—Canadians might well have joined the cause.

It’s not always the most downtrodden who rise up. In a global context, the Founders appear not as the wretched of the earth but as the fortunate sons of Britain who, at a certain point, found it more advantageous to become sons of liberty.

In 1773, Bostonians disguised as Mohawks hurled hundreds of chests of British tea into the ocean. Though the [Boston Tea Party](#) is commonly assumed to have been about taxes, the tea in question had had its taxes *reduced* to help the East India Company. The colonists' concern was that cheap Company tea would undercut smugglers and local venders—they were like cabdrivers protesting Uber. John Dickinson, one of the wealthiest colonists, warned that the vile East India Company, having devastated India, would start in on America. “We are not Sea Poys, nor Marattas, but *British Subjects*, who are born to Liberty,” he protested. Tea Partiers dressed like the Indians of one continent to show that they would not be treated like the Indians of another.

For a war of independence, it is bizarre how many foreigners featured in the American Revolution. The greatest American hero after Washington was the [Marquis de Lafayette](#), who arrived, in 1777, barely speaking English. Washington and Lafayette's war-ending triumph over Lord Cornwallis at Yorktown, in 1781, owed much to Comte de Rochambeau's French soldiers and Comte de Grasse's French ships. About a quarter of the British Army troops, meanwhile, were actually German—the hated Hessians.

There's a reason for this. Once the colonists showed they could win battles, Britain's many enemies piled on. The result was “a Russian doll of a war, with conflicts nested in other ones, far beyond the thirteen colonies,” Pearsall writes. There is no one name for the connected conflicts, which include the Anglo-French War of 1778-83, the Anglo-Spanish War of 1779-83, the Fourth Anglo-Dutch War, and the Second Mysore War. Pearsall suggests “the Nine Years' War.”

How central were the thirteen colonies here? Burnard and O'Shaughnessy point out that, whereas Britain regularly sent nobles to govern the Caribbean colonies—and dukes and earls to Ireland—the men appointed to administer the thirteen colonies more often lacked titles and were paid less. The Massachusetts governor during the Boston Tea Party, Thomas Hutchinson, was a local merchant.

Hence the Hessians. George III made do with mercenaries from German lands because he needed British troops to protect a place that mattered more: Ireland.

Even within the Americas, the thirteen colonies weren't top priority. In 1778, the British commander Henry Clinton was ordered to abandon his occupation of Philadelphia, the largest city there, and send the troops instead to St. Lucia (five thousand men), St. Augustine (three thousand), and Canada (two thousand). The Cabinet discussed—and George III supported—withdrawing from the coastal colonies entirely in favor of the Caribbean. Britain didn't withdraw, but its Royal Navy gradually redistributed its ships. Forty-one per cent of the fleet was at the North American mainland in the summer of 1778, thirteen per cent in the summer of 1780, and eleven per cent in the summer of 1781.

Lord Cornwallis encountered these imperial priorities in 1778, when he was briefly ordered to leave America along with four thousand troops during a panic that the French might invade Jamaica. He ran fully aground on the same priorities in 1781, when rebel forces surrounded him at Yorktown. Cornwallis needed reinforcements, and one reason too few came was that Britain had sent ships to the Indian Ocean, where it was fighting the Sultan of Mysore, Hyder Ali. The battles in southern India “were on a scale that far surpassed those of America,” Burnard and O'Shaughnessy write, and they burned through British resources. Pearsall deems Hyder Ali the unsung hero of Yorktown.

Cornwallis laid down his arms in October, 1781. Yet a puzzle for schoolchildren is: If the war basically finished with Yorktown in 1781, why wasn't the peace treaty ratified until 1784? In fact, only the American fighting had ended. Major engagements lay ahead: Britain's triumphant defense of Jamaica against France in the Battle of the Saintes, in 1782; the exhaustion of the Franco-Spanish siege of Gibraltar, in 1783. Combat in southern India raged until 1784.

The global war concluded inconclusively, with territory changing hands in many directions. Yet this didn't leave the warring empires on equal footing. France ended basically insolvent, and the financial strain brought down its monarchy. The ensuing turmoil upended Spain, which lost most of its empire. All this may explain why the war doesn't linger in British memory as a painful loss. Taking a broad view, it's possible to argue that Britain *won* the American Revolutionary War.

Certainly, Britain “flourished as never before,” Burnard and O’Shaughnessy write. It kept its monarchy and its valuable Caribbean territories. (Even today, Jamaica’s head of state is officially King Charles III.) Although Britain lost the thirteen colonies’ allegiance, it retained their trade. In 1820, the politician Henry Clay deemed the United States to be “sort of independent colonies” of England, “politically free, commercially slaves.”

Beyond America, Britain grew explosively. Cornwallis, known in the U.S. as the poor sap who lost the war, is remembered differently in the U.K. After Yorktown, he became the governor-general of British India. Using hundreds of elephants to haul artillery, Cornwallis invaded Mysore and carved up the sultanate. He was, according to the British foreign-affairs adviser John Bew, “among the most effective of all British empire builders.”

The American colonists didn’t overthrow the British monarchy; they escaped from it. Nonetheless, they might have brought other kings down. This, at least, is what they believed: that their ideas ignited revolutions.

But that’s not how it looks from the outside. “The sad truth of the matter,” the German theorist Hannah Arendt wrote, is that France’s revolution “made world history” whereas America’s was “of little more than local importance.” Two classic transnational histories by British authors, Eric Hobsbawm’s “The Age of Revolution, 1789-1848” (1962) and C. A. Bayly’s “The Birth of the Modern World, 1780-1914” (2003) conspicuously start with the seventeen-eighties, the decade *after* the American Revolution began.

Bayly, unimpressed by the thirteen colonies’ influence, argued that the main engine of political modernity wasn’t a revolution in ideas but one in arms. By the eighteenth century, developments in military technology and state organization had made wars punishingly expensive. That’s why Britain, after the Seven Years’ War, needed to hike taxes, setting off the American Revolution. And it’s why France, after the American Revolutionary War, had to do the same, which led to the calling of the Estates General, the revolt of the Third Estate, and the monarchy’s fall.

The American Revolution helped cause the French one in this strictly fiscal sense. Ideologically, though, the connection was murkier. French

revolutionaries sought to remake their society, executing tens of thousands of those who stood in their way. Even Thomas Paine, the Revolution's best-known foreign champion, was imprisoned as a counter-revolutionary in 1793. If not for a stroke of luck to do with markings on cell doors, he, too, would probably have been killed.

France's revolution set off a slave uprising in its colony of Saint-Domingue. The French National Convention accepted this and abolished slavery throughout the empire. When Napoleon later sought to reestablish it, Saint-Domingue's leaders declared independence from France, forming the Black republic of Haiti, in 1804. They initially modelled their declaration on Jefferson's but scrapped it. "To write this Act," the declaration's author explained, "we need the skin of a white man for parchment, his skull for an inkwell, his blood for ink, and a bayonet for a pen!"



All this puts America in clarifying perspective. It's telling that several key words of late-eighteenth-century political confrontation—democrat, aristocrat, and revolutionary (as a noun)—were unknown in the American Revolution. Had that even *been* a revolution? Black and Native Americans, the most clear-cut victims of tyranny, fought largely against the secessionists. This is understandable; independence placed power in the hands of America's local élite, many of whose members held slaves (as eight

of the first ten U.S. Presidents did). “I would have never drawn my sword in the cause of America, if I could have conceived that thereby I was founding a land of slavery,” Lafayette said. It’s hard to imagine the Founders surviving long in France or Haiti.

Although U.S. leaders initially cheered foreign uprisings, their enthusiasm curdled into disenchantment and disavowal. It didn’t take long for George Washington and his followers to recoil from French radicalism. The difference between the American and French revolutions, John Adams huffed, is “the difference between *right* and *wrong*.” When Francophiles aligned with Jefferson wore tricolor cockades, Washington’s men responded with sombre black ones. Division over the French Revolution became a major cause of America’s first partisan split: Democratic-Republicans were for it, Federalists against.

Yet it was the Federalists who held power in the late eighteenth century. So, when republican France went to war with its monarchical neighbors, President Washington declared neutrality. Although his famous farewell address is commonly read as a statement of general political principles—a criticism of entangling alliances—Washington’s warning that “passionate attachment” to a “favourite nation” would lead “deluded citizens” to betray their country wasn’t hard to decode. Under President John Adams, the Federalists sought to eradicate French ideological influence by raising the bar to citizenship, lowering the bar to deportation, and criminalizing malicious criticism of the federal government.

Thomas Paine, released from prison and woven back into French society, wrote a long, furious letter to George Washington. The question, Paine asked, was “whether you are an apostate or an impostor; whether you have abandoned good principles, or whether you ever had any?” His searing indictment was half the length of “Common Sense.”

U.S. hostilities with France peaked with the Quasi-War, a set of naval skirmishes between 1798 and 1800. Congress raised an army to defend the homeland, and President Adams appointed Washington to lead it. Although an invasion was unlikely, an aged Washington threw himself into preventing the French Revolution from reaching American shores.

By then, even the Democratic-Republicans had soured on France. In 1797, Jefferson proposed a “divorce” from it. Meanwhile, he regarded Saint-Domingue’s uprising with unconcealed terror. “The revolutionary storm now sweeping the globe” would soon strike the United States, he warned. “The day which begins our combustion must be near at hand.”

At the end of Jefferson’s and Adams’s lives, their Hispanophone counterpart Simón Bolívar invited the United States to a conference of American nations in Panama. Here was a more congenial setting for contemplating liberty than Paris or Port-au-Prince. The Latin American independence wars had been mostly élite-led affairs. Necks were safe in Panama.

Still, coöperating with foreigners gave pause. Latin America’s revolutions, however moderate, had nonetheless involved ending slavery. Bolívar, indeed, had taken aid from Haiti. Latin Americans seemed looser about race, too. Mexico’s second President, Vicente Guerrero, not only abolished slavery but appeared to have had African ancestry himself—some called him El Negro.

These were sticking points, my academic colleague Caitlin Fitz argues in “Our Sister Republics” (2016). When President John Quincy Adams accepted Bolívar’s invitation, his opponents pounced. Could U.S. delegates really be expected, the Virginia senator John Randolph asked, to sit “beside the native African, their American descendants, the mixed breeds, the Indians, and the half breeds”? The notion that “all men are born free and equal,” Randolph said, must be rejected “for the best of reasons, because it is not true.”

Panama became a powerful wedge issue. Attacking Bolívar’s proposal was the “first-ever collective bid for power” from the coalition that would become the Democratic Party, Fitz explains. To its members, Latin America’s leaders weren’t revolutionary peers but swarthy radicals. In two decades, the United States would, under a Democratic President, attack Mexico and seize more than a third of its territory.

In the eighteen-fifties, with the Democrats again holding the White House, Congress sought to adorn the U.S. Capitol dome with a statue. The sculptor, Thomas Crawford, was based in Rome and proposed a woman wearing a

liberty cap. But Jefferson Davis, as Secretary of War, objected. The United States stood for birthright liberty, he maintained, not “the liberty of a freed slave.” Crawford replaced the liberty cap with a military helmet topped by a menacing eagle, which is how it appears today.

By the time Jefferson Davis was cancelling the liberty cap, it was hard to see the United States as leading the charge for freedom. Its kingless government, once a badge of distinction, had become normal in the mid-nineteenth-century Americas. Now the U.S. stood out for different reasons. Its refusal to abolish slavery placed it in a small club of holdouts, with Cuba and Brazil. And its violent expansionism—invading its southern neighbor, dislodging Native nations—made it a rising empire among republics.

Toward the end of his life, Jefferson wrote to Adams that “the flames kindled on the 4th of July 1776” had “spread over too much of the globe to be extinguished.” This is a familiar vision: the United States illuminating the world. Burnard and O’Shaughnessy’s and Pearsall’s books reverse the beam, showing the Revolution from without. It looks different in that light: less transcendent, more scuffed by historical forces.

Maybe that’s all right. Since 1776, Americans have been insisting that they were the protagonists of global history. After the Second World War, they did indeed catapult into a position of supremacy. This was another fates-or-hobgoblins turn of events, but many Americans took that profound luck as their rightful due. That historical egotism fuelled their headiest ambitions. Was this healthy? Jefferson’s vision of American flames igniting the planet lands differently now. One could be forgiven, these days, for wishing that the United States were a little less central in world affairs. That its inhabitants were one people among many, just like everyone else. ♦

Books

The Idea That Reshaped Identity Politics Has a Complicated Backstory

Kimberlé Crenshaw gave us the terms “intersectionality” and “critical race theory.” Her new memoir shows that she isn’t done fighting over what they mean.

By Kelefa Sanneh

May 04, 2026



In 1969, a British magazine called *Nova* published an interview with John Lennon and Yoko Ono. It was around the time the Beatles broke up, and also around the time Lennon and Ono got married, and the two seemed to delight in each other’s company and ideas. At one point, Lennon was musing about his belief in reincarnation, and enumerating some of his past lives and identities, when Ono made a blunt analogy. “Woman is the nigger of the world,” she said. The interviewer, Irma Kurtz, wasn’t impressed. “I had to wonder where that sweeping statement placed Negro women,” she wrote. But Ono’s phrase resonated: the magazine put it on the cover, and it eventually became the title of a would-be feminist anthem written by the

couple and sung by Lennon. The song stalled at No. 57 on the pop chart, partly because radio stations refused to play it, but the incendiary formulation was hard to forget—especially as, in the decades that followed, the taboo against non-Black people using the N-word grew markedly stronger.

An unexpected new burst of infamy arrived in 2011, when the motto appeared at SlutWalk NYC, a feminist protest, on a sign held by a protester—a white woman, as far as anyone could tell. The march organizers apologized, calling the sign “racist,” and a writer named Flavia Dzodan responded with an essay that spawned a resonant phrase of its own: “My Feminism Will Be Intersectional or It Will Be Bullshit.” (Dzodan later wrote about her dismay at seeing the phrase emblazoned on T-shirts and coffee mugs, all of them unlicensed.) Like the old, unsayable phrase, the new one made a claim about the complicated relationship between race and sex. An “intersectional” feminist movement was one that didn’t merely see similarities between racial and sexual subordination but acknowledged the ways they overlapped—[especially for Black women](#), who experienced both at once.

By 2011, “intersectionality” had nearly completed its journey from intellectual obscurity to cultural ubiquity. In an era of social-media politics, with everyone talking to (or shouting at) everyone else, arguments and identities tended to stack atop one another, and so “intersectionality” made intuitive sense: it explained why movements needed to be accountable to multiple constituencies at once. In conversations among progressives, the word often functioned as a way to commend the work of Black women. One story on National Public Radio praised the playwright Lorraine Hansberry for being “intersectional before it became a thing”; another observed that Beyoncé was working to “nudge her listeners toward the concept of intersectional feminism.”

Unlike many intellectual concepts, this one has a clear origin story: “intersectionality” was born in 1989, in a [law-review article](#) titled “Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex: A Black Feminist Critique of Antidiscrimination Doctrine, Feminist Theory and Antiracist Politics.” The author, a professor named Kimberlé Williams Crenshaw, proved to have a knack not just for provocative legal essays but for coinages,

too. Around the same time, she popularized another term that would reach the mainstream—“critical race theory,” a name for a branch of legal scholarship that eventually became a catchall for left-leaning ideas about racism. During a 2020 campaign rally, Donald Trump promised to ban C.R.T. training in the federal government, calling it a “hateful Marxist doctrine,” and in the years that followed [C.R.T. became central to a debate](#) over how—or whether—schools should teach students about race.

Plenty of scholars and journalists have written histories of these contentious terms, “intersectionality” and “critical race theory.” Now Crenshaw has written something different: a history of herself. In [“Backtalker: A Memoir”](#) (Simon & Schuster), she frames her life and her remarkably influential career as one long fight against various forms of exclusion and unfairness. Like many radical thinkers, she seems to harbor a certain ambivalence about radicalism itself. She tends to present her ideas as sensible and traditional—the reasonable conclusions of a clear-eyed intellectual who simply refused to shut up about what she witnessed and experienced. At times, she seems genuinely puzzled by the controversy her ideas have aroused, among both potential allies and dedicated opponents. Near the end of the book, she writes about what it was like to hear her coinages taken up by people who had doubtless never opened a law journal. “Fox TV jumped on the bandwagon, amplifying efforts by a few dedicated extremists to attack critical race theory as ‘divisive,’ ‘dangerous,’ and ‘un-American,’ ” she writes, and though it’s clear that the people on television didn’t consider these descriptions to be compliments, Crenshaw might have taken them as such. Neither of the movements she named was designed for mainstream acceptance. [C.R.T. was born as an insurgent project](#), and intersectionality was once a critique of the civil-rights movement. What are they now?

On a quiet street on the north side of Canton, Ohio, there is a sign marking Kimberle Gardens, a small public-housing complex. It was named for Kimberlé Crenshaw by her father, Walter, Jr., who worked for the city’s public-housing authority. Crenshaw’s mother, Marian, was a teacher, and when she was pregnant she agreed to let Crenshaw’s big brother, Mantel, name his baby sister. He chose “Kim,” for his favorite actress, Kim Novak, and the family transformed “Kim” into “Kimberlé,” a name that few would guess had any connection to a blond movie star. Walter was an accomplished singer and Marian played the piano, but Crenshaw evidently did not inherit a

talent for music. Her mother offered her a consolation that proved accurate: “Don’t worry baby, you can talk!” Crenshaw delivered her first speech at the age of eight, in church, in 1968: Martin Luther King, Jr., had just been assassinated, and the pastor asked for comment. “Before I thought better of it, I was on my feet,” she writes, and she remembers “exhorting everyone not to let Dr. King’s death be the end of our freedom struggle.” At least in retrospect, Crenshaw’s childhood unspools like an extended freedom struggle. When she was six, she writes, a white teacher stubbornly declined to cast her in the role of princess in a classroom game, so her parents had the teacher come to the house to make amends. (It was, she writes, a “profound recognition,” and a way of counteracting the “thoughtless devaluation faced by little Black girls.”) In seventh grade, a racist classmate tormented her, enabled by the careful neutrality of many so-called friends, whom she likens to Swiss bankers hoarding Nazi gold. As an adolescent, Crenshaw clashed with her aunt’s new husband and, she says, found herself on the receiving end of a “rage-filled verbal assault,” while her aunt declined to intervene. (“This was male supremacy at work,” she writes.) And, after some unhappy years at an almost all-white Christian school, she transferred to a more diverse public school, writing, “I went running from that dreadful place like Harriet Tubman.”

Not all of Crenshaw’s struggles held obvious political lessons. Her father died young, when she was ten—and so, shockingly, did her brother, who was shot to death at Wilberforce, the historically Black college he attended, during a student brawl. Crenshaw went to Cornell, where her life was almost derailed, even ended, by an ex-boyfriend she describes as obsessive and abusive. Inspired by her father, who had been studying for a law degree when he died, she made her way to Harvard Law School, where she fell in with a politically engaged group of students who were pushing the school to hire more Black professors and to offer a course specifically about race and the law. (They also agitated, unsuccessfully, for what was known as a “no-hassle pass,” which would have given students the right not to be catechized by professors.) Their activism was a tribute to [Derrick Bell](#), an influential legal theorist who had become Harvard’s first tenured Black law professor, in 1982, and had recently left, precisely because he felt the administration was moving too slowly in diversifying the senior faculty. (In 1998, Lani Guinier became the first Black woman to receive tenure at Harvard Law.) In Crenshaw’s view, the school offered courses full of “cold artifacts” rather

than warm-blooded evocations of the Black people and neighborhoods she wanted to help. In some ways, her life at Harvard was the logical continuation of her life in Ohio, and of her precocious determination to find a way to continue the struggles of Martin Luther King, Jr.

The difference, though, was that she arrived at Harvard just as a group of legal theorists was pushing back against the assumption—held by civil-rights leaders and other activists—that a focus on rights and integration was the best way to help people in disempowered communities. This movement, known as [critical legal studies](#), was associated with the political left, and its exponents, known as crits, loved to disparage liberal theorists’ devotion to the Constitution as naïve and counterproductive. In 1984, a prominent crit named Mark Tushnet published [“An Essay on Rights,”](#) in which he argued that the First Amendment had become “the primary guarantor of the privileged,” because it frustrated “progressive legislative efforts” by protecting the political and commercial “speech” of the rich and powerful. “Things are on the whole terrible,” Tushnet wrote, and he suggested that people who wanted change might do better to scrap quaint ideas about “rights,” rather than cling to them.

It was in this context that C.R.T. emerged, led by a cohort of mostly nonwhite scholars who shared the crits’ skepticism about the American legal system but wanted to outflank them—seizing the term “critical” for themselves—by insisting on the practical importance of civil rights for those who had historically been consigned to rightlessness. One of those scholars was Bell, the professor whose departure the students were lamenting. In 1976, Bell had published “Serving Two Masters,” a sharp and unsentimental essay about the legal strategy of school desegregation. Bell argued that, in pushing for desegregation, groups like the N.A.A.C.P. had their own agendas, which didn’t always align with those of Black parents who cared most about securing a good education for their children. Often, Bell wrote, desegregation turned out not to be the fastest or surest method to improve these children’s school experience. A movement less concerned with rights, and more attentive to the wants and needs of Black parents, might have chosen different strategies—and, in some cases, might not have opposed all-Black schools. In 1986, Crenshaw was hired as a professor at the U.C.L.A. School of Law, and two years later she published her first major essay, [“Race, Reform, and Retrenchment,”](#) in which she argued against both the

old liberalism of the civil-rights movement and the more recent heresies of C.L.S. thinkers like Tushnet. She suggested that the civil-rights movement was a victim of its own success: by successfully agitating to outlaw segregation, the movement had the “deleterious effect” of making it seem as though America had achieved racial equality, which weakened the political case for further change. Still, she insisted on the ways in which the idea of gaining rights had been “a radical and liberating activity for Blacks,” and she ended not with a call for revolution but with a rather mild demand for a program “that focuses on the needs of the African-American community.”

Crenshaw was one of the organizers of a 1989 conference of like-minded legal scholars, billed as New Developments in Critical Race Theory, though the “new” was redundant, since the term itself was new. The movement that emerged had little in the way of dogma, beyond a belief that racism was central to American law, rather than a perversion of it, and that scholars had a responsibility to take race seriously. In their writing, “color-blind” became an insult, a way to disparage old-fashioned thinkers who imagined that racism could be fought by acting as if race didn’t exist. During his battle with Harvard Law, Bell insisted that race itself could be an academic credential, as when students demanded “a teacher whose credentials include experiences in and with American racism similar to those the students have already suffered”—in other words, a Black professor. Mari Matsuda, another C.R.T. scholar, expanded this idea into a broad principle, arguing that “those who have experienced discrimination speak with a special voice to which we should listen.” This sounded like not merely a demand for inclusion but a demand for deference, with each speaker’s identity determining whether her voice was “special.”

In 1993, Crenshaw and Matsuda were part of a group of C.R.T. scholars who published [“Words That Wound,”](#) a collection of essays on free speech. The introductory essay, attributed to all of them, decried “first amendment fundamentalists” and argued that “‘freedom’ does not implicate a right to degrade and humiliate another human being.” But Crenshaw’s own essay, on the hip-hop group 2 Live Crew, stopped short of calling for censorship. The group’s 1989 album, “As Nasty as They Wanna Be,” had been ruled obscene by a judge, and three members had been arrested for performing tracks from it at a night club in Hollywood, Florida. (They were later acquitted.) Crenshaw arrived at a split decision, calling the album “misogynist” and

criticizing its “frightening explosion of violent imagery directed to women like me,” while also arguing that the prosecution had been unfair, and quite possibly racist, given that similarly offensive white performers, such as the comedian Andrew Dice Clay, had not been targeted. Compared with her C.R.T. allies, Crenshaw could sound like a liberal—which is to say, a moderate.

In retrospect, C.R.T. looks less like a coherent ideology and more like a tendency, and one that may wax and wane with changing ideas about political power in America. The language of civil rights will always be most appealing to political minorities in search of procedural arguments to temper or frustrate the will of the majority. In times and places where sympathy for Black Americans runs high, there will often be a temptation to move beyond demands for formal equality and press instead for more targeted forms of redress. Possibly this was the case at elite law schools in the nineteen-nineties, where even the most obdurate deans could not afford to ignore their militant students indefinitely. And possibly it was the case again, two decades later, during the Obama years, when C.R.T. enjoyed a resurgence, as many left-leaning institutions were transformed by the demand to be more proactive in fighting racism and supporting Black employees. [The mood is different now](#), especially in the aftermath of the Supreme Court’s ruling, in 2023, that many [race-conscious college-admissions programs](#) were unconstitutional. If America is truly as racist as the C.R.T. pioneers claimed, ambitious moments of reform will prove illusory and will give way to periods—like this one, perhaps—when advocates, in a more defensive frame of mind, are less eager to disparage the benefits of mere “formal equality,” and when even a race theorist as critical as Crenshaw may find herself extolling, as she does in the introduction to her memoir, “the promise of America.”

In Crenshaw’s book, C.R.T. comes across as a group project, while intersectionality is more of a personal quest. She has been thinking about the relationship between race and class ever since she was a girl, but she writes that she found new inspiration soon after arriving at Harvard, when she and a companion visited a friend who was the first Black member of the Fly Club, a venerable campus fraternity. She worried that they might be turned away from the club on account of race, but they were invited in, with a caveat: she had to use the back door, not because she was Black but because

she was a woman. That, apparently, was a club rule. A moment earlier, she and her companion, a Black man, had braced to contend with a race-based insult together; now she was left to contend with a sex-based insult alone. “The Fly Club episode has become my lodestar,” she writes—even though, technically speaking, it was *not* an instance of intersectional oppression. (As she tells the story, it involves no racial discrimination.)

The idea of intersectionality is deceptively and seductively simple—too simple, doubters sometimes think, to require an academic theory. Yet the legal arguments around it are fairly subtle. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 barred discrimination on the basis of sex, as well as race, though, as a historical matter, it’s not quite clear why. (Senator Howard W. Smith, a Democrat from Virginia, added sex to the bill’s list of protected characteristics; he was known to be both skeptical of civil rights and supportive of women’s rights, so people aren’t sure whether he was hoping to sabotage the bill or to improve it.) Emma DeGraffenreid, a Black woman who had worked at a General Motors plant in St. Louis, might have seemed doubly protected by the Civil Rights Act. After she was laid off, in 1974, she became the lead plaintiff in a suit against G.M., arguing that her firing was unjust. Seniority rules, negotiated with the union, obliged the company to lay off workers in reverse chronological order, beginning with the most recent hires; DeGraffenreid argued that she would not have been laid off if she had been hired earlier, and that she would have been hired earlier if she were not Black and female. A district court was open to her claim of race discrimination, skeptical of her claim of sex discrimination, and hostile to the idea of fusing the two. The judge wrote that the Civil Rights Act did not entitle a plaintiff to join the two categories into “a new special sub-category, namely, a combination of racial and sex-based discrimination.”

Crenshaw used DeGraffenreid as one of the case studies in “Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex,” the essay in which she coined the term “intersectionality.” Elsewhere in the paper, she considered a different case, in which a Black woman plaintiff was not allowed to stand for similarly situated white women in a class-action suit because a judge ruled that she had failed to show how white women faced discrimination. In each case, Crenshaw argued, a Black woman was facing additional discrimination because of her particular bundle of identities. The fine points of class-action law were, of course, less influential than Crenshaw’s

insistence on paying close attention to the way Black women were treated by the courts, and the essay's most memorable lines were broader categorical claims. "Not only are women of color in fact overlooked, but their exclusion is reinforced when white women speak for and as women," she wrote. Near the end, she concluded that anyone wishing to fight racism or sexism should begin by "addressing the needs and problems of those who are most disadvantaged."

A few years later, Crenshaw published ["Mapping the Margins,"](#) which explored how these overlapping identities affected women contending with violence. The essay appeared in the *Stanford Law Review*, but these were not purely legal arguments: Crenshaw wrote about how non-English-speaking women struggled to navigate domestic-violence shelters in Los Angeles, and about how some Black leaders voiced support for Mike Tyson during his prosecution, in Indianapolis, for the rape of Desiree Washington, an eighteen-year-old Black woman. (He was convicted and served three years in prison.)

In all these instances, Crenshaw seemed to be taking her own advice and paying heed to the perspectives of the "most disadvantaged." But, as the intersecting identities become more complicated, "most" can be hard to define. In many American contexts, women who don't speak English face extra hurdles, but it doesn't necessarily follow that they are generally the "most disadvantaged" women. And, in the [case of Tyson](#), it's not clear that Black women and Black men actually disagreed about the verdict; in a local poll conducted by the Indianapolis *Star*, in 1993, sixty-six per cent of Black men "questioned the fairness" of his conviction for rape, but so did sixty-eight per cent of Black women. These views might well be wrong, of course, but Crenshaw's intersectional approach doesn't explain when outsiders ought to defer to the judgments of Black women and when they ought not to.

As Crenshaw's reputation grew, she became a public intellectual, less focussed on the intricacies of anti-discrimination law and more focussed on the news. During the confirmation hearing for [Justice Clarence Thomas](#), she travelled to Washington to support Anita Hill, the law professor who accused Thomas of sexual harassment, and she was disappointed by the fact that many Black people still seemed to support Thomas. (In one darkly comic moment, she spotted a group of Black protesters outside the Capitol,

and thought she had found some allies—until she heard the leader praying, “Lord, we beseech you to protect him, to render this Jezebel powerless against him.”) Crenshaw’s feelings about the trial of O. J. Simpson were mixed, because she felt that America was mourning his alleged victim, his ex-wife Nicole Brown Simpson, in a way it might not have mourned a Black woman. She is uncharacteristically circumspect about Simpson’s acquittal. “To this day,” she writes, “the Simpson case stands in our cultural memory as an outrageous illustration of Black jury nullification rather than the everyday ways in which women are snuffed out.” This is a curious conclusion, not least because Simpson almost certainly murdered *two* people, his ex-wife and her boyfriend, Ronald Goldman.

Does it matter? Women are, of course, snuffed out far too often, and sometimes in ways that underscore their particular vulnerabilities—but the homicide victimization rate is much higher for men. As any good intersectionalist would tell you, both race and sex matter a lot: Black women are nearly twice as likely as white men to be the victims of homicide, but Black men are nearly *six* times as likely as Black women to be victims. Grim statistics like these inspired President Obama, in 2014, to create My Brother’s Keeper, a government-led initiative aimed at improving the lives and prospects of young men of color. With its clear focus on race and sex, it was a distinctly intersectional initiative, but Crenshaw emerged as one of its most persistent critics, chastising the program, both publicly and privately, for ignoring Black girls and women. (During one contentious White House meeting, Crenshaw recalls, Valerie Jarrett, a senior adviser to Obama, told her that she did not understand intersectionality.) Reasonable people can disagree about which metrics matter most, but by many measures Black men in America do seem to face particular challenges: a [2019 study](#) by the economist Raj Chetty found a huge income gap between Black and white men who had grown up in households with similar incomes, but none between Black and white women.

In Crenshaw’s original formulation of intersectionality, she took it for granted that the burden of being a Black woman in America was necessarily “greater than the sum of racism and sexism,” but human identities interact in complicated and sometimes unpredictable ways. This becomes even more apparent if we expand our idea of intersectionality, as Crenshaw once recommended, to encompass “class, sexual orientation, age, and color,”

among other characteristics. (Crenshaw notes in passing that she has widened her focus to include not only Black girls but “gender-expansive youth,” too.) Intersectionality is, by design, a divisive creed, and, once we start dividing, there is no telling where we will stop.

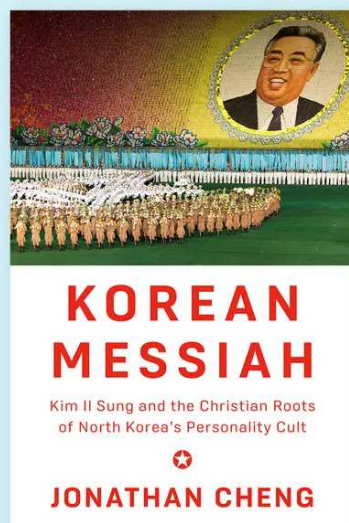
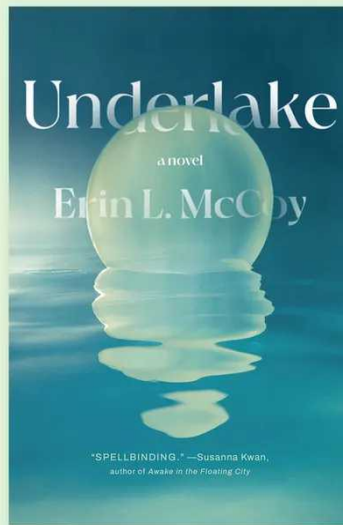
Usually, the task of forming a political coalition, or of redressing an injustice, requires that we ignore most of what makes us different—we must pretend, in other words, that an identity like “Black” is more coherent, and more stable, than it really is, and that someone else can be enough like you to speak meaningfully on your behalf. During the long aftermath of the civil-rights movement, many authors and advocates imagined that King’s struggle could be continued by expanding its reach. Critical race theorists helped popularize the phrase “people of color,” to suggest a grand coalition of all the world’s nonwhite people. At the same time, latter-day intersectionalists have been working to complicate our simple identity categories further still, until the resulting map of human difference becomes so fine-grained that it can be hard to say who, exactly, is allowed to speak for whom. Especially among activists and academics, this explosion of identities has muddled Crenshaw’s neat system of greater and lesser disadvantage. What it hasn’t done is erase the gap between Black America and the rest of the country, or our hunger for theories that promise to help close it. ♦

Books

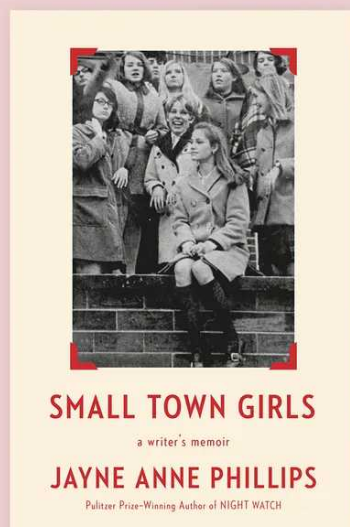
Briefly Noted

“Korean Messiah,” “Small Town Girls,” “Underlake,” and “August, September, October.”

May 04, 2026



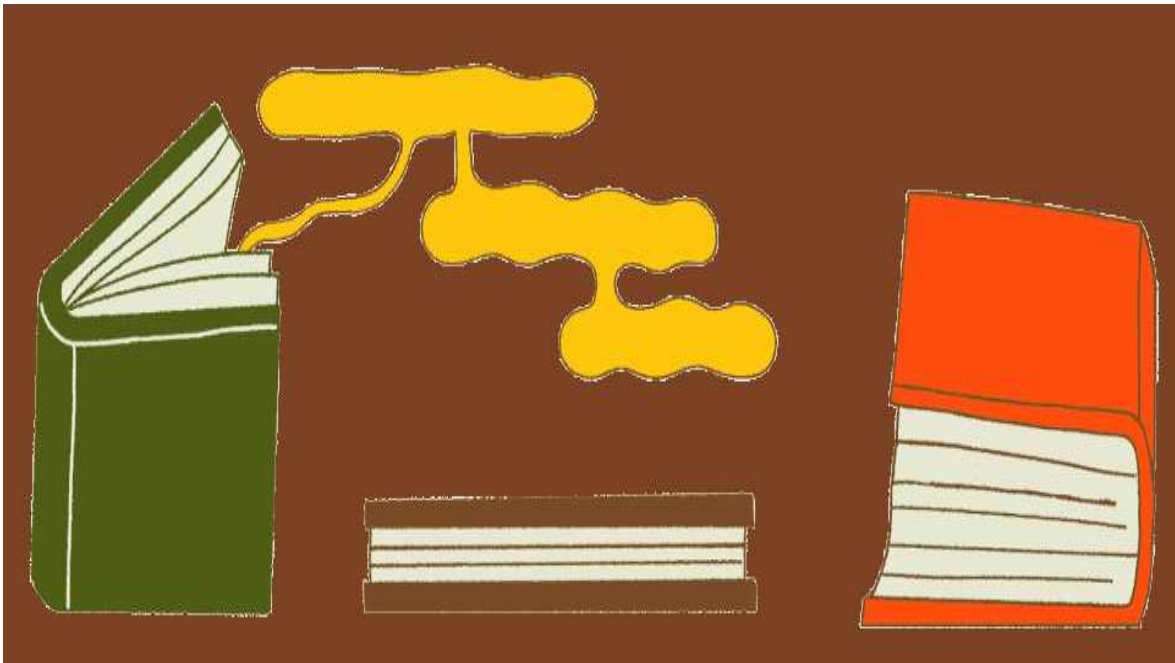
[Korean Messiah](#), by Jonathan Cheng (Knopf). This ambitious history, by the *Wall Street Journal*'s former Korea bureau chief, traces how Kim Il Sung's cult of personality is indebted to the Presbyterian faith in which he was raised. In the late eighteen-hundreds, American missionaries in Korea converted thousands of people. Kim, who took power in 1946, reframed Christianity as a symptom of American imperialism and repurposed its rituals with himself at the center, instituting requirements for ideological activities and imposing harsh punishments on those who failed to show sufficient devotion. Cheng traces how, with the help of Kim's son Jong Il and a distant uncle who was once a pastor, Kim borrowed the tactics of religion to solidify extraordinary psychological control over an entire population.



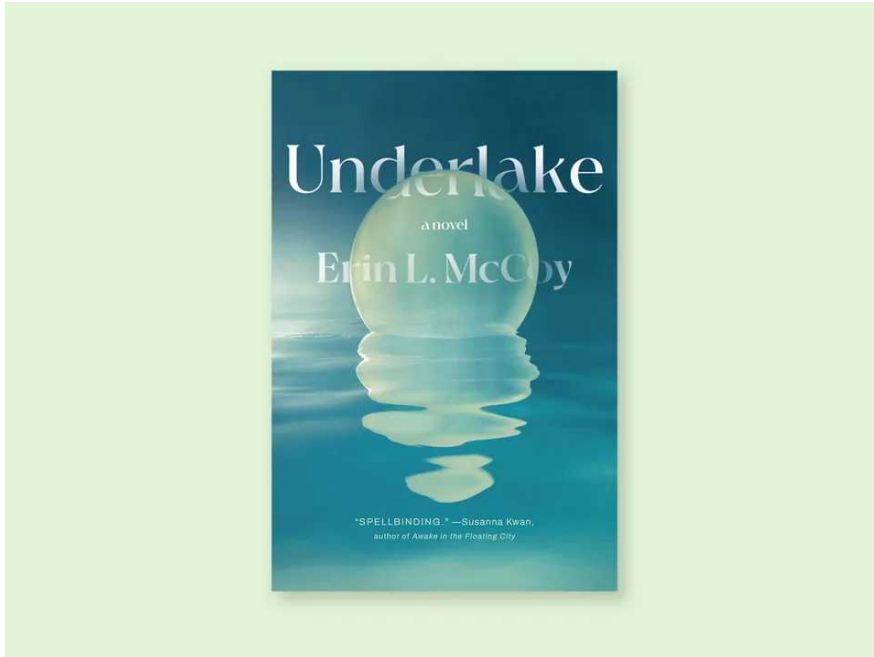
[Small Town Girls](#), by Jayne Anne Phillips (Knopf). In these quietly stunning essays, a Pulitzer Prize-winning novelist, the daughter of an Army veteran and a schoolteacher, looks back on her upbringing in Buckhannon, West Virginia. Born in 1952, Phillips would come to intuit that, in the beauty shops of her youth, women were “initiated into womankind as it existed in our town”; she wanted a bigger life, with options that weren’t available to her restless mother. Many of these pieces find Phillips decades removed from her Appalachian childhood, living elsewhere and writing on other subjects but mindful that she’s not finished reflecting on her origins. For

writers, she says, “our hope in holding a world still between the covers of a book is to make that world known, to save it from vanishing.”

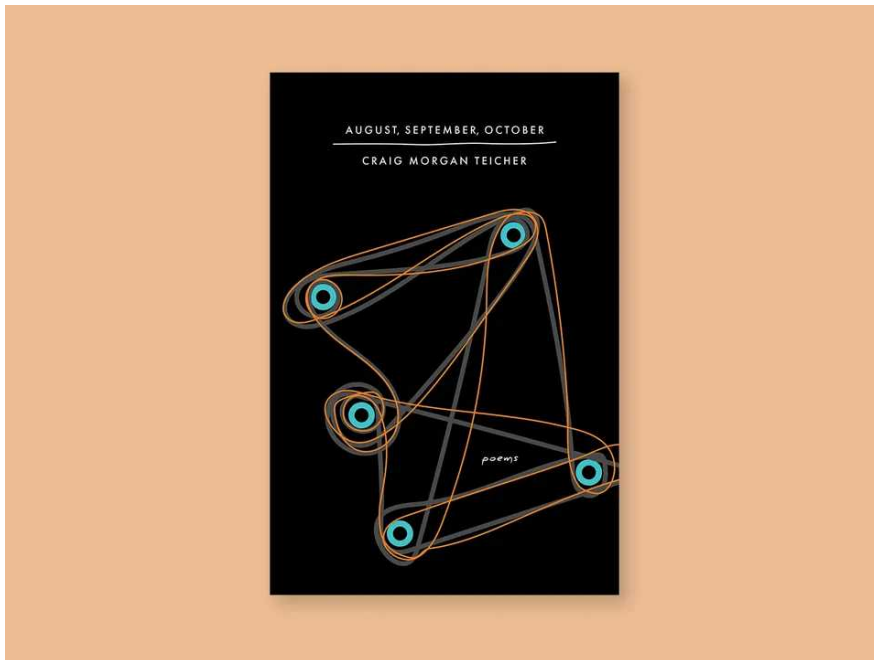
What We're Reading



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Underlake, by *Erin L. McCoy* (*Doubleday*). This surreal début novel riffs on the idea of drowned cities: towns seized by the government and submerged, via dam construction, in order to create reservoirs. The narrative centers on two fictional towns: Paintsville, which was flooded in such a manner in 1979, and the nearby Steels, which is still above water. The protagonist, Otta, is a diver and an aspiring marine biologist. She is enlisted to search for a strange woman's missing daughter, who the woman believes is living in Paintsville. Though McCoy's plot is often murkier than the polluted lake around which its events unfold, her voice, highly attuned to sensory experience, shines through.



[August, September, October](#), by *Craig Morgan Teicher* (Boa Editions). Life may seem to proceed in only one direction, but this moving poetry collection posits that it is more like a poem: characterized by rhyme and repetition, sometimes looping back on itself, each new line reframing those that precede it. As Teicher considers aging, parenthood, marriage, and memory, he meditates on the relationship between time and the forms that capture it: the sonnet seeking to memorialize a moment, or the diary that is a record of its own incompleteness. These poems' immediacy is heightened by their self-awareness as crafted objects; Teicher insists that a life is not a fixed thing but an ongoing act, a process of making and remaking.

Books

The Artist Who Made America Look Like a Promised Land

Frederic Edwin Church sold a nation on its own mythology. That was his making—and his unmaking.

By Sebastian Smee

May 04, 2026



In Curzio Malaparte’s perverse and irksome novel [“The Skin,”](#) an American Army officer stationed in a devastated southern Italy in 1943 exclaims, “Ah Europe! What an extraordinary place it is. I need Europe, to make me conscious of being an American.” The officer—“an American in the noblest sense of the word,” a man with a “delicacy of feeling” prone to blushing at the sight of the degradation all around him—seems to be talking about European culture, of which he is in awe. But he is also using Europe’s moment of deepest ignominy as an excuse to believe in American innocence.

Europe served a similar function in nineteenth-century America. The Continent had generations of infamy to draw on. It had artists like [Francisco Goya](#) and [Hieronymus Bosch](#). It had cities like Rome, about which James Salter once wrote, “Nothing so often betrayed could retain a shred of illusion.” The French Revolution, coming so soon after America’s successful War of Independence, had produced first the Terror and then a war of conquest that culminated in humiliating defeat. France lurched from republic to dictatorship to empire before cycling back through absolute monarchy, constitutional monarchy, Second Republic, and Second Empire. The United States, searching for self-definition but loath to lose its illusions—its innocence—needed all of this as a counterpoint.

Gifted, worldly, and widely loved, Frederic Edwin Church (1826-1900) was the emblematic artist of the middle decades of America’s nineteenth century. A leading figure of the so-called Hudson River School, he painted panoramic landscapes of astonishing detail, grandeur, and moral ambition. Combining dramatic mountains, lush tropical forests, and awe-inspiring geological formations under relentlessly epic skies, he portrayed these environments as richly interconnected, stirring in themselves but also part of something larger: a bigger feeling, a greater idea.

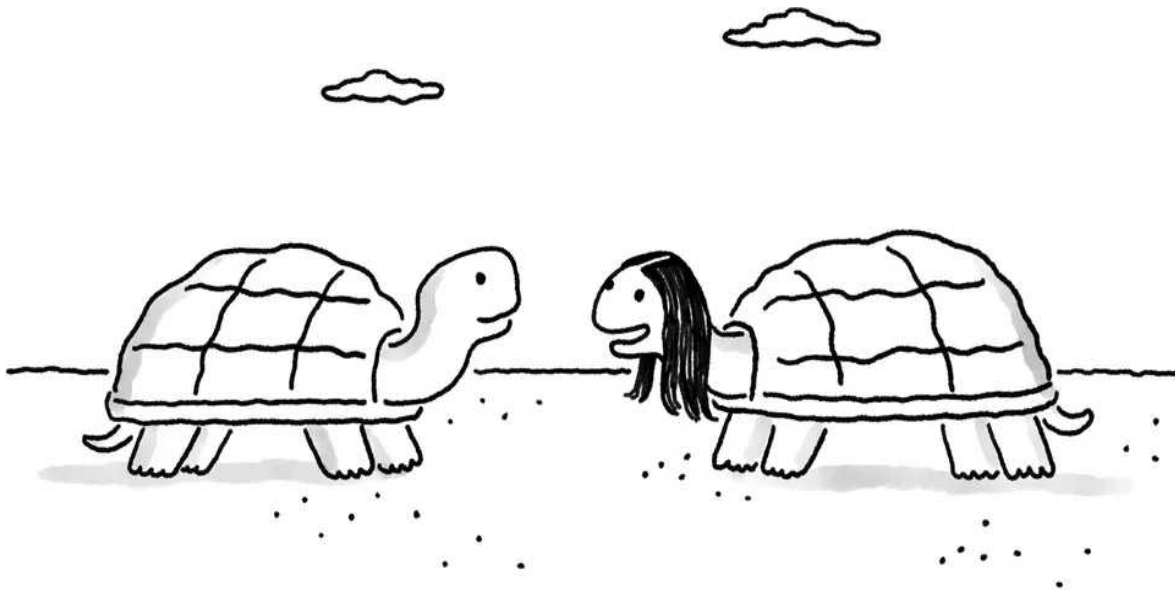
Mark Twain, a repeat visitor to Church’s most celebrated painting, “The Heart of the Andes” (1859), as it toured the U.S., wrote to his brother that a “third visit will find your brain gasping and straining with futile efforts to take all the wonder in.” You will struggle to understand, he continued, “how such a miracle could have been conceived and executed by human brain and human hands.” Landscape painters gain cultural centrality by showing a nation’s territory to itself. Church did for America what John Constable and J. M. W. Turner had done for Britain. Like Turner, Church also travelled far beyond the shores of his homeland. But whatever he painted, whether Andean volcanoes, Arctic icebergs, or the Athenian Parthenon, he was always involved in the difficult project of American self-definition.

Constable and Turner remain central to British identity today, their paintings reproduced on coffee mugs and fridge magnets; Church’s position in American culture is more precarious. Did he show us the United States or something we struggle to recognize—either because it still relied too heavily on Europe or because the United States he depicted was too wrapped up in a

vulgar display of its own innocence? The two-hundredth anniversary of Church's birth is being marked this year by a range of publications and exhibitions. [“Frederic Church: Global Artist”](#) (Yale), the title of an illustrated collection of essays edited by Tim Barringer, Elizabeth Mankin Kornhauser, and Jennifer Raab, feels apt when you understand Church as an American looking to the world for definition. The essays discuss his relationships with the Ottoman Empire, Colombia, and Rome, and consider his legacy in the context of Indigenous and settler histories, slavery, science, ecology, and religion. Perhaps even more apt, however, is the title of a lively new biography of the artist by Victoria Johnson, [“Glorious Country: How the Artist Frederic Church Brought the World to America and America to the World”](#) (Scribner), the “glorious country” in question being America.

Church's credentials as America's national artist were impeccable. Born fifty years after the birth of his nation, he was the direct descendant of an early Puritan pioneer. His father ran a successful silver and jewelry business, and later served as a director of an insurance company in Hartford, Connecticut. To go with his ancestral claims, Church, who had been drawing obsessively since early childhood, also inherited an artistic mantle. At eighteen, he became the only student of [Thomas Cole](#). Though born in Lancashire, England, Cole moved to the United States while still a teen-ager and became his adopted nation's preëminent painter-interpreter. The precocious Church was embraced by the Cole household at a farm, known as Cedar Grove, in Catskill. While other artists of ambition sailed for Europe, Cole's protégé was perfectly satisfied sketching along the Hudson.

[Cole's canvases](#) were synthetic constructions teeming with homilies. He saw America as an Arcadia destined for corruption by populist forces, personified by Andrew Jackson. “We are still in Eden,” he told a New York audience in 1835. “The wall that shuts us out of the garden is our own ignorance and folly.” The changes he witnessed in America, including railway expansion, the adoption of steam power, and worsening pollution, convinced Cole that life's natural rhythms were accelerating out of control. “The Course of Empire,” a series of allegorical paintings he began in 1833, depicted American destiny in terms laid out by Edward Gibbon in “The Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire.”



m.e.menair

Cole's works were as notable for what they omitted as for what they showed. To paint an 1827 view of the Hudson River Valley from the Catskills, he moved aside a mountain blocking the vista, and edited out a hotel and a guardrail at a scenic lookout. (As Diana Seave Greenwald writes in "Frederic Church: Global Artist," when Church visited the Holy Land forty years later, he also chose to edit out or marginalize the obvious—that the territory was Muslim and part of the Ottoman Empire—preferring to focus on the landscape's links with its Greco-Roman and Crusader past.) But Cole's authority extended beyond his canvases; he was also doing his part to create the artistic world from which the young Frederic Church would so auspiciously emerge. He helped found the National Academy of Design, in New York, the year before Church was born. He arranged for two small landscapes by Church, then just shy of nineteen years old, to be exhibited at the academy's prestigious spring show; they were well received, and Church was off and running. He was, according to a friend, "fortune's favorite from the beginning."

Church's first important painting, completed in 1846, was "Hooker and Company Journeying Through the Wilderness from Plymouth to Hartford, in 1636," which depicts early Pilgrims (among them his ancestor Richard Church) seeking asylum from the Bay Colony government in Boston. The wooded, well-irrigated landscape, gilded by the light of the gloaming, is

presented as a promised land. The painting may be the first appearance in art of the American doctrine of Manifest Destiny, a term coined the year before by the newspaperman and diplomat John O'Sullivan. Manifest Destiny entailed not just westward expansion but the spread of liberty and democracy, which O'Sullivan believed was nothing less than "Christianity in its earthly aspect." Abraham Lincoln was wary of the doctrine, perceiving that any such notion of divine inevitability could be used to justify land grabs and war.

Church was not inclined to Cole's pessimism. Where his teacher favored generalized nature, Church moved gradually toward greater specificity and empiricism, even as he continued to use landscape to explore ideas of liberty and American identity. When Church moved to New York, in 1847, he aroused interest as the only student of the famous Thomas Cole. Most of his early sales were to the committee of the National Academy's rival organization, the Art-Union. Established in 1839, the Art-Union sought to connect New York's art world with a national audience through a subscription system and an annual lottery. Church did not, however, neglect the National Academy, and in 1849—in the midst of bloody riots pitting nativists against immigrants and New York's working class against the wealthy—he was promoted to full academician status. Three years later, his "New England Scenery," which transposes the pastoral picturesque of the French artists Claude and Poussin to New England, was sold for thirteen hundred dollars, the highest price then paid for an American painting.

Church's combination of talent, affability, and fine manners eased his way into New York's élite, sometimes inspiring envy among his painter friends. (He "never knew what poverty was," his friend Worthington Whittredge noted.) At the Century Association, a men's club for artists and wealthy patrons (Twain called it "the most unspeakably respectable club in the United States"), he met with Cyrus Field, a merchant about to become famous for laying a telegraph cable across the Atlantic Ocean. In 1851, Church was travelling with Field and his wife, Mary, in Virginia when he first encountered the slave-owning American South.

Tensions over slavery were then ratcheting up everywhere. "There is infamy in the air," [Ralph Waldo Emerson](#) wrote after a fugitive from slavery was brutally captured in Boston; the shame of complicity, he added, "robs the

landscape of beauty, and takes the sunshine out of every hour.” Church and the Fields stayed at Shirley, a plantation just southeast of Richmond. Their host, Hill Carter, “considered himself an enlightened and benevolent man,” Victoria Johnson writes; he “occasionally sold children away from their parents, but no more often, he insisted, than he felt absolutely necessary.” During their visit, the first installment of Harriet Beecher Stowe’s [“Uncle Tom’s Cabin”](#) appeared in a Washington, D.C., newspaper. At Field’s urging, Church painted a view of Virginia’s Natural Bridge, the renowned geological formation alluded to in [“Moby-Dick.”](#)

As a national icon, the Natural Bridge served as a quiet, [Emersonian rebuke](#) to Europe’s militaristic triumphal arches, reinforcing the naturalness of American democracy. Church depicted the high arch, which sits on land once owned by Thomas Jefferson, with scientific precision yet in a romantic, golden light. He signalled his support for racial equality by painting a Black man, picked out by light in the foreground shadows, standing while speaking to a seated white woman, his gestures suggesting pedagogical intent.

Church’s landscapes themselves had pedagogical intent, and the lessons were not just scientific but ethical, spiritual, patriotic. This intent aligned with the nation’s urgent emphasis on education as a defense against mob rule. It aligned, too, with the advice set out in Emerson’s rhapsodic 1836 essay [“Nature,”](#) which posited the natural world as an arena for moral instruction. Channelling Jean-Jacques Rousseau’s [“Emile, or On Education,”](#) Emerson stressed not just self-reliance but an innocent, childlike way of living, free from the “corruptions” of tradition. The influence on American culture of Emerson’s rallying cry—“Why should not we also enjoy an original relation to the universe?”—is hard to overestimate.

When Church travelled to the Andes, first in 1853 and again in 1857 (Field accompanied him on the initial trip and financed both), he was seeking just such an “original relation.” But his epic trip wasn’t itself original—it was in direct emulation of [Alexander von Humboldt](#), the Prussian naturalist and explorer, who, between 1799 and 1804, had traversed thousands of miles in South and Central America. In his treatise [“Cosmos”](#) and in other writings, Humboldt presented the world as a giant “interlaced and interwoven” organism in ways that spoke powerfully to Emerson and [Henry David Thoreau](#) and still resonate today. He also extolled landscape painting as one

of the highest expressions of a love of nature. Church set out to deliver on Humboldt's insight. Johnson's descriptions of his journeys are among the most exciting parts of her biography:

As they climbed ever higher, the rock began to alternate with slabs of glacier. The hail turned to snow. The smoke surging from the crater rolled downward, and even in his discomfort Church admired the "vaporous undulations &c. melting into a smoky light." When the cloud drifted apart briefly, he caught a thrilling glimpse of the summit, swathed in snow. At this altitude, he could barely take ten steps without losing his breath. The horses trudged forward, often coming to a standstill as they snorted and gasped in the thin air.



The most important painting to emerge from that first trip, "The Andes of Ecuador," has a low, centered sun irradiating a vast landscape framed at left by a palm tree and at right by a waterfall. In the distance, stretching the vista almost to its breaking point, are two snowcapped volcanoes. The painting was seen by Thoreau when it went on display at the Boston Athenaeum and was purchased by William Henry Osborn, a young railroad executive with whose family Church would become lastingly close.

Church felt it vital to the success of his pictures—and perhaps, by extension, to American democracy—that people trusted in the accuracy of what he showed them. The thousands who came to see his 1857 painting of Niagara Falls, first in the United States and then in Britain, were astounded by its immense scale and unique perspective. As a performance of attentive observation, it seemed unprecedented. Artists before Church found it all but impossible to “freeze” the movements of water, but in Church’s hands, as the art critic [Robert Hughes](#) wrote, “not a wavelet or an eddy fails to play its part in a narrative of factual cause and effect.”

Church’s second, shorter trip to the Andes led to the creation of his masterpiece. The profusion of precisely rendered detail in “The Heart of the Andes” is mesmerizing, and a reminder of the promiscuous relations, in those years, between science and Romanticism. Just as Emerson had written that “every appearance in nature corresponds to some state of the mind,” Church made sure, as the art historian Rebecca Bedell has said of the painting, that “almost every pictorial detail has its counterpart in Humboldt’s words.”

And yet “The Heart of the Andes” is not a faithful rendering of a particular view. It’s a composite, contrived in the studio, informed by the scores of sketches and color notations Church had made while travelling. Like a teacher guiding a child, the work leads the eye step-by-step from the lower right to the upper left. In the foreground is a lushly forested valley with a river and a waterfall and two pilgrims before a wayside cross. In the middle distance is a human settlement, then a band of golden grasslands, then the arid lower slopes of the Cordilleras, and finally the snowy peaks, including the grand dome of Chimborazo.

Seven decades or so earlier, the Scottish naturalist James Hutton had argued that geological processes played out gradually over previously unimagined periods of time. His discovery of what John McPhee later termed “deep time” seemed to pulverize any claims to human significance. But Church, undeterred, was drawn to the idea that those processes offered lessons in destruction and renewal which could be applied to a nation teetering on civil war. In a forty-three-page guide to “The Heart of the Andes,” Church’s friend Theodore Winthrop found “proofs everywhere of change, building,

razing, upheaval, sinking, and deliberate crumbling away.” But he also saw evidence of how “new ruin restores the strong lines that old ruin weakened.”

Church wanted to help restore America’s “strong lines,” which he thought of as republican, abolitionist, Christian, and scientific. Like Humboldt, he believed that science could be reconciled with religion. But when Charles Darwin published [“On the Origin of Species,”](#) in 1859, a new view of life threatened to snuff out Humboldt’s idea of a benevolent “harmony, blending together all created things,” and replace it with a Hobbesian vision of randomness, conflict, and opportunism. Darwin’s theory did not preclude social coöperation or progress, but it undermined the idea that there was any deeper purpose to life than survival. Church, for all his scientific curiosity, was not moved to convert Darwinism into pictorial rhetoric. “I wish science would take a holiday for ten years so I could catch up,” he wrote near the end of his life.

That Church combined his educational mission with a gift for showmanship led some to compare him to [P. T. Barnum](#). The circus promoter who gave us bearded infants, giantesses from Maine, and Jumbo the elephant had earlier established the American Museum, in lower Manhattan. Along with exhibits of skeletons, mummies, and Revolutionary War mementos, the museum included an entire floor of dioramas and panoramic paintings. In phalanxes of varying typeface which mirrored the very babble of democracy, the posters advertising the museum promised “hours and hours of entertainment, instruction, and moral uplift.”

Barnum’s museum wasn’t far south of the Tenth Street Studio, where, over three weeks in May, 1859, Church first displayed “The Heart of the Andes” to twelve thousand ticket-holding patrons. The painting’s gigantic walnut frame resembled a window set into a niche. Heavy draperies on a curtain rod were drawn back to reveal the work, which viewers often had to line up for hours to see. “The subject is new, the scenes are strange, the facts are amazing,” Winthrop wrote, sounding (as Bedell notes) very much like one of Barnum’s publicity leaflets. But Church was not a snob. If he had a bit of show biz in him, it was just one more thing that made him emblematically American.

Among the crowds who came to see the painting was Isabel Carnes, the pretty daughter of a luxury-imports merchant from Dayton, Ohio. By the beginning of 1860, she and Church were engaged. After marrying, they settled on his property in the Hudson Valley.

By then, Church had a band of followers. More than any artist before him, he had made the case for American art—and, by extension, American identity—as distinct, vigorous, and independent. Yet, with the United States on the cusp of civil war, the question of what counted as “American art” became newly charged. Art historians—among them Angela Miller and Tyler Green—have argued that “The Heart of the Andes” was perhaps less about South America than it was about the United States. At a time of intensifying divisions at home, a depiction of Ecuador could offer an Edenic, new-world landscape free from the partisanship tainting Church’s New England landscapes. The Andes’ natural features could symbolically integrate both the North (snowcapped peaks) and the South (hot lowlands). Church was using a foreign landscape, in other words, to appeal for American unity.

When war broke out, Church’s friend Winthrop died on the battlefield; he is often cited as the first Union officer to die in combat. Church’s landscapes from those traumatic years functioned as commentaries on the conflict’s course. Warnings, laments, and odes to renewal were expressed pictorially as dying days under bleeding heavens, belching volcanoes, proud icebergs, lavish rainbows amid spangling, mist-suffusing sunlight and dawns of peace and hope.

Church was the first great American painter to make a point of snubbing Europe; he neither grew up nor trained there, and did not set foot in the Continent until his reputation was long established. Yet he continued to depend heavily on European pictorial conventions, above all that of the Romantic sublime. The sublime—a concept introduced by the first-century philosopher Longinus and later refined by Edmund Burke and Immanuel Kant—rests on an encounter with something too immense or too powerful for the human mind to comprehend fully. With it comes an expectation that, as the mind cracks apart under the strain of trying, we might glimpse the transcendent. In landscape painting, the sublime had its origins in the high-angled, panoramic vistas (or “world landscapes”) of Joachim Patinir,

Albrecht Altdorfer, and Pieter Bruegel the Elder. It was developed into a rhetoric by Salvator Rosa in the seventeenth century and by Caspar David Friedrich and Turner in the early nineteenth century.

In Church's hands, the sublime served as an index to the vastness and complexity of nature, the greatness of God, and the "naturalness" of the new nation. But there was something belated about his adoption of this fundamentally European tradition. Compare Church's landscapes with paintings by the French realists and Impressionists who were his contemporaries, and you become conscious of an assumed relationship between landscape, national identity, and religious revelation that had already begun to feel strained. The landscapes of Church and his peer Albert Bierstadt (who painted the American West) can feel like histrionic versions of Friedrich's simpler, more concentrated aesthetic.

When Church did finally visit Europe, in the late eighteen-sixties, he was unimpressed. ("The Tiber is not the Hudson," he wrote.) He was drawn instead to the Levant, and his travels to the Middle East, in 1868, inspired what many consider his last masterpiece—not a painting but Olana, a lovingly designed landscape and his home on a hill in the Hudson Valley. With its winding paths, extensive planting, and choreographed vistas offering views of four states, Olana is a sort of *Gesamtkunstwerk* to which Church devoted the final decades of his career. "I can make more and better landscapes in this way," he wrote, "than by tampering with canvas and paint in the studio."

The eccentric design of Olana was inspired by fortresses in Persia (where, curiously, Church *hadn't* travelled), as well as Italian, East Indian, Gothic Revival, and French Second Empire architecture. Its *Wunderkammer*-like interior, preserved and open to the public since 1967, is hectically eclectic—filled with paintings and sketches by Church and his friends alongside Indian and Chinese furniture, Central Asian textiles, Persian tiles, Mexican sombreros, Japanese paintings, European Old Master copies, and an extensive library.

Church's fondness for pumping moral rhetoric into his pictures may reassure us that, on questions about slavery, democracy, and the environment, he was on the right side of history (to invoke another innocent illusion). But it's also

what caused his work to fall from favor. His problem was not so much that people stopped buying the rhetoric—it was that people wanted less rhetoric. Winslow Homer, a decade younger than Church, started his career by making illustrations for *Harper's Weekly* during the Civil War. He populated his landscapes—closely cropped and near at hand—with real people, not ciphers, and his robust, adhesive style was more in step with vernacular traditions. If, today, Homer feels more emblematically American to us than Church does, it's because his paintings made his audience care a little more about the story and a little less about its cosmic implications.

In America, the lessons of Impressionism—which coincided in France with the end of an empire and the beginning of the enduring Third Republic—fell on receptive ground. The new movement, as it gathered momentum, unravelled France's academy-based, state-sponsored Salon system. (The annual juried spring exhibitions at New York's National Academy of Design were patterned after the Salon.) A thriving republic, artists started to realize, might require fewer visions of the sublime and more images of everyday scenes. People wanted beauty, yes. But, instead of God-bothering sunsets and foreign vistas, they yearned to recognize themselves and the people they loved.

Like the republican project itself, the artistic movements of both Europe and America were a mashup of mutual influences. And yet Europe's sheer cultural weight intensified America's thirst for separation. In Church's day, that separation depended on promoting a robust idea of American innocence over Europe's enfeebling corruption.

The rhetoric of innocence, even if it's illusory, can be energizing, but, when it fails to match reality, it can also become exhausting. The distance between the ideal in your head and the facts on the ground can open out at your feet like a canyon. The only way to subdue the dizziness may be to let go of the big ideas—nation, nature, arcs of history bending toward justice, and so on. That may be why the dominant strains in American modernism (at least until the mid-twentieth century, when the sublime reappeared in the work of the Abstract Expressionists) cleaved to the factual, the intimate, the proximate. The poet William Carlos Williams's rallying cry “No ideas but in things” found echoes all through American culture, including in the writings of

[Ernest Hemingway](#), the photography of Walker Evans (“If the thing is there, why there it is”), and the poetry of [Frank O’Hara](#) (“I do this, I do that”).

But, even if Church’s propensity to recruit nature for heavy-handed symbolism can seem too much today, something about his work—some combination of thrilling ambition, tact tethered to empiricism, and loving tenderness—continues to magnetize our spectacle-jaded eyes. Sadly, his life rhymed not only with American success but also with American grief. His and Isabel’s first two children both died of diphtheria in March, 1865, just weeks before President Lincoln’s death. Church threw himself into public life, serving as a parks commissioner in New York and helping to found the Metropolitan Museum of Art. His decades-long development of Olana, however, coincided with worsening rheumatoid arthritis. Beginning in his wrist, it eventually affected his entire body. Warm weather helped, so he spent more than a dozen winters in Mexico while Isabel, suffering from her own chronic health troubles, turned increasingly to religion. Fred, their oldest surviving child, was suspended from Princeton for cheating, then caught embezzling from his Seattle employer to feed, Church suspected, a gambling habit. He ended up managing a hotel in Honolulu, far from his dismayed parents.

Shortly before Lincoln’s assassination, in 1865, with the North’s victory in the Civil War in sight, the President had told his wife, Mary, that he wanted to visit Jerusalem and the Holy Land. Around three years later, Church and his family set forth to do what was denied to the Lincolns. Their travels in the Middle East nearly coincided with Mark Twain’s. Church went to the Holy Land in search of sublimity; Twain fastened on the absurdities of those determined to find it. In the book that resulted, [“The Innocents Abroad,”](#) Twain’s mockery often settled on his stand-in for the pious guidebook author William C. Prime, who, he wrote, “went through this peaceful land with one hand forever on his revolver, and the other on his pocket-handkerchief. Always, when he was not on the point of crying over a holy place, he was on the brink of killing an Arab.” Twain was by turns amused and appalled by the histrionics that taint our tellings of history, and by the yawning gaps between myth and reality.

Still, when Twain visited Church at Olana, in 1887, he had a wonderful time. It was, he wrote in a thank-you note, “an ideal holiday, in a Garden of

Eden.” ♦

Books

Harriet Clark's Début Is a New Kind of Coming-of-Age Novel

In “The Hill,” a daughter grows up amid visits to her imprisoned mother, inheriting the afterlife of a youthful radicalism that shattered her family.

By James Wood

May 04, 2026



The bildungsroman is the coming-of-age novel; it is also the coming-to-terms novel. The protagonist, usually a young man, undergoes a series of adventures that eventually spit him out wiser, stronger, set up for life's journey. The form schools the hero in the ways of the world, and, even if he is rebellious ([“A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man”](#)) or cynical ([“Sentimental Education”](#)), the ways of the world are taken as given. Or even embraced: perhaps the genre's best-loved example, [“David Copperfield,”](#) ends with marriage.

It is curious that the bildungsroman, officially committed to interrogating the world, should be so at home in it. Then again, the novel, a worldly form and

rather proud of it, has good reason not to question the basic terms of our existence. We shouldn't be surprised that, with a few notable exceptions, the novel avoids any fundamental metaphysical skepticism: it may be a largely secular genre, but its secularism is settled, not unduly tormented. Traditionally, the bourgeois novel questioned the viability of bourgeois life, not the viability of life itself.

But imagine, for a moment, a different kind of coming-of-age novel. Say that a human life is a metaphysical experiment—though one that, by and large, refuses to think of itself as such. Metaphysical because we are trying to ascertain the meaning of our existence, the significance of our short lease. An experiment because we can, if we want, test the likelihood of that significance against the likelihood of futility. And a refusal because we might come to the alarming conclusion that life, metaphysically speaking, is not ordained or designed but arbitrary—that it is, in fact, ordained to be arbitrary. Just as the worldly novel tends to do, most of us dodge and deny this fundamental experiment, since the revelation would seem to rob life of the jewel of meaning. Or worse, to turn it into a sort of prison sentence.

Are there examples of *this* kind of bildungsroman? A coming-of-age novel alert to the terror of the arbitrary, restless with the very terms of our earthly existence? In our era, two come to mind: Marilynne Robinson's "[Housekeeping](#)" (1980) and Kazuo Ishiguro's "[Never Let Me Go](#)" (2005). Robinson is warmly theological where Ishiguro is bleakly philosophical, lyrically expansive where Ishiguro is almost blandly lucid. But what these books have in common—apart from the telling fact that both are narrated by female characters—is a powerful estrangement from the structures of ordinary life. In both novels, young people are trying to figure out how life works, confounded by the arbitrariness of what is presented to them as natural. The arrivals and departures that, for most of us, constitute the largely comprehensible stages of existence (birth, school, love, marriage, death) function, in these novels, like whimsically slammed doors. Though embedded in society, these young characters are Kaspar Hauser-like figures, spectrally isolated from the signifying world, forced to construct meaning for themselves, from the ground up. For Robinson, that task amounts to the construction of a personal religion, part pantheistic, part Christian. For Ishiguro, the quest results in a revelation of the darkest possible allegory. Both are profoundly unworldly novels: they show us that it is not inevitable

that we can (Robinson), or should (Ishiguro), make our way through the world at all.

Now a third joins their company, Harriet Clark's superb first novel, ["The Hill"](#) (Farrar, Straus & Giroux). It is narrated by Suzanna, who lives with her grandparents in New York City. Nearly every weekend—first with her grandfather, then with a nun named Sister Claudine, and, finally, once she's nearly a teen-ager, on her own—Suzanna makes a trip out of town to visit her mother in a hilltop prison. Only gradually does it emerge that her mother is serving a very long sentence for her role in a bank robbery that resulted in the death of a security guard. Clark's novel is a brilliantly deprived bildungsroman. It has the form and emphasis of a coming-of-age story but is devoid of the usual content. We see Suzanna through her developing phases—at nine, at twelve, at fifteen, and then about to graduate from high school, a period when "a great venturing forth had commenced" (though not for Suzanna, who does not apply to college). People dispense advice to our heroine of the kind that one encounters in stories properly poised on the cusp of life. Suzanna's grandmother tells her, "We'll have to see how you turn out." Suzanna's mother intones, "All kids leave their mother . . . children leave. They're supposed to." She writes imploringly from prison, "If you figure out a way to be happy . . . it changes everything."

But where would Suzanna go? And how could she leave her mother, if her mother left her first? Besides, like the young sisters in "Housekeeping," Suzanna is only faintly socialized. Her father is not in the picture; she seems to have no school friends; she is at the mercy of her eccentric and willful grandparents. Clark's novel is something of a tribute to Robinson's. She gives Suzanna's mother and grandmother the same names that Robinson gives her book's mother and aunt (Helen and Sylvie), and she likes to start sentences with Robinson's grandly suppositional "Say" (in the style I channelled earlier: "Say that a human life is a metaphysical experiment"). More important, Robinson seems to have shown Clark how to write about a girl whose mother is absent (in "Housekeeping," the mother kills herself) but whose fate rests with elders so absorbed in their own intricate dramas of departure that their young charge feels abandoned twice over, by two generations of absconding guardians.

Like Robinson, Clark gets some comedy out of the morbid whimsy (so it seems to Suzanna) of the very old. For one thing, the old have an inconvenient habit of dying. It's foolish, Suzanna laments, "to have attached myself to the group of people least likely to stick around." First to go is Suzanna's grandfather, who had accompanied her for years on her weekly prison visits. (Her grandmother has taken "a vow of absence" and never goes to see her daughter.) Suzanna views the world with a sort of jealous estrangement, refusing to make sense of fundamentals such as death. She has divided others into "those who leave and those who stay," and her grandfather's departure simply puts him in the wrong camp. Here, Clark's novel offers a beautifully subtle picture of childish unsubtlety: "One day it was unbelievable that a person would die, and another day we believed it. A change in him or in us."



Lars

Even when not dying, the older generation has a marked talent for disappearance. Sylvie, Suzanna's grandmother, is at the heart of the book: stubborn, abrupt, vengeful, wounded, and wounding. Also, wildly amusing. Her erratic driving, for instance, stems from her conviction that the lines on the road are mere suggestions, "and when had she given heed to other people's suggestions?" Furious at her imprisoned daughter, Sylvie punishes her near-at-hand granddaughter with another type of imprisonment: a vision of the world as an implacably hostile zero-sum game, in which everyone is

killing one another. Your mother's choices "killed your grandfather," Sylvie tells Suzanna. And now "you're killing me." Sylvie is haunted by what she sees as her daughter's selfish desertion of Suzanna as a baby: when she chose to rob the bank, she tells her granddaughter, "she held you and looked at you and then she put you down and left you forever." Now Sylvie metes out the same punishment on Suzanna: "Punishment comes in many forms, and my grandmother's preferred form was banishment. My removal or hers, expulsion or disappearance." One day, Sylvie takes Suzanna, age nine, to the bank that her mother robbed, forces her to go inside on her own, and then inexplicably drives away. Suzanna understands this particular lesson to be that "the arrangement of my family was neither destined to be nor destined to last." Sylvie systematically deconstructs Suzanna's world. You don't have to visit your mother, she says. But I do have to, Suzanna replies. "According to who?" Sylvie asks. "You don't even have to go to school." Fed on moral scraps, the child must find her own meaning on which to subsist.

With the exception of the punitive visit to the bank, Suzanna's grandmother does not discuss her daughter's crime or her reasons for committing it. "What your mother did" is Sylvie's smothering précis; "your mother took it too far" is her grandfather's milder version. This may well echo the kind of rationed discourse that the author heard when she was growing up with her own grandparents. But it is also a canny novelistic strategy to keep this autobiographical novel from being flooded with autobiography. Harriet Clark, born in 1980, is the daughter of the [Weather Underground](#) activist Judy Clark, who took part in the robbery of a Brink's truck in Nanuet, New York, in 1981, an incident that left three people dead. Judy was found guilty of murder in 1983, and served thirty-eight years, mostly in Bedford Hills Correctional Facility. Harriet was thirty-eight when her mother was released, in 2019. In the book's acknowledgments, she says that she has been working on this novel for "a very, very long time." One can barely imagine the intolerable weight of this family inheritance—its singularity at once tempting and difficult for a novel, irresistible for so many years yet the only thing one wants to escape, with the novelist daughter always mentally at work, like Penelope at her shroud, on a project that she is simultaneously unwriting. From the novelist's point of view, the story's fatal glamour skews it toward memoir: Why fictionalize such remarkable facts? Clark's wise remedy is to strip her fiction of most of those facts, reducing the local references so that the narrative shifts away from singular autobiography

toward singular emblem. Not Harriet Clark but an isolated girl in the city; not Bedford Hills but a hilltop compound named only Hillcrest; not the notorious Brink's robbery but a heist that went "too far."

One effect is that the bildungsroman, which would typically chart the stages of a richly realized domestic existence, is forced to turn its stripped story into a kind of bitter allegory, in which those stages of development and fulfillment are ironized by an institution that deprives them of meaning: the prison. Clark wields prison nomenclature like something out of "The Pilgrim's Progress": we become intimately familiar with the compound's various spaces—Visiting, Children's Center, Laundry, Processing, the Hole, the Roost. Sister Claudine, the kindly nun who takes Suzanna to visit her mother after her grandfather's death, is referred to as Sister. When Sister retires from prison work, she ends her days at the ominously named Saint Joseph's Home for Compassionate Returns, praying at the bedsides of the dying. These are the true spaces and phrases of Suzanna's development, the valley she must journey through. If what she wants most is to be united with her mother in prison, if it is in Visiting or the Children's Center that she feels most alive, then her life is something like an inherited prison sentence, weekly revoked and reinstated. The prison, which took away her mother and which makes Suzanna's life conditional, functions like the clones' boarding school in "Never Let Me Go," generating and voiding meaning at once. Suzanna's mother may say that the most important thing is to find a way to be happy, but an acquaintance of Sylvie's seems closer to the mark when he briskly consoles Suzanna: "Don't worry . . . you'll get to die too. No one has to live forever."

The other effect of Clark's reductions is that she need not revisit and adjudicate the ethics of Judy Clark's radicalism. The book focusses not on the past but on the strange, lonely present, which is full of waiting. Suzanna's grandparents have steered her away from all forms of political engagement: "Though previously in the family attempts had been made to act on the world, great efforts to change it, what had been communicated to me was that the world was none of my business." This may explain why Suzanna's mother is a somewhat indistinct presence in the novel (at least compared with fierce Sylvie)—patient, even serene behind bars, more eager to talk about her daughter's future than about her own future, let alone her troubled past. By widening the lens, Clark is able to redirect the book's gaze

from the mother toward a quizzical, sometimes critical, but not unaffectionate portrait of two generations of political activism, with the attendant self-involvement and domestic negligence. Suzanna's grandparents may powerfully disapprove of their daughter's choices, but as good Communists they did their time in the Soviet Union, where Suzanna's grandfather worked in the Moscow office of the *Daily Worker*. Perhaps Sylvie now regrets her time in Moscow, even the tenor of her politics. But Suzanna can't help noticing, as she listens to her grandmother talk with her friends, that an entire generation seems to have done a notably poor job of "keeping their children around." Parental abandonment is passed down, learned. Suzanna's mother abandoned her the moment she decided to rob the bank. And Sylvie, who still gazes with utmost tenderness at a black-and-white photograph, taken during her time abroad, of a nameless wailing Russian child, has permanently abandoned her own daughter by refusing to visit her.

Is it any wonder that Suzanna longs only for connection and reunion? Her fond idea of restoration, of healing, of heaven—a secular version of the poetic dreams of eternity that punctuate "Housekeeping"—is:

a place where everyone we'd ever known would be. A crowded place. Everyone would remark on the crowdedness and the surprise of seeing him here and her too. Generally everyone was glad to see each other and be together and no one seemed to care who had betrayed who or who, even, had killed who. . . . Everyone was so relieved to see how bewildered everyone else was that the feeling in this place was almost festive.

It is a measure of this novel's lucidity, its honesty and unillusioned wit, that Suzanna's vision of this crowded heaven, shared with her grandmother, is not allowed to rest on its lyrical laurels. "Like hell," Sylvie comments. Or, at least, like prison. ♦

The Theatre

“Schmigadoon!” and “The Lost Boys” Are Killer Revamps

Camp has become the go-to aesthetic for Broadway musicals. These two new shows dare to be sincere.

By Emily Nussbaum

April 30, 2026



The frothy, delectable “Schmigadoon!” is about a classic Upper West Side predicament: a love affair between two doctors, one who hates musicals and one who adores them. Josh is a skeptic who gets itchy whenever actors burst into song; Melissa is a believer who longs for a romance so transcendent that it can be expressed only in an airy glissando, opted up an octave. Three years into their relationship, they’ve hit a wall, because you can’t duet with somebody who won’t sing back.

And then, on a couples’ hiking trip, they stumble into a landscape that is Melissa’s fantasy and Josh’s worst nightmare, an idyllic village called Schmigadoon. A magical hamlet with cute gabled cottages and hand-painted

mountains, it's the setting for a gleeful mishmash of virtually every mid-century musical, including "Brigadoon" (from which the show draws its premise), "The Music Man," "Oklahoma!," "Carousel," "The King and I," "South Pacific," "Finian's Rainbow," and "The Sound of Music." Villagers in sorbet-tinted outfits burst into "I want" numbers; the giddy ensemble seizes any excuse to kick up their Capezios. Josh is desperate to escape, but unfortunately, as a leprechaun informs him, he can't do so without finding true love.

Will you, too, fall head over heels? I sure did. My response to entering Schmigadoon was, to be frank, not that different from Melissa's: I'm an easy lay for a swoony ballad, I love a deep-cut golden-age callback, and I'm happiest when grinning lunatics in crinolines start grapevining around a gazebo. During the pandemic, I devoured the show's source, the TV series "Schmigadoon!," co-created by Cinco Paul and Ken Daurio; back then, Melissas like me were so thirsty to experience something resembling live theatre that we lurked on TikTok, watching stars on hiatus lose their minds in Hell's Kitchen sublets. (Anyone who saw Ben Platt singing "Part of Your World" in a ketchup-red wig, using a fork as a trident, knows what I'm talking about.)

Season 1 of the TV show was aimed at such diehards; the second season, "Schmicago," a pastiche of sexy, cynical musicals from the seventies, including "Pippin" and "Cabaret," felt broader in its appeal and, artistically, like a kick step up—and I hope that its creators turn that season into a Broadway show, too. But Paul's loyal adaptation of the debut season clicks beautifully onstage, because "Schmigadoon!" is now exactly what it pretended to be: a live Broadway romp, all escapist virtuosity and (you gotta have) heart.

The first sign of the show's commitment to the bit is the third song, a delirious hoedown called "Corn Puddin'," a parody of inane but delightful vintage numbers such as "Real Nice Clambake," "Shipooopi," and the demented "Turkey Lurkey Time." Josh rolls his eyes, repulsed by the elbows-out hoofing; Melissa goes native, twangily improvising a verse asking for an "extry" helping. Soon, the two leads are flirting (and cavorting) with new true-love prospects, in smartly crafted songs that are peppered with meta touches. "Effortless, effortless! This is so effing

effortless,” Melissa croons in “Enjoy the Ride,” as she banters with a Billy Bigelow-ish carnival barker. “I wanna taste the things I’ve never tasted. / Man, your pants are really high-waisted.” A rowdy riff on “Ya Got Trouble!,” from “The Music Man,” escalates, alarmingly, into warnings about “Cows and sheep having amorous congress!” An airy ballad called “Suddenly” beautifully captures the irrational yet irresistible romance that pulses through the genre: “There’s no sense in trying to explain it. / What and where and why and when and how. / All I know is suddenly I love you / and, suddenly, that’s all that matters now.”

“Schmigadoon!” is at its funniest when it tweaks the tradition’s sillier motifs, such as a crowd of children nonsensically bursting into laughter at the end of a song. But the show isn’t a finger-wagging critique, let alone an edgy deconstruction—it’s mostly an opportunity for the creators to poke gentle fun at the classics while tapping into the sparkling well they sprang from. If you’re in a picky mood, you could find flaws: Act I ends with the kind of soft cliffhanger that makes more sense in TV. But who cares? The book’s shambolic rhythms pay off, as pressure slowly builds on Josh to join in instead of judging. And, God, the dancing is good: skilled, energetic, joyful.

The cast is excellent, particularly Isabelle McCalla as a spunky teacher, Brad Oscar as a closeted mayor, and Max Clayton as that tight-panted carnival barker. Alex Brightman, who was such a devilish extrovert in “Beetlejuice,” plays Josh with likable restraint, which makes his inevitable solo feel as meaningful as a longed-for kiss.

Still, the standout is a performer in a minor role: McKenzie Kurtz, who was the thrilling wild card in the otherwise disappointing recent revival of “Heathers,” in which she found wiggly layers in the bitch queen Heather Chandler. As the Ado Annie-like Betsy, a horny teen-ager whose father owns a shotgun, Kurtz is playing a character who should be, and kind of is, a one-joke punch line. She pulls off her big song, “Not That Kind of Gal,” gloriously, channelling the mid-century musical’s warped blend of libido and innocence. But it’s Kurtz’s physical performance, especially her gleaming rictus of a grin—jaw dropped nearly to her collarbone, eyes popped as wide as sunflowers—that becomes a symbol of the show’s wholesome appeal,

which is all about being a little bit extray. In the safe space that is “Schmigadoon!,” there’s no such thing as cringe.

The equally larger-than-life musical “The Lost Boys” opens with a mysterious bang, and then with a staticky black-and-white date displayed high above the stage: “1987,” shuddering like a threat. Over loudspeakers, we hear the syrupy voice of President Ronald Reagan, droning on about family values. Finally, we see a flashlight—a cop is moving through the inky darkness of an industrial space, unwitting prey for the undead.

From then on, “The Lost Boys” never stops moving, managing to be at once kinetic and poetic, earnestly emotional and rock-and-roll bombastic, a remarkably sincere vampire story produced with such attention to detail that you might forgive the fact that the music is pretty weak. Camp has become the go-to aesthetic for new musicals, in fabulous recent spectacles such as “Death Becomes Her,” “The Rocky Horror Show,” and “Cats: The Jellicle Ball,” and in entertaining but lesser offerings such as “Titanique” and “Chess.” “The Lost Boys,” which is based on a cult-classic vampire flick with a giggly homoerotic subtext, could easily have chosen that path, placing the audience at an ironic distance from its cheesy source, which is now notable mainly for a *GIF* of a well-oiled, shirtless saxophone player. It’s comparatively risk-free I.P.: easy to mock, hard to defend on purist grounds.

This makes it all the more impressive that the creators have taken such a big swing, by shifting the material in the opposite direction: like the TV series “Buffy the Vampire Slayer,” they swap camp for mythology. It’s not that the writers, David Hornsby and Chris Hoch, or the director, Michael Arden, ignore the movie’s goofiness; that oily saxophonist struts onstage early, to huge laughs. But they’ve given the story a much darker edge, and also a strong political through line about a single-parent family resisting Reagan-era shame. Best of all, the central characters, the single mom Lucy and her sons, Michael and Sam, have a legitimate thematic arc: they’ve fled cross-country to California to escape an abusive, alcoholic father, which makes their behavior cohere, particularly in the case of the moody, tormented Michael (L. J. Benet), who is both attracted to violent monsters and fearful of becoming one. The erotic implications of vampiric temptation—and of glam-rock front men who generously offer to pierce an ear under the boardwalk—remain. But they’re balanced by a plot about the nerdy younger

brother, Sam (an appealing Benjamin Pajak), coming out, complete with a corny, unabashed queer-hero solo. The moment should fall flat, but in a musical unafraid to be blunt, and in the context of today's eighties-style homophobia, it kills.

The show's biggest weakness is its music—and normally that would be enough to sour me on any musical. The songs, by the indie band the Rescues, are dominated by gluey ballads and hollow thrash numbers, full of on-the-nose lyrics such as “I have to have you.” This poses a particular problem when it comes to Star, Michael's love interest, whose songs are frustratingly limp. So why does “The Lost Boys” feel so exhilarating, even without the ingredient that makes a musical a musical? Mainly, because it's such a sharp, propulsive production in every other way. The dazzlingly engineered set, by Dane Laffrey, is refreshingly handcrafted after years of Broadway shows being dominated by screens. The dedicated cast never condescends. It's all enough to make a dopey song feel like a jam.

Everything is framed by the set's colossal, shadowy industrial space, dense with ladders and catwalks—the better for vampires to lurk. But the stage keeps seamlessly shifting, transforming into a realistic, cluttered two-story house; a grimy boardwalk lit by neon; a slinky, skunky vampires' lair; the bright interior of a video store; a spooky bridge; and an abandoned playground, complete with a rusty pelican on a spring. The titular vampire gang has formed a band, and when its members start to shred, the stage sinks down to create a mosh pit—a hellish underworld into which victims later drop.

By the final showdown, the production has made use of every bit of stage space, with sensational flying sequences (choreographed by Lauren Yalango-Grant and Christopher Cree Grant) that allow the vampires to float, hover, and—in one especially intense moment—dive from that bridge. “The Lost Boys” has a staggering budget, and you feel every cent of it onstage: there's even an eerie “button” scene *after* the curtain call, like a post-credits teaser. Instead of feeling self-indulgent, the show makes its enormity a strength—embracing every chance to underline its points and then scrawl “How true!” in the margins. Does that sound like overkill? Perhaps, but it's a blast.

Even so, my favorite number was the smallest: “Wild,” sung by Shoshana Bean, who plays Lucy with quiet warmth. In that derelict playground, Lucy reminisces about her hippie youth, then spins in joyful abandon on a rusty carrousel. Amid the clamor of the show’s anthems, “Wild” is a sweet respite. It’s an homage to the fearlessness of adolescence, when every risk feels worth taking, whatever the cost. ♦

An earlier version of this article misspelled Chris Hoch’s surname.

“The Devil Wears Prada 2” Gives the Decline of Magazines the Glossy Treatment

The sequel, which reunites Anne Hathaway, Meryl Streep, and Emily Blunt, is familiar and at times preposterous—but it’s also a savvy, shiny reflection of our era.

By Justin Chang

April 29, 2026



In “The Devil Wears Prada 2,” the offices of the fashion magazine *Runway* have become a moderately kinder, gentler place. Two decades after we first met her, Miranda Priestly (Meryl Streep), the indomitable editor-in-chief, still demands perfection from her staff, but her mid-meeting insults are more sniffy than withering, and even her sharpest glare no longer has quite the same serrated edge. Over the years, Miranda has been slapped on the wrist enough times by human resources to curb her abuses. Now, rather than flinging her coat at some trembling lackey, she has to hang it up herself, and

you see her wince from the strain—a sign of age, perhaps, but also of humiliation. Even journalistically, she’s unusually off her game. Her opening scene involves a rare editorial lapse that tables her dream of a promotion to the top ranks of *Runway*’s parent company, Elias-Clarke. The magazine, too, is a shadow of its former self, and the horrors of corporate consolidation and downsizing loom. How bad can it get? In this movie, even Miranda Priestly flies coach.

The first “[Devil Wears Prada](#),” released to major success in the summer of 2006, was adapted from Lauren Weisberger’s best-selling [2003 novel](#), which drew on her experience as an assistant to [Anna Wintour](#), then the editor-in-chief of *Vogue*. Weisberger’s book may have been an opportunistic takedown, but the director David Frankel and the screenwriter Aline Brosh McKenna spun it into one of the finer Hollywood entertainments of its era, with the pleasing sophistication and bitchery of a classic studio comedy from the forties or fifties. (Call it “All About Yves Saint Laurent.”) Miranda, a shrieking one-note villain on the page, was reborn, in Streep’s performance, as the most exquisite of holy terrors: a silver-haired, dulcet-toned fascist of the fashion world, as thoroughly impossible as she was ultimately irresistible. Streep’s second go-round, by contrast, unfolds as a series of micro-indignities—a plunge from her Olympian perch, one stumble at a time.

Rest assured that “The Devil Wears Prada 2” is, no less than its predecessor, a glossy Manhattan fairy tale, and one so overstuffed with top-of-the-line fabrics that cushy landings are all but certain. The sequel is also a first-class reunion tour, with at least three ludicrously extravagant stops—a villa in Vermont, a retreat in the Hamptons, an overextended Milan Fashion Week—and all the principal players faithfully reporting for duty, Frankel and McKenna included. Stanley Tucci is back as Nigel, Miranda’s unfailingly loyal consigliere, who never butchers a bon mot or wears the same pocket square twice. Emily Blunt, whom the first “Prada” made a star, returns as Miranda’s chippy-chic former assistant Emily Charlton; she now oversees luxury retail at Dior, a position that allows her to exact the odd measure of revenge on her old boss.

The story’s most significant character, save Miranda herself, is Andy Sachs ([Anne Hathaway](#)), who once toiled alongside Emily in the assistant trenches

and finally surpassed her. Andy was the magazine's resident ugly duckling turned overachieving swan, though she ultimately abandoned the nest for a lowlier, ostensibly more serious career as an investigative reporter. Getting Andy back into the *Runway* fold is the first of the sequel's many contrivances, but one with a queasy note of plausibility: early on, she and many of her newspaper colleagues are unceremoniously sacked via text message, a culling that might bring to mind, among other journalistic bloodbaths, the recent gutting of the [Washington Post](#). With suspiciously fortuitous timing, Andy is snapped up as *Runway*'s new features editor—a move that Irv Ravitz (Tibor Feldman), the Si Newhouse-esque head of Elias-Clarke, hopes will salvage what remains of the publication's credibility in the wake of Miranda's bungle.

Miranda, for her part, scarcely remembers Andy, vehemently opposes her hiring, and waits, with sadistic patience, for her to fail. The two women are thus locked into the same power dynamic as before, and although Andy has the benefit of more clout and experience—plus the support of *Runway*'s next generation of assistants, deftly played by Helen J. Shen, Simone Ashley, and Caleb Hearon—she will once again have to earn Miranda's grudging respect. The script has a shrewd manner, more endearing than exasperating, of repackaging the same elements under heightened circumstances, and Frankel and McKenna have largely mastered the art of the callback: shower steam being wiped off a bathroom mirror, a Madonna-scored dress-up montage. The best allusions are purely visual, and they remind us of the original film's pop-cultural hold; at one point, we glimpse a familiar-looking turquoise belt that, in keeping with Miranda's past prophecy, has trickled down from the most exclusive of ateliers to an open-air market. To some extent, the cool commercial logic of the fashion industry—which transforms beautiful, original works into cheaply reproducible goods, season after season—echoes that of Hollywood, which regularly cannibalizes and, yes, franchises its greatest successes. It's a grind, but not always or entirely a soulless one, and we take its sturdy mechanics for granted at our peril. The very existence of art and beauty can be enough to make the relentless churn seem worth it.

What if even those fleeting pleasures were to vanish for good? The possibility is not exactly nil. McKenna, working this time without the safety net of direct source material, has composed a shiny soap-bubble satire of a

doom-laden cultural and journalistic landscape. As bubbles go, this one is easy to burst, but what it reflects back at us isn't too far removed from the truth. For one thing, the film, an incestuous weave of fiction and reality, is stuffed with wall-to-wall cameos, including Lady Gaga, Donatella Versace, and an effervescent cloud of New York media *élites*. Yet despite such surface-level glamour, and no small amount of Prada placement, the movie continually undercuts its own self-intoxication. It laments a world in which *Runway's* sky-high budgets, standards, and aspirations are unsustainable, the most lavish shoots and stories elicit little more than a scroll and a yawn, and Miranda's ironclad judgments sometimes go unheeded. Instead, two corporate raiders, a mercenary media-dynasty scion (B. J. Novak) and a vacuous tech bro (Justin Theroux), will determine the future of *Runway*, an institution they'll never understand, support, or deserve.

The stakes, in other words, have never been higher, and if the writing can turn leaden with high-mindedness—no less a Renaissance masterpiece than “The Last Supper” is enlisted in service of bolstering *Runway's* artistic bona fides—the new film does, in certain respects, prove savvier than its predecessor. In the first “Prada,” Andy was forced to choose between hard news and haute couture, a false moral-professional binary that, in the sequel, has been upended by the sheer desperation of the new media world order. Before, Andy had only to hold on to her ideals; now she has to save a crumbling media empire almost single-handedly. A less agile heroine might have buckled under the weight of the enterprise. But Hathaway once again shoulders Andy's mix of steeliness and flightiness with consummate grace, and her shifting perspective reshapes our own prejudices—it's through her eyes that we come to believe that even the gargantuan excesses of *Runway* are worth defending against the encroaching tyranny of know-nothing billionaire vulgarians. “You're much more confident,” Emily tells her, in a brief moment of sincerity, and much of the fun here lies in watching Andy tap into that self-belief. No longer one to wither under her boss's scornful gaze, she becomes, for Miranda—and for her affectionate old mentor, Nigel—an ever more formidable ally.

“The Devil Wears Prada” was a fairy tale with many frogs and nary a single viable Prince Charming. The sequel, sizing up its protagonists and the direness of their professional circumstances, grants them some romantic redemption. Andy gets a decent if colorless new love interest (Patrick

Brammall), who works as a real-estate contractor, and even Miranda has found stability and happiness with the latest of her many husbands (Kenneth Branagh). You have to wonder if domestic bliss hasn't played its role in her defanging, though she resists any real temptation to settle down. "Boy, I love working," she coos at one point, and in Streep's sudden smile—as warm and genuine as Miranda is typically contemptuous and frosty—you see two creative geniuses, actor and character, merged into one. "The Devil Wears Prada 2" is selling a truckload of preposterous goods, but it sells them awfully well, with unfeigned assurance, conviction, and the appropriate ratio of cynicism to hope. As industries and their titans are brought low, this film suggests, the best we can ask for is the satisfaction of doing good work and the lasting friendships we may forge along the way. That's all. ♦

Poems

- [While My Daughter Is in Surgery I Think About a Night in a Hotel in Florence](#)
- [1970](#)

Poems

While My Daughter Is in Surgery I Think About a Night in a Hotel in Florence

By Ellen Bass

May 04, 2026



She'd bought a black leather jacket from a stall on the Ponte Vecchio.
The yellow light of the stones gleamed on the river
as she slipped her pale arms into the sleeves, wrapping herself in the animal
skin.

We lingered over linguine Alfredo and stopped off for a last gelato,
walking the long way back, only to find our bags
packed and stored behind the hotel desk.

With my blundering Italian, it seemed I'd booked our room for only one
night.

They were terribly sorry but it was a holiday, a delirium of people crowding
the city,

and though they called other hotels, there was no room at any inn.

When we asked if we could sleep in the lobby, they hesitated
and then they said they had—it wasn't really a room—but there was a bed.
And they led us along a labyrinth of hallways up and down a maze of stairs

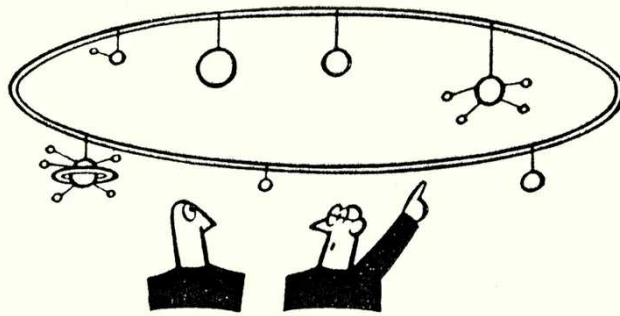
a route so elaborate we wondered how we'd ever find our way back—
to four walls that rose up within other walls deep in the heart
of the heart of the building. A tiny chamber
with no windows, no space even to open our bags.
But the bed—so strangely ordinary—was made with clean sheets
and a thin coverlet as if it had been waiting there—
maybe for centuries—for us to arrive.
The darkness was absolute—not a glint of light
from outside, no street lamps or headlights,
no stars or moon to push time forward.
No sound of voices, horns, tires. Not a dog barking
or a feral cat knocking the lid off the garbage.
Not a leaf rustling toward autumn. Or a mosquito whispering.
Not the suicidal wings of a moth against flame.
There was no flame. Nor any pebble
clattering down the medieval stones, plinking into the tea-colored water.
What are the names of the nights when you regret nothing?
When the sorrows that came before and the sorrows
that would come after part
like a stream parts when it bends around a rock.
There's nothing I left behind of that night.
Not the smell of the leather that enveloped her,
not the ochre reflections of the buildings, their narrow balconies
rippling in the water, not the darkness that held us becalmed
as though the universe granted us one night of reprieve
from its endless cycles of birth and death.
We were young. Even I was young. And we laughed
at our good luck and slept.

Poems

1970

By Brenda Hillman

May 04, 2026



Shadows advance at the edge of L.A., eucalyptuses peeling
like Band-Aids in the smog.

You read Suzuki, Baudelaire, & M. L. Rosenthal in a library carrell
the color of butterscotch.

The more you read, the less bad you feel; this solution will last
your whole life. . . .

Lopsided smoke rings from a hitchhiker's mouth, Joni Mitchell
on the turntable, Yusef Lateef.

Friend with pink eyebrows reading, friend in a pinafore singing.

Your hair is a yard long. Blue work shirt. Ripped jeans.

A poet visits in a cloak & writes “Open Field” on the board.

Star ribbons loop across the sun. Incense & suffering, beauty
of suffering. The Saturday boy issues fierce remarks,
you are both in love with Keats dying.

The war the war. The marches
change nothing. You lie

on a mattress with others, springs poking through.
Some are gay but don’t say.

Large amounts of pot. Marlboros crushed into linoleum.

One candle is lit with another, moths are invited in. This year

a case of Coors, next year “A Case of You.” Mourning
for America won’t end.

Now the past flies by like an owl with a vole in its beak,

fire takes the hills where fire took your heart & desire
stunned you.

This is drawn from “[Still House in the Desert.](#)”

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Tuesday, April 28, 2026](#)

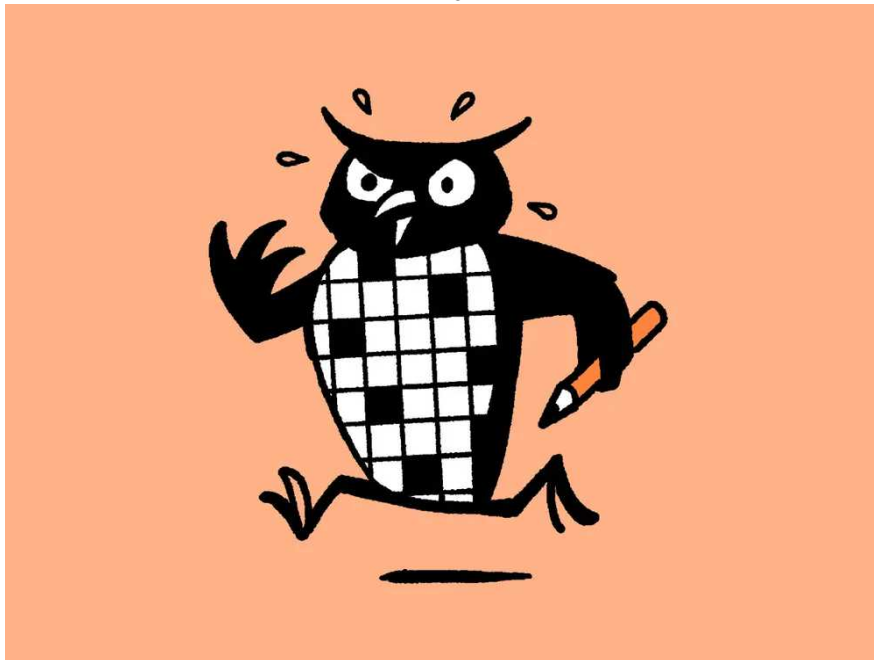
Crossword

The Crossword: Tuesday, April 28, 2026

Today's theme: Homegrown.

By Adam Wagner

April 28, 2026



The Mail

- [Letters from Our Readers](#)

Letters from Our Readers

Readers respond to Sarah Stillman's piece about the detention of migrant children, Patrick Radden Keefe's investigation into car-insurance fraud in New Orleans, and Ronan Farrow and Andrew Marantz's profile of Sam Altman.

May 04, 2026

American Deprivation

Sarah Stillman, in her excellent article on the U.S. government's detention of migrant children, does what many media outlets find impossible: she stays with an ongoing horror even as the news cycles that placed it front and center have passed ("No Mercy," April 20th). Stillman's piece also reminded me that the United States is the only U.N. member state that refuses to ratify the organization's Convention on the Rights of the Child, which enshrines children with certain rights—including to stay with their families whenever possible and to due process. America's refusal dates back to the nineteen-nineties; considering this, the current Administration's actions can be seen only as a shameful continuation of our country's failure to respect human rights, even on its own soil.

Lindsey Price Jackson
New York City

Stillman's piece details widespread medical neglect at the Dilley Immigration Processing Center, in Dilley, Texas, and points out that one source for its population's medical problems is the town's water. However, she doesn't spell out exactly why the water is dangerous. I am an immigration attorney, and I visited the Dilley detention center in 2016 to offer legal support for detained families. During my trip, I stayed at a local hotel, where the staff told me not to drink the tap water. They also explained that Dilley's two main sources of income were the detention center and oil extraction—and that it was well known that the latter was responsible for the

state of Dilley's water. As many authorities, including the E.P.A., have documented, fracking generates huge amounts of wastewater, which can easily contaminate drinking-water wells. Drinking that water can cause both acute illness (like the abdominal pain that Stillman describes) and chronic illness. It's hard to imagine that *ICE* and the Dilley detention center's operator don't know this.

Amy Adams
Portland, Ore.

Scheming

Patrick Radden Keefe's portrait of a truck-slamming scheme in New Orleans shows his gift for finding the Shakespearean in the sordid ("Slammers," April 20th). It also called to mind an earlier scheme. In the nineteen-nineties, California freeways—especially in Los Angeles—had become the proving ground for what insurance investigators then called the swoop and squat, in which a driver would swoop in front of a commercial truck and slam on his brakes, engineering a rear-end collision and the insurance claim that followed. By 1990, the California Highway Patrol was already reporting a surge in staged incidents; by June, 1992, investigators were tracking roughly three hundred and fifty suspected crashes. Organized rings were recruiting drivers for the "swoop" cars, and the scheme grew sophisticated enough to prompt Assembly Bill 1050, in 1999, after a wave of dangerous—and sometimes fatal—incidents on Route 710.

That story suggests that slamming is less an anomaly of the Big Easy than the latest flowering of a particularly American tradition—one that began, as so many things do, on a California freeway.

Rebecca Sherman
Weatherford, Texas

As viewed by this lawyer in Missouri, what Keefe (no relation) describes is nauseating. There are bad actors in every profession, but illegal and unethical conduct by a lawyer is especially harmful. Our justice system depends on public confidence, and, as a result, the rules governing lawyers in every state are strict. A lawyer doesn't have to break the law to lose his

license—just ask Bill Clinton, Rudy Giuliani, or F. Lee Bailey. When lawyers misbehave, people stop believing in the court system and in equal justice. Widespread cynicism helps authoritarianism thrive.

There are almost 1.4 million attorneys in the U.S. The vast majority are honorable and conform their actions to the rules. Those who don't conform deserve punishment to show the public that unethical behavior is not tolerated.

Bob Keefe
St. Louis, Mo.

How to Influence People

I read Ronan Farrow and Andrew Marantz's profile of Sam Altman with great interest ("Moment of Truth," April 13th). The authors write that Altman has always been able "to convince disparate groups that what he wants and what they need are one and the same." That line stood out to me because I saw this exact dynamic play out last year, in Altman's appearance on "The Tucker Carlson Show." At one point during the interview, Carlson asks Altman about a legal case in which OpenAI is being sued because ChatGPT appeared to have facilitated a suicide. (Altman and Carlson don't provide further details, but there are several such cases ongoing. In one, relating to the death of a sixteen-year-old named Adam Raine, court documents indicate that Raine wrote, "I want to leave my noose in my room so someone finds it and tries to stop me," and that ChatGPT responded, "Please don't leave the noose out. . . . Let's make this the first place where someone actually sees you.") About ten minutes later, Altman steers the conversation toward his hope to pass "A.I. privilege" legislation that would create legal protections around conversations with A.I. He frames it as a privacy safeguard that will be beneficial to society. But, of course, this would make it much more difficult for regulators, lawyers, and journalists, like Carlson, to access chat logs in investigations and lawsuits. Nevertheless, Carlson's follow-up questions suggest he has bought Altman's account that keeping these conversations in OpenAI's hands is a good idea.

Tracy Meier
Newport Beach, Calif.

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Letters should be sent with the writer's name, address, and daytime phone number via e-mail to themail@newyorker.com. Letters may be edited for length and clarity, and may be published in any medium. We regret that owing to the volume of correspondence we cannot reply to every letter.

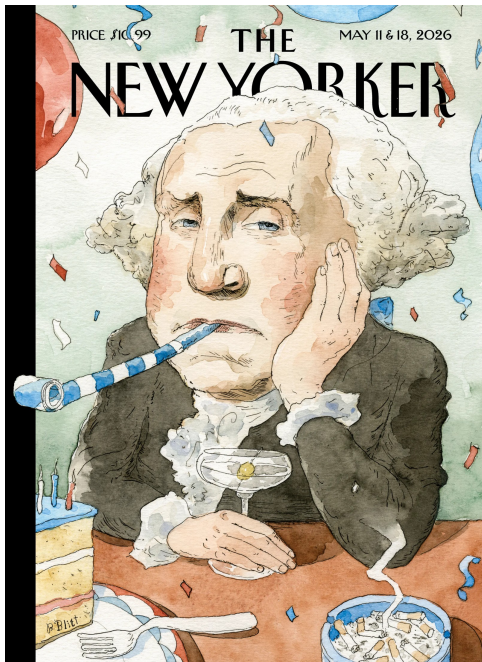


Table of Contents

Goings On

[“Heated Rivalry” and Its Wine-Mom Fans Reunite](#)
[Rachel Syme Gets Suited Up](#)

The Talk of the Town

[Two Hundred and Fifty Years of Complicated Commemorations](#)
[Colbert’s Trumpet Player on Life After Late Night](#)
[Is the Twenty-fifth Amendment Really an Option?](#)
[On the High Line, Buddha Is the New Giant Pigeon](#)
[In HBO’s “The Dark Wizard,” Dean Potter Climbs On](#)

Reporting & Essays

[Was the Declaration of Independence Better Before the Edits?](#)
[How Americans Caught Gold Fever Again](#)
[Barack Obama Considers His Role in the Age of Trump](#)
[The Life and Times of an American Tween](#)
[Comeback Kids](#)

Shouts & Murmurs

[Senior-Discount Disneyland](#)

Fiction

[Mapping Trump’s America](#)
[Standings](#)

The Critics

[The American Revolution Wasn’t the Main Event](#)
[The Idea That Reshaped Identity Politics Has a Complicated Backstory.](#)
[Briefly Noted](#)
[The Artist Who Made America Look Like a Promised Land](#)
[Harriet Clark’s Début Is a New Kind of Coming-of-Age Novel](#)
[“Schmigadoon!” and “The Lost Boys” Are Killer Revamps](#)
[“The Devil Wears Prada 2” Gives the Decline of Magazines the Glossy Treatment](#)

Poems

[While My Daughter Is in Surgery I Think About a Night in a Hotel in Florence](#)
[1970](#)

Puzzles & Games

[The Crossword: Tuesday, April 28, 2026](#)

The Mail

[Letters from Our Readers](#)